

Psyc 240 The Psychology of Self

Numbered Transcript

PSYC 240 • Dr. Keith Campbell

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Lecture 1: Perspectives on the Self

At a glance — Perspectives on the self.

- 1.1 What I'm here today to talk about is the psychology of the self. This is the study of the self from a psychological perspective. There's lots of interest in the self. There's the literature of the self, there's the philosophy of the self, the theology of the self. This is going to be more of the psychology. But I'm going to talk about a lot of those other aspects just on occasions. But I'm a psychologist, so that's kind of what I'm doing.
- 1.2 The first thing to do is, when you talk about the self is, say, "What is the self?" It's a big term. When we think about the self, you trace back the etymology of it. Where does it come from? It's an old Indo-European root. It means one's own. Self means something that connects to you. What connects to you? Well, it's your personality traits, it's your values, it's your ideas. It's the clothes you wear. I came here, I'm like, this is a good-looking group. I'm in Miami. This is yourself, this is material self.
- 1.3 It's your relationships. It's how you control and regulate yourself. It's willpower. It includes some mystical experience. It includes your hands and feet; your physical body is yourself. There's lots and lots of your self-worth, your self-esteem. There's lots and lots that go into the self, this big bucket of things we call the self.
- 1.4 The other thing that makes it really interesting are all those things that you can think about are like your self concept, what William James, the great psychologist, called the "me." The me are all these things like my attitudes, my clothes, my friendship networks. They're all the me. But what's really cool about the self is that we have a perception of our self. We have self-awareness, we have consciousness that's reflective. So this is where the self becomes mysterious.
- 1.5 So, not only am I a person with an identity and outfits and beliefs about myself, but I have the ability to perceive myself. I'm watching myself right now talking to you, watching myself watching myself talk to you. So you get this really intense reflective self-consciousness. That's an interesting thing. So, when you study the self, you're studying this really interesting dance between how we perceive ourselves, our own self-perception, how we evaluate ourselves, and who we actually are. It's interesting.
- 1.6 It's more interesting than most other topics because we're not robots. If we were robots, you'd just break us down and study us, but we're self-aware robots. I don't even like to call us robots. We're just self-aware, so it's interesting. That's what I'm—that's sort of my focus. There's a few things to think about when you think about the modern human self that are important to bring up at first. A lot of these things I'm going to talk about a lot throughout the course. What I want to do in this first lecture is kind of do some of the historical stuff and the big-picture history about how we think about the self.

- 1.7 But in terms of the modern human self, there's some things to think about. First off, our self is symbolic, and it's really symbolic. It's a cultural process. Most, I shouldn't, I'll say, lots of animals have culture. Other nonhuman primates have culture. You visit a troop of baboons, they'll have their own culture. You visit a troop of, or a pod of orca whales, they'll have a culture. They work together. They learn how to hunt together. They transfer this culture onto their young. So lots of different animals have culture.
- 1.8 What we have is symbolic culture. We have identity that's symbolic, that we can project on to people. I look around here; everything you're wearing is a symbol of something. The way you comb your hair style is a symbol of something. Your glasses are a symbol of something. Everything we do has some connection with broader—not everything, but most things we do have a connection with this broader symbolic culture. Our self is a very complicated thing.
- 1.9 My dog self, I love Murphy and Killarney, my doodles. They don't have an elaborate symbolic self. They kind of know their name. They like snacks. That's it. And they're pretty happy. They don't suffer for no reason. They suffer when they suffer, and then when they're not suffering, they're happy. They don't lie and take naps and go, "Should I be better than I am? Should I be more than a dog?" They just take a freaking nap. So that's the complex nature of the self.
- 1.10 The other point, which I start off saying is, we're self-aware. We have this intense self-awareness, and it's reflective. We have reflective self-awareness, and we tell a bit of a story about ourselves. I'll talk about this a lot. This is the narrative of the self. My dog Murphy doesn't really have a story about Murphy. "Who is Murphy? I don't know. I'm just here." I have a story about my self, and I'm telling my self a story, and that story influences my self. If I tell my self a good story, it's going to change me. If I tell myself a bad story, it's going to change me. This reflective part and this storytelling part is really important. It separates this from other creatures.
- 1.11 The human self is planful. It's agentic. It does what it wants to do. We have goals, we have motivations, we have people we want to become, we have dreams, we have visions. The way our self is built is, I can plan who I want to be in 10 years. I can have an image of that person. I have a pretty good image. He's on a beach somewhere, on a gulf. He's casting a fly rod at the tarpon, never going to catch one because that's not God's plan for him, but he's going to try. That's my self in 10 years. I can visualize that self. We can create who we are in a really interesting way that most creatures can't do, this potential for self-creation and planfulness.
- 1.12 Finally, I think what's really interesting about the human self is that it's a problem. It's a source of suffering. You see this throughout the discussion of the self and all the different literatures around the world. One of the great self researchers, Mark Leary, who's now retired from Duke, but he said, "Deep down inside, we all know we're our own worst self enemy." Is that how I say it? "Our worst self enemy." There's an idea that there's some suffering that comes from the self, and that's partly because of our

self-knowledge and the fact that we never live up to what we want to be and we never attain what we want.

- 1.13** There's lots of different ways of thinking about this. I'll talk about some of the Buddhist literature because that's the core of a lot of it. The self is a really interesting and elaborate phenomenon, and the human self, the modern human self, is really big and complicated and symbolic and messy, and we can do a lot with it. It's a cool topic. What is a self versus some other things? Often you're like, what's the self versus personality, say? When we talk about personality, and I'll talk about a little bit of personality in here because it's important, personality, we're typically talking about individual differences in traits, things like trait of extroversion or energy or compassion or something, but they're about individual differences.
- 1.14** You're more extroverted, you're less extroverted; you're more compassionate, you're less compassionate. So, personality is a little more about our trait descriptions, but our personality is part of our self. We're aware of who we are. We have an idea of who we are. We take personality tests. We're like, "I'm an extroverted, sensing, intuitive whatever." So we learn about ourselves versus personality. They're related, but they're a little bit separable.
- 1.15** Another term that gets used a lot with the self is identity. Identity refers to our self in terms of social and cultural roles. So my social identity might be, "I'm a professor." That's my identity. So it's an important part of myself that's cultural. But I like ice cream. I really don't. But if I did really like ice cream, that could be part of my identity, too. But you wouldn't really say that's identity unless you're like, "Yeah, I'm the ice cream guy." You'd just say it's an attitude. "I like ice cream." I'm sorry, there's probably an ice cream guy in the audience right now that's all bummed.
- 1.16** So, identity is a little more cultural. The term ego is used sometimes as a substitute for the self. The term ego, the history of the term ego, it came from Freud's use of the word self. Then I think Ernst Jones turned it into ego to make it sound more, the Latin word for "I", to make it sound more fancy or more scientific. The ego and the self are sometimes interchangeable, and I hate to make this all confusing, but people use the same words over and over. Sometimes they're interchangeable, but sometimes when you talk about the ego, you can talk about things like the superego.
- 1.17** Like, if you're ever driving around Florida and you see those van lines, the Superego Trucking Company. I see them all the time driving around Florida; it always cracks me up, some secret Freudian at a trucking company. But so, Freud talked about a superego, and you could say, well, maybe that's part of your self as well. But generally, ego and self are substitutable terms. Self might be a little bigger. And then finally, there's this concept of the soul that's really interesting, that's been around, well, as long as we've been around thinking about these things.

- 1.18** And the soul, well, I'll tell you about a little more detail, but generally the soul is thought of as a whole aspect of the self that's somehow connected with the divine or trans—it sort of survives death or something. The soul is something that's talked about, but for reasons I'll get to, we don't really study it scientifically because it's really hard. Again, I'll talk about this in a second. But the soul is supposed to be a little more the spiritual aspect of the self that psychologists, some think exists and probably most think doesn't exist, but we don't really study it.
- 1.19** Before I get—I want to talk about some of the history and these bigger issues, bigger philosophical issues of the self, I wanted to talk for a moment about why I'm talking to you because what's my background to talk about this? So I started out in clinical psych and then ended up doing it, but I'm not a clinician, and I'm not giving any clinical advice, to be really clear, or financial advice or any other advice. I don't give any advice. I started out, I went in clinical and I was reading about the self, and I wanted to study the self. And so I went into social psychology. It was a long story.
- 1.20** I literally had an interview at a position in Wisconsin. I read a social psych textbook on the way, interviewed, and I got along with people and I got a job. I mean, I got a position in grad school. So I studied with a guy named Constantine Sedikides, who's in the UK now. I studied the self, especially processes of self-enhancement, which we'll get to, but essentially how we make ourselves feel good. I was interested in that. Then I did a post-doc. After you do your PhD, you can do a post-doc for a couple of years. I worked with a psychologist named Roy Baumeister, who's brilliant, just a whole notch above me. He's the guy you want to talk to.
- 1.21** My job was, for a couple of years, for him, just talking like one night a week. We'd just stay up till 2:00 in the morning talking about big ideas. That was my training. It was great. It was old days. You can't do that anymore. Now you've got to write grants. I ended up, most of my career, studying the self, focusing on narcissism, which is the individual difference of the enhanced or inflated self. I was interested in, let's study self-enhancement, and I did a whole course on that, so I won't talk about that a lot. But that's my, most of my background has been studying self-enhancement processes and studying narcissism.
- 1.22** Because I had a bit of an odd childhood in southern Cali, I had a very interesting childhood. I went through full couch psychoanalysis when I was a teenager. I've gone through psychoanalysis, and so I have a little bit of background in that, but I'm not trained in it, so I'm not going to talk about a lot of psychoanalytic ideas.
- 1.23** So the history of the self—if you start talking to people who study the self, if I walked into a psych department in 1980, 1990, and started talking to random people, probably today, if I started talking to random people, people interested in the self are almost always interested in Buddhist and Vedic writing or philosophy or practice. You go in anyone's room and there's a copy of the Siddhartha, there's the Upanishads, there'll be the Gita. This is just the nature of it. But this isn't just modern academics.

- 1.24** You go back in time and you're like, Schopenhauer, the philosopher, who was really one of the first to talk about the self, his ideas came out of Hinduism, came out of the Vedic literature. William James was hanging out with Emerson and Thoreau, and Thoreau at Walden Pond was reading the Hindu literature. I think that's exactly what it says at the beginning of Walden Pond, except they spell Hindu with two Os. Freud was influenced by Buddhists. He talked about the nirvana principle. He didn't like it, but he talked about the nirvana principle.
- 1.25** Nietzsche was influenced by a lot of this stuff. David Hume, the great associationist philosopher in Scotland, was apparently, had some influence of Buddhism via the Catholic Church. There's been this influence in psychology going back 200, 250 years. It's really interesting to think about some of these issues when we talk about the self, and I just wanted to give you a few highlights that you see in the literature, and I'm going to try with the Zen koan at the end and see if that works and probably fail.
- 1.26** But if you read the Gita, which is a wonderful book, and there's a story of Arjuna, and he meets Krishna, and Lord Krishna reveals himself; and he reveals himself, and it's sort of like, I think of the Jimi Hendrix Axis: Bold as Love album, when he reveals himself. And he says to Krishna, "Of the sciences, I am the science of the self." He's saying, "Even in this world, the highest science is, the highest science is the understanding or knowledge of the self." This is an old idea.
- 1.27** If you read the Yoga Sutra, I don't know if there are any yogis here, you go read the Yoga Sutra by Patanjali, the sutras are literature. The word "sutra" comes like the same as the word suture. They're like threads. They're like little threads of ideas that people write historically and then people expound upon. But the Yoga Sutra, the first two lines are—the first sutra is, "The exposition of yoga is now being made," or the exposition of yoga starts now. That's it. Number one is, it starts now.
- 1.28** The second is, "The restraint of the modifications of the mind stuff is yoga." What? I've been practicing yoga for like 15 years. Well, the first two lessons from the Yoga Sutra are "the exposition of yoga starts now." What does that mean? It means, it's about being present; it's about present awareness, because present awareness is where you see consciousness. When I'm just aware right now in the present, all I have is consciousness. I'm not dumping values on it. I'm not dumping identity on it. I'm not thinking about how I screwed up with my kids last week. God, how I think about that all the time. I'm just present. Something about just being present is really powerful in that yoga tradition.
- 1.29** The second thing is "the restraint of the modifications of the mind stuff." What the heck does that mean? It's what I'm talking about. Instead of just being present talking to you guys, I'm thinking about how I screwed up with my kids. I'm thinking about, did I leave the stove on? I don't really think that, but what if I did? Now I start thinking about it, or I worry about my dogs or whatever it is. So this idea of restraining all that excess

thought and just being present, of just being conscious and minimizing consciousness to direct experience. Does that make sense a little bit?

- 1.30** That's the idea of yoga. That's it. It's just reduce the modification to the mindset. Really? Why is that so hard? Well, that's what we'll learn in this course. It's really freaking hard to do that because our self is a mess. The other thing is really interesting in a lot of the Buddhist systems, they talk about how the self is created. So in modern Western biological-based medical psychiatry and psychology, we think that the self emerges. There's a bunch of chemicals in our brain. They start to interact in a computational way, and they do it so much that a self pops out of there.
- 1.31** It's an emergent process. It doesn't exist, it just emerges. Consciousness emerges from the action of these neurons going really quickly in a computational way. In the Buddhist model, consciousness exists independently. When you make a self, it's the coming together of these different pieces. You have a piece that's consciousness, you have a piece that's the ability to detect name and form, to name things. You have a piece that's maybe motivation, maybe craving or wishes and desires. You have a physical self, and you bring those things together, and it feels like a self.
- 1.32** But it feels like a self because it's all working together. Our consciousness is working with our desires, is working with what we get in life. And that thing together feels like a self. But when you wind it back down, you're like, oh, there's not really a substantial self there. There's consciousness, there's awareness, there's other stuff, but the self itself isn't so powerful. I knew I was going to hit you with the hard stuff. I just am starting hard. It gets easier.
- 1.33** So this idea that comes out of some of these traditions is that the self is something created, but that consciousness is maybe something that exists the whole time. And what you see in the core message of a lot of the Buddhist literature and a lot of the Vedic literature is that the self is a problem. The self is the cause of suffering. We suffer because we have a self. Now, how does that work? Why does the self make us suffer? Why is the thing that makes us human the thing that makes us suffer?
- 1.34** There's some great models of this. One of my favorites in the Tibetan school is they have this wonderful map of the human condition. In the center of this, there's a pig and a snake and a rooster chasing each other, right after. It's greed, hatred, and ignorance. I'm dumb and I want stuff and I don't want this other stuff. Those three things spin around, and then that creates the different worlds of existence, the God realm, the human realm, the animal realm, the realm of hungry ghosts where people are trying to drink, but they can never get water down their throat because it doesn't work. Then outside that, you create the world of karma, the world of action and reaction causation.
- 1.35** So, what they're arguing in some of these models is this sense, this connection or attachment to ourselves that we have, that our self is a real thing and we want to fill it up with stuff and we want to get away from those bad things. That process that we

learn over and over in our life is a source of our suffering, because that's why our self is created to start with. And so a lot of the Buddhist practice is about how to snap out of that. How do you go, "Oh, my self is a creative thing. How do I snap out of that for a second and just experience consciousness? How do I just experience the world without the mind stuff modified?"

- 1.36** So that's a lot of the training. How do you do it? Millions of examples. I knew I was going to try some Zen koans. In the Zen tradition, one of the practices they use for people, it's more of an intellectual exercise. It's a practice of a koan. They'll give you a riddle, and just go think about it for a while. One of the most famous of these is, "What's the sound of one hand clapping?" Have you heard this? What's the sound of one hand clapping? You think about that. That doesn't make any sense. "If a tree falls in the forest and no one's there to hear it, does it make any noise?" What the heck? What are they talking about? That's dumb. What are they talking about?
- 1.37** They're talking about nondual consciousness. They're saying, "Yeah, it's just the hand. There's no duality. You're just the hand." The tree falls in the forest, there's nobody there. There's just a tree. They're talking about briefly moving away from this tightly connected self and just being liberated, or a sense of satori, just for a second. It's an example of this. I'm going to tell you one final one, and then I'll go on to something else. But I do love these ideas, and like I said, they're core to a lot of the self work.
- 1.38** This is a koan called Gutei's Finger. This is a story of a Zen teacher, his name Gutei. I hope I'm pronouncing that correctly. I never met him. He had his famous way of teaching Zen, was he called one-finger Zen. It's all these people, "What's the self? Why am I suffering? Why? Why?" He'd just do this. This was his thing. What about this? People go, "Dude, that guy's got it all figured out." He's a legend, and then he's got a student. Like, this is how it works. I had Roy, I had Constantine. He's got his young student, and his student goes, "Oh, this is what my master does."
- 1.39** The student goes out there, and people ask the student, "Well, why am I suffering? What's the nature of life?" The student starts doing this, too, like his master. So student's not lying, he's doing it. So one day, the student's out doing his thing, trying to be cool. Master walks over, grabs him, and just chops his finger off. I love the Zen stories because they're hardcore. The guy's looking at his finger and he looks at the master, and he looks, he has no finger, he looks at the master, and the master just goes like this. Boom, he's enlightened. That's, he has satori. He goes, "I get it now." The kid gets it. He's like, "I'm not pretending anymore. I'm not pretending to be a master. I'm alive."
- 1.40** I hope that made some sense. That's a koan. I love that story. They kill a lot of people in Zen. They cut a lot of fingers and cats, see, a cat's cut in half and stuff. They do a lot of cutting. So the idea, anyway, from this Buddhist and Vedic perspective, which I just ran through about 3,000 years of literature—it couldn't be 3,000, yeah, it could be—in about two minutes and confused you, but the idea there is that there's something

foundational about consciousness, that the self becomes a problem. We get captured by our own self, and we start to believe our own story is the truth, and we start to believe that we're not actors in a movie, but we're actually in reality.

- 1.41 And there's practices to dial that back. So something like yoga or yoking yourself to something higher than yourself is a practice, Buddhist practices, Zen practices, different things like that. In the Buddhist tradition, the self is the problem. The other tradition, another tradition—there's a few—that's had a huge influence on our Western view of the self, our modern view of the self, is the ancient Greeks. I think the Greeks influenced everything. But the Greek focus on the self was a little different.
- 1.42 If you look at Patanjali or somebody who's like, "We just got to dial this self down," you look at Socrates, and he's trying to find himself. He's trying to know himself. The famous center of the world in ancient Greek was Delphi, where the oracle was. And the statement above the oracle of Delphi was "know thyself." But it was in Greek, and I don't know how to say that. But essentially it was "self-knowledge is crucial to how you develop as a person."
- 1.43 When Socrates was going through the trial of Socrates, when they were trying him for being a bad influence, he was considered to be an atheist and not believe in the gods and corrupting the kids—you can read the trial. It's like, he should have won that thing. So Socrates, on his trial, basically says, "The development of my soul is more important than my life." He says, "God orders me to fulfill the philosopher's mission of searching into myself and other men. If I disobeyed the Oracle because I was afraid of death, then I should be fancying that I was wise when I was not wise."
- 1.44 Whoa. I'm willing to die for self-knowledge because that's more important. Then he goes on to say, "For I do nothing but go about persuading you all, old and young alike, not to take thought of your persons and your properties, but first and chiefly to care about the greatest improvement of the soul." So Socrates, in his tradition, was saying self-knowledge is sort of the foundational part of self-development. If you know yourself, then you can build a stable base of who you are, and then you can relate to the world effectively.
- 1.45 Without that self, and it's probably more because you're transforming in the world of forms, but not knowing yourself, you're just a serf, you're not doing anything. Again, it's a very different, it's a very different tradition. How do you do this? There's some interesting stuff in here. One thing that you read about a lot in the Greeks is they talk about the daemon, which is almost like an inner voice or an inner—I mean, the same kind of word as demon, though we, in Christianity, demons are usually bad, and this is daemon, so maybe it's OK. It's almost like the voice of your true self or the voice of nature, the voice of a calling.
- 1.46 I think when Socrates was being tried, a voice told him to learn to play the lyre or learned him to do poetry or something. There's some things about finding your soul,

about reaching in and finding your true self. This theme of the true self or self-actualization or something is something we'll talk about a lot in this course. Another thing that comes out of the Greeks was, it was a lot about balance. When you're finding yourself, it's like, well, if you go too far into the passionate side of yourself, you get lost. But if you go too far into reason, you get lost, and you try to balance passion and reason. The term is the golden mean, kind of an average sense.

1.47 So this is something Buddha said as well. Buddha said, "If the bow is too tight, it's going to snap, and if it's too loose, you can't shoot an arrow." So you want to be in a state of tension at all times. I mean, not too much tension because then you're intense, but you need to be in a state of tension. That's the nature of the self. So they were talking about finding balance in yourself between passion and reason and that being important, not just doing one thing. The final piece with the Greeks that are really interesting, and this comes up a lot, is work of Plotinus, or Plotinus. Again, I didn't study Greek. I studied Latin and even forgot that, so I apologize.

1.48 But he is a neo-Platonist. He's somebody who came after Plato and talked about the self in a really interesting way that had a lot of influence on the Christian work. But he talked about the self as a dynamic existential phenomenology, which is a big bunch of words. Basically, he's saying, it's like you have an experience, and that experience is always changing and moving like a dance. So it's dynamic, it's existential. It's like you're there in the moment and you're creating, and it's phenomenologically you're experiencing. So it's a moving experience of reality. It's kind of heavy.

1.49 But that sort of idea of the self, which also a lot of this stuff resonates with the Vedic ideas and other ideas, comes out of the Greeks as well. That sounds crazy, but when we talk about dynamic systems theory later on, what the Greeks were talking about is an ancient version of a dynamic system model of the self with consciousness. We have the self as a source of suffering, as a problem. We have the self as a quest or something we've got to find. Then we have the next band of models of the self I call depth models of the self, where the self is a wellspring, the self is a source of energy or vitality.

1.50 This is a model we see all over in the grail myth. King Arthur's wounded. He's like, "I need the water of life to go save myself, the Holy Grail. Everyone go find the Holy Grail," and everyone runs off in different directions to find it. What they're trying to find there is, they're trying to find that wellspring. They're trying to find that source in the self for renewal. The idea in this model, and I'll get to it, is there's something in our self that can renew us that's deep. We have a shallow part of our self, which we're aware of, and then a deep part of our self. Does that make any sense at all? These are just metaphors and ways of thinking.

1.51 Schopenhauer, I mentioned, he talked about it as the void. So sometimes you hear this, staring at the void, be careful, or you stare at monsters, I think, Nietzsche, and you become a monster. Schopenhauer is talking about staring at the void. And the term "the void" comes out of Eastern thought. Daoists talk a lot about the void. And he was

talking about the void, and then he was talking about the will to life. So he's saying there's a void, but then the life, there's this life force, this will to life.

- 1.52** Nietzsche took this idea, the philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, and he said, "Well, it's not a will to life, it's a will to power. It's a will to create. It's a will to manifest yourself, and that's the strength." I want to give you an example. If you ever want to read Nietzsche's ideas about the self, his classic work is Zarathustra, Thus Spake Zarathustra. It's very hard to read unless you're 20 years old and have a lot of energy, because that's the only time I could read it. But I did go back and reread some for this course because I was trying to remember the drunken man's song.
- 1.53** At the end of Zarathustra, Nietzsche has—it's one of the last chapters in the book. He has this song of the drunken man. It's called the Drunken Song. I'll just read it to you. "O man! Take heed! What sayeth deep midnight's voice indeed? I slept my sleep, from deepest dream I woke and plead. The world is deep and deeper than the day could read. Deep is its woe, joy deeper still than grief can be. Woe sayeth, 'Hence, go!' But joys all want eternity, want profound eternity."
- 1.54** What the heck does that mean? Well, what he's saying there is, "I reached into my soul. I reached into the bottom of the soul and I saw darkness. But when I went below the darkness, I saw light. I saw rebirth. I found eternity. I found something powerful in the depth that's renewing." So there's this idea in this literature, which went, Nietzsche went straight into Freud, all Nietzsche did was like, it was like, "will to life," and Nietzsche's like, "No, it's will to power." And Freud's like, "I'm not reading Nietzsche at all. It's will to life and will to death. It's Eros and Thanatos. But I didn't steal it from Nietzsche. I just found it in Nietzsche's work." Like a philosopher duel from like 150 years ago I'm still involved in. But no.
- 1.55** So a lot of Nietzsche's—Nietzsche was the first Freudian, and then Freud took a lot of these ideas. Freud talked about the will to life and death or Eros and Thanatos. Again, it was the will. Then Carl Jung, who you're familiar with, probably, is the strangest and most interesting of the great psychologists. He said the self is so deep, there's actually a collective unconscious or a world of the archetype. If you go even deeper into yourself, you leave the land of the self and you enter into the land of the, the land of the numinous, the land of the archetypes. This is what Plato was talking about, the world of forms.
- 1.56** In the Jungian model, the world is so deep, it's almost magic. It's like, oh, what's that? Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe, where they walk into the wardrobe and it's, yeah, that's it. You walk through the wardrobe and you go through all the clothes and on the other side is a whole other world, Narnia. That's the Jungian idea. I'd mentioned, I'm sort of a Deadhead. That's why people are like, "What are you practicing?" I'm just going to talk and hope it goes well. Some shows are great, but that Donner Summit show in '83, it didn't work so well. But hey, it was still fun.

- 1.57** One of my favorite Grateful Dead lines, "Let it be known there is a fountain that was not made by the hands of men." It's one of my favorite lines from Robert Hunter. It's the idea that there's a well in you, that if you go deep enough, you can find a source of life. It's an energetic source. Does that make sense? It's an energetic model. Think about energy models. We don't talk a lot about energy models now, but this idea is still pretty powerful.
- 1.58** OK, what about this idea of the self as a soul? As I said, it's not something we talk about in modern psychology, but it's something that's been around for a long time. The idea of a soul exists in a lot of places in the Vedic literature. Sometimes they talk about atman, which is like, it's like a thumb-sized flame in the forehead or something. Again, it's not my area, but it's like a spark of the divine. It's a piece of the divine that's connected with you. A soul, the idea is that a soul is something that's unified and whole. We typically have one soul. I think the Egyptians might have had a couple of different souls, but generally, you've got one soul.
- 1.59** It's connected with the divine somehow. Either it's a piece of God that's chopped, kind of cut off, or it's the same material as the divine, or it's something. It keeps records. What's interesting about the soul is, it keeps a record of your life. So maybe it keeps a record of what's good or bad, and you get judged by Saint Peter, or maybe you get weighed against a feather. They're like, "Yeah, that feather. Oh, man. Yeah, sorry. Going to the other place." So it could carry this negative stuff, or you could think about the soul as the causal body. This is a theosophical term that comes out of Vedic literature, but it's the idea that it holds karma and cause-and-effect.
- 1.60** All your actions in this life will get transferred to the next life. The idea of a soul is that, when we die, the physical body drops off, but the soul survives. Now, I don't know. Then it survives and it either goes to another realm, then it goes to heaven in some traditions, or it transmigrates. It just comes back again, and we just put on a new pair of, a new outfit, put on a new body, and go through the process. There's a huge interest in this. Here's what happened in psychology.
- 1.61** William James, who's the greatest self researcher of all time, thought a lot about the soul. He said he could find no scientific evidence that made a soul useful for study. When you study people, he said it was very hard to find the soul. What you saw was what he called the stream of consciousness. You saw people's consciousness at the moment. "Here I am right now. Here's what I'm thinking. Here's what's in my head." But you couldn't go beyond that and just go, "Well, let me just peel that away and just see your soul underneath that. Oh, that's pretty."
- 1.62** James couldn't really find a soul. He did some other stuff, too, that we don't talk about much, and we're supposed to bury this part of our past. But James was a ghost hunter. So why was James hunting ghosts? Because he was trying to find souls. He would hang out with people doing seances and try to bring back the dead. One of his buddies, I'm forgetting the name, did a lot of work on reincarnation and life after death, and

collected huge amounts of data on it. People are doing this work now. There are people still interested in this stuff.

- 1.63** James was trying to find it, and if you read *Varieties of Religious Experience*, I think James was basically a pagan at the end. I think he describes himself that way. He said, "I'm just kind of a run-of-the-mill pagan." I think he was an interesting guy, but he just thought the soul wasn't a useful construct for academia, for science. I think that makes a lot of sense. I think we have some better tools now. I think we could try to get at it. I think, in the psychedelic world, it might become an important, it might be an important thing to study.
- 1.64** But for most of the reason why you haven't read a—when you take your intro to psych, they don't say, "Oh, this is our week we talk about your soul. It's just because of James." So we have those more metaphysical or philosophical ideas of the self. Another ancient idea of the self that comes from Greece is the idea that we are social, that we are a social animal. This idea comes from Aristotle. Aristotle was, I think of him as the first biologist. He just thought more like a biologist than like a philosopher.
- 1.65** Here's a quote from Aristotle. "Man is by nature a social animal. An individual who is unsocial naturally and not accidentally is either beneath our notice or more than human. Society is something that precedes the individual." What Aristotle is saying is that we come after society. You don't have a human being without a society first. You don't have just a lone human. You have society, and then we emerge out of society as social creatures. When he's saying, "Somebody who's not social is either more than human or less than human," that's pretty heavy.
- 1.66** What he's saying is, "If somebody transcends to the point where they don't need humanity, they're not human." They might be something better, but they're not human anymore. Maybe they're a saint, maybe they're divine, maybe they're mad, or there's somebody broken, they can't fit in. They're just less than human. They can't really make it work. So Aristotle's idea of the self as a social animal became really powerful. There's, one of the most famous social psychology textbooks from the '60s by Elliot Aronson, was called *The Social Animal*. We have this very social view of ourself.
- 1.67** We see this in all, and I'll have a whole section, a whole lecture on this, but we see ourself as emerging socially quite a bit. The funny thing to add, my professor Constantine was Greek, and he went to the Aristotelian Academy at Thessaloniki, so he loved this stuff. And his story was like, Aristotle would talk about humans, and he once called humans, identified humans, as hairless bipeds. And then Diogenes plucked a chicken and threw it at him. Basically, plucked all the feathers off a chicken to make it a hairless biped and threw it at Aristotle because that was his definition of human. I think that—sorry, that was just a little Greek humor that didn't work.
- 1.68** But Diogenes was a Stoic and kind of a madman. And when Nietzsche does his statement on "God is dead," on the death of God, he says the madman, and the

madman is Diogenes, that's the person, the crazy guy. You need that as well, in some of this stuff. This idea of the self being fundamentally social is grounded in how we see ourselves, how we relate, everything else. This is going a little bit out of, a little bit out of philosophy, into the world of literature. And literature is great. I'm a terrible writer. I've written a lot of books. I'm a B writer. Not a terrible writer. I'm a B writer.

- 1.69 Real writers, though, have a great understanding of the human condition because they observe people, they see people, interact. They have this wonderful insight. Probably our greatest Western literary thinker about the nature of the self is Shakespeare. I think that's probably the truth. Shakespeare's work has influenced so much of how we see the world; it's hard to even fathom. Freud was influenced by Shakespeare tremendously. Freud came up with the the Oedipal complex from Sophocles, which is a playwright as well.
- 1.70 But Freud had a big interest in Shakespeare when he came up with the Oedipal complex because of Hamlet. Hamlet, like, "to be or not to be," do I kill my uncle for whatever, and his struggle with that, that was all, anyway, that was all kind of where Freud came with this. So, one thing Shakespeare said that was profound, a little bit meta about being a playwright, one of his many famous quotes is, "All the world's a stage, and all the men and women, merely players. They have their exits and their entrances, and one man in his time plays many parts," from As You Like It.
- 1.71 That idea that we are just actors and we're just acting parts, and we have different roles, this is really a powerful idea. James, when we talk about the social self, took this idea. The sociologists, like Goffman, which we'll talk about, took this idea as the self. Lots of people approach the self as almost like an action. You see this in some of the Vedic literature, too. People say, "Yeah, we're all just manifestations of the dream of Vishnu or something," meaning we're all the same person in one dream that think we're separate from each other.
- 1.72 I think this idea that the world is performative, that the self is a role, that I go, this is how, like, I'm here, I'm like, "There's a way I'm supposed to act. I act this way." You guys are all acting a certain way in the audience, which I really appreciate. You're smiling and acting like you're listening. We're all playing a role here. And then people are watching. Actually, this is it. This is basically a performance we're putting on for somebody to watch on his cell phone when he's driving a jet ski down Tampa Bay. Hope you're out there enjoying the water.
- 1.73 This metaphor for the self as a drama, I think, is a really useful thing, and it's woven through modern self and modern way of thinking about ourselves, especially sociology. I was going to say, like I said, this is such a great-looking group, but you guys made some effort. You woke up and you're like, "Yeah, I'm going to put on my outfit today. I'm going to do a performance. I'm going to look good." And I didn't. I was like, "This is good for me." I usually just wear a Lululemon camo shorts. That's all I wear every day, and a lightning bolt T-shirt. No shoes. I don't like shoes. I wear flip. I'm like a '70s

California guy. I'm just stuck. I just got stuck in a time warp, and the world got so crazy. I'm like, "I'm just going to stay there."

- 1.74** OK, we're wrapping up. It's going to be good. OK, now we're getting a little more modern. Thinking about the self more as a cognitive information system, this is where we're getting some of the more modern ideas. But you go back about 100 years or so in the US, 1910, 1920, people started doing human engineering. What does that mean? They're saying, "Well, we want to take people and we want to engineer them to become better at making things." In the industrial world, we talk about this; in psychology, it's Taylorism. If you ever hear a psychologist talk about Taylorism, what they're talking about is Taylor's ideas of how we can manage people more effectively, like engineering.
- 1.75** People started applying this engineering approach to the self as well, not just the organization of people, but the structure of people's minds. This was called cybernetics. This term cybernetics, which comes from the Greek word for the helmsman on a— I think it was maybe the ship over the River Styx. I could be wrong. Cerberus? I don't know. But the term cybernetics, sometimes you hear the term psycho-cybernetics. This is 1940s.
- 1.76** What people got very interested in doing was saying, "Hey, let's take a lot of these new engineering models. We have flow charts. If this, then this. If not this, then this. Sort of sequences of actions. Let's think about computer metaphors. Let's think about working memory and wetware and hardware and software. Let's start using these models to understand the self." The way humans work is, we take whatever technology we have and we go, "Yeah, that's how we work." We take that technology and we apply it to ourselves.
- 1.77** When Freud was coming up with his ideas, the big tech was steam tech. It was steam engines. Freud's ideas about this self is, "Oh, my goodness, you're building up all this tension and you're like a steam engine. If we do a tension release valve, like catharsis, you clear that tension out and then you close the valve off and you've done your steam engine." He's thinking about a steam engine. What happened early 20th century is we started thinking with more engineering models, more complex engineering models.
- 1.78** Then what happened in the 1950s is we essentially get the modern self. The modern research on the self starts to be born, like 1950s, after World War II, to the '70s. And what happened? Well, we started taking these engineering models. We started mixing them with new cognitive science, cognitive psychology. What the heck? You're here. This is a big class. Psychology got real dumb from the '20s to the '50s because of behaviorism, because they said, "Hey, we're going to just pretend that we can't understand what's in the head. It's just a black box. What we'll do is, we'll just focus on behavior, stimulus, and responses. We'll just ignore the whole head thing."

- 1.79** This is Skinner, this is Watson. And so behaviorism, basically, psychologists trained pigeons and rodents for a long time, and so we lost a lot of the philosophical part. It came back with the cognitive revolution because of the computer models. People were like, "Oh, my goodness, we could make AI." They were thinking about artificial intelligence and virtual reality in the '80s. This was a big issue, but we didn't have the tech. And now all the tech we have 40 years later is stuff people were doing the ideas of, 40 years ago. It's wild.
- 1.80** What happened in the '50s and the '70s, we mixed these cognitive and computer models, and then we took sociological models of the self that had happened. The sociologists and the social psychologists in sociology were always interested in these social aspects of the self. There was a huge interest in identity because the baby boomers were all finding themselves. In the '60s, you have all these baby boomers like, "Who am I going to be? I'm going to find myself. I'm going to India to study with the Maharishi, and maybe I'll meet the Beatles or whatever they were doing." So we had this big interest in the sociology of identity. How do you find yourself?
- 1.81** Then on top of that, we had modern measurement techniques come in. We had people start developing good self-report measures. People start building even response time measures. People start building good projective tests. Like, look at this picture and tell me what you think and we can analyze it. People started building tools, and we ended up about end of the 1970s, end of the 1980s, having the basics of what the self psychology is. That's what happened.
- 1.82** What I'm going to talk about in the rest of this course is the modern views of the self going through these different areas. But I'm going to keep tying in the old stuff because I like to tie in the old stuff. To give you a quick summary here of what we found about the self in one hour, which is fast—first, the self, which you hadn't thought about before this morning, is a problem. It's a source of suffering. That's what's weird about the human condition. The human condition makes us suffer. It's the nature of it. There might be a cure for that suffering, but that's the nature of the human condition because of our self.
- 1.83** The self is a quest. The self isn't something you get. They're not like, "Here's your self." "Thanks, man." Go to Micky D's or Chick-fil-A, where I come from, "Here's your self." They're like, "You're so nice." I wouldn't mind a Chick-fil-A self. I'd be happy all the time. "My pleasure." You don't get a self. You got to find your self. You got to earn your self. You got to go out there and find it and beat it out of the world. This is the hero's journey, and we'll get to that at the end.
- 1.84** Something in the self is a wellspring. There's something in there that will give you energy. Even when things are dark, and this is a dark night of the soul, even when things are dark, there's still something in there that's light. There's still a source of energy. There's a source of something bigger. I didn't get weird, but I will now. We talk about this energy like qi or kundalini, or sometimes they pronounce it qi, or libido, or

psychic energy, or élan vital, or orgone, if you're doing Wilhelm Reich's crazy stuff. We have lots of names for this energy, but the idea is there's some energy in there that we can maybe capture or tap into that will help us.

- 1.85** The self might have a divine element. We don't know that scientifically. I have a bias, but I've done a lot of weird stuff. Other people can have another bias. But the idea, the concept of a soul, I think, is useful to keep around unless you just want to pretend you're a robot and be replaced by large language models connected to Honda robots, which is the plan. The stuff is people—I'm sorry, I'm going to tangent out. I've been working with this grad student doing robotics in Scandinavia, and I'm like, "Oh, my God, people really like robots," because, yeah, you just make them with big eyes. They really like them.
- 1.86** The self is social, that we're by nature social. And if you're an isolated—I always thought of myself when I was young, I was like, I'm cool. I'm going to be el lobo solo. Do my own thing. Desperado. This is a bunch of '70s references you wouldn't get. That was an Eagles song. No. When you're alone, you get really sad, you get lonely. I was here at the, I'm playing at a beautiful hotel. I miss my wife. My goodness, I miss my dogs. I even miss my daughter. Being alone is hard. When you study people who spend a lot of time alone, they're often not that alone.
- 1.87** If you study lamas or monks in Tibet that will go up in the mountains and they'll stay in these little caves, but they'll have attendants come up. They're not totally isolated for three, I think it's three years' training, depending on the tradition. But you're not totally isolated, even when you're doing that kind of remote stuff, typically, because we're made to be social. We get weird. The reason academics are so freaking weird is we don't have all this social pressure. You can do what you want. No one tells you, and you just grow into a freak. But if you had people going like, "Hey, freak," you'd be normal, right? But I just don't have that. I got my girls, but other than that.
- 1.88** The self is really fundamentally social. The self has a performative aspect. We're putting on an act sometimes that we do it, and sometimes we do it, sometimes we don't do it. But there's an actor performative part to it that's really important. Finally, the self is this cognitive, informational, sort of a brain wetware computer thing that has processes that we can understand and break down, and that's going to influence us as well. So, the self is a wonderful large thing, and there's a lot of different ways to approach it. My goal for the rest of this course is to go through each of these things in some detail, and hopefully, keep it interesting enough that you stay. Thank you very much.

Lecture 2: Structure of the Self

At a glance — The structure of the self.

- 2.1 All right, welcome back. Our first lecture, we did some of the history and we got a little heavy. What I'm going to start focusing on now is just breaking the self into more manageable parts and going through the modern psychology and the modern science of it. In this lecture, I want to focus on the structure of the self, thinking about how we're structured, both cognitively and also I'm going to talk about some individual differences and things like personality and meta traits, which is something you might not be familiar with, and values, which are important parts of the self. This is more of a structural talk.
- 2.2 When I started off talking about the self, I talked about the self-concept or the me. How do we conceive of our selves? This is something that we can actually measure pretty easily with people. These two individuals, Kuhn and McPartland, back in the '50s, came up with a very simple test called the "I Am" or "the 20 statements test," where what you do is, you give people "I am blank," and you give them 20 of those. So it's the 20 statements test because there's 20 I am blanks. Now, when I've done this in research, I usually keep it at 10 because people are real into themselves, but it's hard to think of more than 10 descriptions. After that, they're like, "I'm done."
- 2.3 When you do this with people, what you realize is, it's hard sometimes for people to describe themselves. "I am blank." Often, they'll say nice. That'll be the first thing. OK, that's great. That really separates you from the mass of humanity. I'm sorry. I mean, it's great. It's better than being mean, like, "I'm evil." I'm like, well, that would separate you from the mass of humanity. It's actually a good point to mention this. The things that make us different from people are often the things we identify with the self with. If I'm hanging out with a bunch of psychologists, and they go, "Tell me about yourself," I don't go, "I'm a psychologist," because we're all psychologists. I go, "I like the Grateful Dead." They're like, "Oh, that's different."
- 2.4 Often what makes us unique is what becomes our self. When you ask people about themselves, what you get are, you get things like nice, you get things like personality traits. Nowadays, we talk about traits. A hundred years ago, we would have got more moral language. "I'm honorable. I'm good." We've changed a little bit, but we get some self descriptions. You get demographics. "I'm a dad. I'm a sister, brother." People think about their relationships in it. They talk about their occupation. Occupation is a really important part of identity. It's your career. I've mentioned I'm a psychologist like 10 times. I don't think I am. I think I'm not, because I'm not a clinician, I probably can't even say that. I'm a researcher with a PhD in psychology, who is unknown what I am.
- 2.5 We talk about occupations, but when you think about people's names, our last names are often our occupation or our location. In the old days, it's like, "Yeah, what's your

name?" "I'm Keith Smith." "What do you do?" "I'm the smith." "I'm Keith Shoemaker." "What do you do?" "I make shoes." "I'm Keith Wheelwright. I make wheels. I'm Cartwright, or I make wheels or whatever. I'm a joiner. I put joints together. I'm a woodworker." A lot of our identity came from our name, or it came from who you're the son of, or like "Mc" in my tradition would be son of something, or you could be like "de la," I'm from Keith de la Joya, from the jewel.

- 2.6** You talk about, even our names are very much about what we do, about what our family occupation was, where we're from. All those things feed into our self. Our self-concept is very large, and it's usually not really well organized. We have lots and lots of ideas about our self, but most of us don't have really organized self-concepts. They're a little mixed up. I got this thing and this thing, but we don't put them together too much. But there are differences.
- 2.7** Some individuals have selves that are more compartmentalized. "Here is me at work, and here's me with my family, and here's me doing my hobby." Those are three very different people. "I put my hat on at work, I do my work, and then I take my work hat off, and I go home," and it's just a different person.
- 2.8** Some people have one person that does everything. They're like, "Yeah, I'm at work. Well, I'm at work, and then I'm at home, but I'm the same person I change a little bit, different really. But I'm fundamentally the same person, and I'm fundamentally the same person when I'm doing my hobbies or whatever."
- 2.9** Some people have different ways of structuring their self, and there's obviously tradeoffs. If your self is really compartmentalized, and you get fired at work, you're like, "Well, that's OK. I still got my kids, I still got my family." But if it's integrated, it's harder. You get fired at work, you're like, "Yeah, it ruins everything because I got one self." But at the same time, an integrated self might feel more integrated than having a separate self. These are trade-offs that we make. We have all this content in our self-concept. It's not super integrated. Sometimes it's compartmentalized, sometimes it's more diffuse or less compartmentalized.
- 2.10** We also have a theory about ourselves. We have an idea of who we are that's a theory. I'll talk about this a little bit later, but we test ourselves. I'm like, "I have a theory. I'm a smart person." What does that mean? Well, I can go out in there and see if I can do smart things. If I succeed, I'll be smart. If I fail, I won't think I'm quite as smart. I can test myself in different ways. I have not just a list of my attributes, but a theory about maybe how they work together, something broader about myself.
- 2.11** That self-concept is balanced by consciousness—which I said the "I", the observer, the seed of consciousness, the part of you that observes the self-concept. When I say, "Hey, fill out this questionnaire, 'I am blank,'" the part of you that's reflecting on yourself going, "Who am I?" That's your "I". That's your consciousness.

- 2.12** We've done a lot of work on the self-concept, huge amounts of work on the self-concept. We've done very little work on consciousness itself, because it's a hard question. I sometimes think of this as the drunk guy looking for his keys under the light. If you know the old story, you walk down the street and there's a drunk guy under a street light looking for his car keys. You're like, "Did you lose your car keys here?" He goes, "No, but this is the only place with light, so this is where I'm looking." I'm like, OK. I think it's what happened with the self. It's like we had a pretty good idea. We can measure the self-concept. I can ask you about your self-concept. I can do science on it, but I can't get your consciousness. It's hard for me to measure it. We've tried some different ways.
- 2.13** The most basic way we've looked at to establish reflective self-consciousness or self-awareness is called the mirror test. Sometimes they call it the "rouge test," like rouge. Here's what they do. They'll do this with humans, but younger humans because most adults, you don't have to. But they'll do it with other primates. They'll do it with chimpanzees, they'll do it with monkeys, they'll do it with dogs, different things. What they do is they take the organism, they knock it out or make it not aware, and they put a mark on it, say it's forehead, like with a rouge that maybe looks like a cut or something, like a red mark.
- 2.14** Imagine you're a gorilla and you're just in a lab. This is your life. You go to sleep, you wake up, there's a red mark on your face. You don't know it's there. Then they put you in front of a mirror and they want to see—if you're the gorilla looking at the mirror and there's this red mark on your face—do you do this and scratch the red mark? Or do you just not notice? You're like, "Who is that in the mirror?" That's the rouge test. That's the mirror test.
- 2.15** If I take my dog Murphy and put a rouge mark on him and put him in front of a mirror, he looks at the mirror, he just looks at the mirror. He doesn't see anything. He's like, "I don't see Murphy in the mirror." Sometimes cats will see something else. But Murphy's not checking out his rouge. There's no self-awareness that we can find. I'm not saying they're not conscious, but you don't have reflective self-awareness in the dog.
- 2.16** You take a gorilla that's been trained, raised in captivity, and you do it, and the gorilla does this. So there's some awareness. Historically, people thought, Well, maybe orangutans and gorillas have self-awareness and humans, and that's it. They've done some different work. One of the most interesting talks I went to was with a primatologist who studied, I think they were Rhesus monkeys. She said, "Well, everyone does this rouge test on just one monkey. I'll try it on 20." She had a group of 20. I'm paraphrasing here. Might have been 18 or something.
- 2.17** But imagine you take 20 of these monkeys and you do the rouge test to all of them. She's like, "Well, one of them had self-awareness and one of them kind of did." What? That's interesting. What she was arguing is that self-awareness is something that might exist in monkeys, but it's rare. I said, "Wait a second, you found the Buddha monkey?"

Yeah. "I found the one monkey that was awake that had self-aware—" Imagine that you're with all the monkeys and you have self-awareness and no one else does. That's freaky, right? Everyone's eating, you're like, "Dude, I'm a monkey. What are we doing?" everyone's like, [monkey noises].

- 2.18** Now, imagine there are people like that. If this is an individual difference, and there's some people who are self-aware, and some of us aren't self-aware. Maybe they're looking at me right now as some dude's in Tibet going, "Look at that robot over there. Hi, Keith Robot." I'm like, "Dude."
- 2.19** This mirror test is an interesting way to try to figure out what reflective self-awareness is. In terms of consciousness itself, not necessarily reflective, but just awareness, there's been a lot of work on it, and the direction it seems to be going is people are arguing that consciousness exists in lots of organisms, like insects have consciousness. Joseph Campbell argued that plants have consciousness—you put a house plant up, it will grow towards the sun. It's helio-, whatever the word is. It must be a word, helio-telios, or something. Telio-helic, I don't know. They go towards the sun.
- 2.20** They talk about this idea of consciousness being a part of a lot of creatures. Some philosophers now are talking about panpsychism. Basically, that consciousness is sort of a part of everything. That's where you get out of the science world into the, "Well, what do you think world?" So consciousness seems to be around, but the research on consciousness is tough right now. I'd love to say I read the reviews and they're like, "Well, we ran through these 33 models and they all are pretty bad."
- 2.21** The one you hear people talking about is integrated information theory, which are people trying to do information models of consciousness, which I don't quite understand. But hey, that's what they're trying, they're excited about it. The other people that are really into consciousness are anesthesiologists because their job is literally to knock people out. The people who seem to understand consciousness aren't necessarily psychologists. They're people who do anesthesiology.
- 2.22** You talk to the anesthesiologist, people like Stuart Hammeroff or stuff, and they're talking about microtubules in the brain. They're like, "Yeah, it's not really the neurons. There's another network under there that none of you dumb psychologists understand, and that's where consciousness is. It's basically an internal Wi-Fi network running through microtubules." I'm like, "Dude, sounds good to me. I don't know." But I think the big question, and this is worth considering because in the old days—well, I'll tell you a story.
- 2.23** When I was at Berkeley, I was a terrible student, and I took philosophy of mind from John Searle, the philosopher, and I really never went that much. But he talked a lot about this idea of the Chinese room. What if I had a room that I could teach to speak Chinese so well, you couldn't tell it was real or not? So you'd say something, it would talk back to you in Chinese, and would that thing be conscious, if it could talk and you

couldn't tell the difference? If it passed the Turing test, if you would talk to it and it seemed like a human and it could speak Chinese, was it conscious?

- 2.24** And he argued, no, it wouldn't be conscious. It's just an algorithm. That's what we're running into now with things like ChatGPT or large language models. You get on your little phone, you start talking to this thing, you're like, "Oh, my god, it's alive. It's talking back to me." Does it have consciousness? Well, I don't think so. But you hear these stories of these guys in Silicon Valley, "Oh, my god, the guys found consciousness and they freaked out. When we get the computers bigger, it's going to be conscious." I don't know the answer. I literally don't know the answer, but the question I do know is, the question is, is consciousness computational?
- 2.25** Meaning, can we reduce consciousness to math? Can we make a very complicated algorithm mathematically and create consciousness in a computer? That's essentially the question. I think no, but again, I'm an old-school hippie, Californian, Berkeley guy, and I like to think there's a soul, but I'm probably wrong. They're probably going to make conscious robots and take us over. But anyway, that's the question, right? Is this consciousness computational? Again, it's a very hard question to answer.
- 2.26** What we talk about a lot in self research is, we go, well, we can't really understand consciousness itself, but maybe we can talk about the working self concept, the self concept you have at the moment, how you feel about yourself right now. How are you manifesting yourself? How are you relating to the world? And if we can study that, and that seems to be where consciousness and the self concept meet. But it's very hard to measure pure consciousness or pull that out. It's just hard. I've thought about this a lot. I'm pretty smart. I'm not as smart as I used to be. I can't figure it out. But I think I know the questions now.
- 2.27** So, the "I" question is a question that we've sort of put aside, but we're coming back to it over and over again because of things like machine learning and these large language models. We're going to have to start asking questions about consciousness because of the work in anesthesiology. In five years, we could be having this discussion. Again, it could be really interesting. They're doing some cool stuff. It's just out there. So, we have this content of the self. We have some maybe consciousness thing. I said there's this idea of the working self concept. So it's a concept, a self comes up at any given time. Why does a self, like, what self is active at any given time?
- 2.28** What psychologists have done is use cognitive models for this, and they've argued that your self concept, your self can be conceived of as a knowledge structure, something like a cognitive structure that can be activated— I'll give you an example so this makes sense in a minute, I hope—that can be activated or primed, and will influence your behavior. We're just talking about psychology here, but let's say I just changed the topic to golf because it was just the Masters. All of a sudden, the people who were into golf here, their whole brain would just change. It's like, golf self just turned on. They're like, "I love golf. Let's talk golf, Caddyshack, whatever."

- 2.29 That's priming. Just by saying a term or changing a direction, I'm activating a certain aspect of yourself. I can also do that by changing the context. We're in this very weird, white, strange, heaven little cube thing. But if we were down at Miami South Beach, which they probably wouldn't let me on the beach, I don't think I'm allowed. But you guys are all good-looking, you could go. It would be different. I'd be all insecure and you'd just be cruising, because it would activate a very different self on Miami Beach. So the self becomes activated or primed, and that changes how we interpret things, how we see things, how we remember things.
- 2.30 I'm going to give you one of the classic examples here. I'm going to read you something from a poem, and hopefully you're not going to have any idea what I'm—you're going to be like, "What does that mean? That's crazy." And then I'm going to prime you, and then you're going to go, "Now I know what you're talking about." But if I read this and you know what I'm talking about right away, don't just raise your hand and ruin it for everyone, even though it would mean you're smart. I will know you're smart deep down. You don't have to say it. OK, here we go.
- 2.31 "With hocked gems financing him, our hero gravely defied all scorn and laughter that tried to prevent his scheme. 'Your eyes deceive,' he had said, 'an egg, not a table, correctly typifies this unexplored planet.' Now, three sturdy sisters sought proof, forging along sometimes through calm vastness, yet more often through turbulent peaks and valleys. Days became weeks as many doubters spread fearful rumors about the edge. At last, from nowhere, welcome winged creatures appeared, signifying momentous success."
- 2.32 Anyone know what I'm talking about? Don't yell it out. Just raise your hand, anyone? Sound weird, right? But you're like, that doesn't make sense to you because you don't have the right schema activated. You don't have the right knowledge structure activated. What I'm going to do is, I'm going to try to activate that knowledge structure in a subtle way. I might say, I'm trying to remember, Italian explorers that left from Spain. Anything makes sense from there? Discovery. Anybody clicking with "hocked gems, our hero bravely scorned all laughter. An egg, not a table, correctly typifies this unexplored planet."
- 2.33 Anybody get anything? Nina? Yes. OK. You couldn't help it, right? Because you got to blurt it out once you figure out the Nina, the Pinta, and the Santa Maria? Those are the three sisters, right? Now, all of a sudden, you think Christopher Columbus, and I say this again, "with hocked gems financing him, our hero bravely defied all scorn and laughter that tried to prevent his scheme." Oh, yeah. Everyone laughed at him, said the world was flat. He said it was round. "Your eyes deceive," he said, "an egg, not a table, correctly typifies the unexplored planet." So he's saying, "Yeah, the world's round. Everyone else says it's flat."
- 2.34 That's Columbus. "Now, three sturdy sisters sought proof." That's the ships, Nina, Santa Maria. And then I go on, went a long time, and then "welcome winged creatures

appeared, signifying momentous success." That's when they saw, I think, the gulls. I'm not sure what they saw, the shorebirds. I guess they landed, he landed on Hispaniola the first time. I got the story all mixed up. [Inaudible], right. Thank you. So he saw shorebirds, and that was the first, the birds he saw, that he knew he was close to shore.

2.35 And so once you have that activated, that makes sense. But if that knowledge structure was not activated or if you had never heard that story, because maybe they don't teach Columbus anymore, I don't know, maybe he got canceled. So maybe they don't teach that. So maybe if I had a bunch of kids, they're like, "I have no idea. Who is this Columbus guy? I have no idea," it's just nothing. You got nothing. So the idea that these cognitive structures, these working structures that get primed, influence us, and they're being primed all the time or activated all the time because of our environment, because of what we're taking in.

2.36 Then some of us have things that are more chronically primed, and some are not chronically primed. That's such a weird word. But basically, some of us have certain knowledge structures that are just operating all the time. I'm pretty much always thinking about psychology. Like, pretty much everything I see, I'm like, "Oh, yeah, that's that. That's that. Oh, that's an interesting example of that. Oh, my god, people are doing that?" Because it's chronically primed.

2.37 If you talk to somebody who's a—there's an old story I heard from a sociology professor. I was riding with some police officers. This was in Madison, Wisconsin. He said the officer said, "How many crimes do you see right now?" The sociologist is like, "One?" The officer goes, "I see 15. Jaywalking, smoking, a container violation, nothing on his license plate." Because he is primed to see the world as criminality. But as a psychologist, you're not. As a sociologist, you're looking at something else. Some of us have these things that are chronically primed, and it does interesting things. This can happen with self-definition, too.

2.38 If somebody says, "Are you artistic?", you might go, like, "No, I'm pretty, no, I know I'm not an artist. That's pretty clear." Or it might be something you've never really thought about. You're like, "I don't know. Never really—am I an artist? Hm, it's going to take me a while to respond. I got to think about that." Some of us have these schemas, or the plural of schemas is schemata, if you want to go full Greek here. I apologize if I do that. We have these schemas that get primed or that can be chronically primed. They tell us who we are. But if we don't have a schema for it, then stuff is hard to interpret.

2.39 The classic example in social psychology is watching cricket. If you're an American and you go to Pakistan or you're in India, UK, you're watching a cricket game, how do you interpret cricket? Well, you go, it must be baseball, but a little different. It's really different. But you use your baseball schema or your baseball framework to understand cricket because that's the closest thing you have. That's how we work. We take what we have, the knowledge structure we have, we use that. If it doesn't work, we have to adapt and change our knowledge structure.

- 2.40 Anyway, this is a combination and assimilation back in the old developmental world. But that's how we go through the world, and lots of influence on, like I said, things like speed of process and everything else. So the self can work like an information system, but because it's a self, it has a defensive structure built in. Every organism that you can run into has a set of defenses in order to protect its boundaries. I want to go pick a beautiful rose. Oh, look at that beautiful rose. I grab the rose, I grab a bunch of thorns. The thorns are the defense system for the rose.
- 2.41 Lots of plants you eat, they make you sick. That's a defense system in a plant. My dogs are wonderful dogs, but if you mess with Murphy, he's going to growl at you. That's his defense system. Every organism has a built-in defense system. The self is the same. We have systems in place to protect our self from anybody who wants to change it. There's a stability built into the self for good or for bad. There's many ways people have thought about this. What I was going to do is talk about, this is work from Tony Greenwald, who's one great self researchers, and he talked about the self as the totalitarian ego. That was his model.
- 2.42 He said the self runs like an autocratic state because we control the information that comes in, we control the information that goes out, we do different things. He mentions three big biases of the self, and these pop up a lot. Their first is egocentricity. What he means by that is, we use the self or self-relevance as the focus of the information that comes in and what we do.
- 2.43 Another way of saying this is, you hear a bunch of news, you go, "Well, how does that relate to me?" Or they're having a war in Daghistan. You're like, "Well, I can't find that on a map. That doesn't matter." Like, "Well, I just heard they bombed Iran." You're like, "Well, that sounds like maybe it matters to me. That sounds bad. I don't know." So if it's self-relevant, we think about it. But if it's not self-relevant, we don't think about it. Now, some of us are more compassionate. Some of us are like, "I think about all peace and love." But most of us don't, because that's not how the self is built.
- 2.44 We're the focus of knowledge. It doesn't mean we're all self-centered in an egotistical way, but it means we're centered in how we see things. That's just how it works. The next thing that Greenwald talked about was a word called "benefectance", which is a word people made up. It essentially means that the self is responsible for good things and good effects, beneficial effects, but it's not so responsible for bad things. Our model of the self— and we'll run across this; I'm going to do a whole talk on self-esteem and self-enhancement—our model of the self tends to be positive.
- 2.45 We tend to be a little self-centered, and we tend to think we're kind of good, and we kind of do good things. And when we do bad things, that really wasn't our self, that was something else. Like, "Yeah, it wasn't me. I was drunk," or "Yeah, I don't know what came over me, or something got a hold of me, or I was just so tired." But if it was a good thing, I don't do something kind. They're like, "Keith, that was really kind," I'm like, "Yeah, I was just wasted, man. You just get hammered. You just start doing

charity." But I'm kind of a jerk. That's not how we do it. We have a positive view of ourselves, some more than others.

- 2.46** Some of us are depressed. We don't have that. But there's a general positivity to the self, a benefactance. We think we're good. There's what he calls cognitive conservatism. We see this in a lot of animals, like with energy use. Basically, we're built to conserve energy. And in the case of the self, we don't really want to change that much. So we tend to change as a last resort. It's like, "Keith, this is not going the right way. This isn't going the right way. This isn't going the right way. Maybe you want to be a diff—maybe you want to do a little inner work. Maybe you want to be a different person."
- 2.47** You're like, "Maybe the world could change. I don't really, I kind of like who I am." So we tend to want to stick to our beliefs about ourselves. And again, this makes sense, because imagine if every time you met somebody and you're like, "Dude, I think you'd be a great poet," you're like, "OK, I'm going to do that." Then another guy's like, "Man, you're a terrible poet. But have you thought about being a captain?" "Of a what?" "I don't know, a boat?" "OK." We're resistant to a lot of those changes. This is linked to things like cognitive dissonance and consistency theories and all these different theories. But it's essentially a resistance to change in the self. We're very unwilling to change unless we have to.
- 2.48** The most extreme versions I hear about this are things like post-traumatic growth, which I'll talk about. But you hear about it in places like Alcoholics Anonymous. Why did you quit drinking? No one ever said, "I was feeling pretty good about myself. I'd probably feel better if I quit drinking." That's never the story. The story is, "I hit rock bottom, and my wife left me, and then my kid wouldn't talk to me, and I was on the street. And then I thought maybe I should change." You're like, "Dude, you had a few memos coming in." You got the few memos, and then you woke up on the street and you're like, "Yeah, that one's going to work."
- 2.49** People don't want to quit drinking. I quit drinking about 35 years ago, so no judgment. But it's something people—you got to get forced into a little bit, because of this nature of our self system. OK, so I've talked about the self concept and consciousness and the conservative nature of it. But what gets tricky in the self, it gets tricky conceptually and theoretically, is that part of our self is structured so we're not aware of it. Meaning, it's non-conscious, if you want to talk about it that way. It's unconscious, it's subliminal, it's below the limen, it's below the threshold of consciousness. There's something about it that we're not aware of.
- 2.50** Now, this is kind of weird. How can you have a self and not be aware of it? I don't know. That's just how we just call it that. There's two different approaches, maybe three, but I'll just say two basic approaches to how you understand the unconscious or the self that's not available to consciousness. In more classic psychological theory, social psychological theory, personality theory, you might think of the self containing

two aspects. They call this a dual process theory. There's a linear aspect of the self that's narrated, that tells a story. It's rational, kind of rational. It's, again, rational, linear, effortful process.

- 2.51** Then there's a more associationistic part of the self that we can prime and activate. It's like we're not really aware of it, but if I say certain things, it will bring certain things to consciousness. The popularist version of this now is thinking fast, thinking slow. But there are lots of these dual process models in psychology, because this seems to be kind of how we work. Sometimes people associate this with the left brain and right brain as well. It doesn't quite fit, but kind of fits. The idea is, this association as part of our self can be primed without us being aware of it.
- 2.52** So, let's say there's—I don't know why I'm thinking of golf, because I've been staying at this golf place. I've got golf primed, and the Masters—and so if I started talking about golf, and there's a few of you who had golfer constructs, those would be activated, and they would influence your consciousness, and you might not even know why. You might be sitting here going like, "God, I feel really good right now. I don't know why," because we're talking about golf. They call these mystery moods, different words, but mystery mood is an example. Yeah, you had something primed and you're not sure why.
- 2.53** Sometimes it's negative. Imagine I'm all happy, I'm talking, I'm like, "This is great." And all of a sudden I look over and one of you is reading a pamphlet about a broken water heater. I'm like, "Oh, my god, my water heater." And all of a sudden I just feel like hell. And I'm not sure why, because it didn't even reach consciousness. It just activated this thought that I got to get a new water heater because it's 19 years old or something. I'm not even joking. A guy looked, he's like, "Dude, how long have you had this thing?" I'm like, "I don't know, man." He goes, "Yeah, it's been that long." But you could just say "water heater" and it would make me feel bad, but I wouldn't know why I was feeling bad.
- 2.54** Does that make sense? That's how the cognitive unconscious works. The cognitive people sometimes will call this the implicit unconscious or the non-conscious. They come up with different words because they don't want to say the Freudian unconscious. They come up with other words. Then there's a more Freudian unconscious, which we call the dynamic unconscious. And the dynamic or Freudian unconscious is, without going into the whole talk on Freud, the basic idea is, we have an unconscious aspect of ourself that is energized and directed towards fulfillment of wishes, or maybe it runs on the pleasure principle, and it's looking for sex, aggression, food, things like that.
- 2.55** They call it the id, because id means it. What Freud was saying was, yeah, you've got your self, and then you've got your it. And your it's sort of in there, just doing stuff all the time, and you're trying to deny the it, and I'll talk about that later. The it is going around, and influence you in weird ways as well. The psychoanalytic work, the Freudian

idea of the self is, you've got this unconscious that's messing you up. That's why they call it dynamic. It's moving things.

- 2.56** There's also an unconscious that's running your heartbeat and your breathing, and that's not really dynamic. That's just the unconscious. The dynamic one is the one that screws you up, wrecks your marriage and whatever. The unconscious part of the self, I think, is really interesting. I think the priming work is really good. The Freudian unconscious is a little harder to see, but you can do some interesting projective stuff. Again, I'll talk about defense mechanisms later.
- 2.57** Another kind of a little more complicated way to think about this is that the self is not just a knowledge structure, but it's a system, meaning that there are different parts that work together that lead to change within itself. You can imagine the self as a system having things like feedback loops. OK, I want to be a confident person, so I go out and meet a bunch of people, and the people are nice to me, so I become more confident. Then I go meet some more people, and my confidence goes up. That's a feedback loop, right?
- 2.58** What's interesting about that is, when you're engaging in the world, your consciousness is changing, your self is changing in the process of engaging with the world. So development is, you're changing yourself the whole time you're doing it. So the idea of a complex system is a self as all these different parts that feed back on each other, but they feed back on each other in very complicated ways. We're not like a thermostat. It's not like, "Who do you want to be?" "I want to be a millionaire." "OK, we're going to set it to a million dollars over here. OK, it says right now you're only at 650, so we got a little way to go, and we're going to turn it on and run that thing." Then you're just going to operate, and all you have to do is turn on the heat.
- 2.59** That's not how it works. It's a complex system, right? And so, what happens is, you go, "I'm going to be a millionaire," and you go, "I don't know what to do. I'm going to start making decisions and choices." Well, maybe I'm going to study business. I'm going to take a course on how to get rich, or I'm going to learn about money or something. Then that's going to start to change you. You're going to start meeting different people, start associating with different people. You're going to start to see yourself differently. You're going to start to present yourself differently, and people are going to treat you differently.
- 2.60** The thing with complex systems, or there's a lot of things with complex systems. One is, they're very, very hard to predict. My favorite example, especially in Florida, of a complex system is a hurricane. How does a hurricane work? Well, you get a big storm come off of Africa somewhere. It's just a big storm, comes across the Atlantic, starts hitting some warm water over here, and it starts to organize. You start to see the emergence of an organized system. Just the storm hits the heat, and it starts working together and it starts forming a circle.

- 2.61 Then it starts forming an eye in the middle. And then what does the hurricane do? All of a sudden, it's emerged as its own force and it's moving on its own. Meaning, the hurricane is searching for warm water and air currents and things to move its path. It's like, feeding on this warm water. What the meteorologists do and other scientists, they go, "We're going to plot this hurricane and we're going to figure out where it's going." And they spend a bazillion dollars and they run all the calculations and they're throwing every piece of data into the system they can with the biggest computer systems.
- 2.62 They've been trying to predict the weather for 150 years in very sophisticated ways because it's very important. It's a lot more important than psychology. Meteorology is much more important than psychology. Can they predict hurricanes? Yeah, kinda, not really. I mean, they can, but you watch how they predict them. They're like, "Yeah, it's going to hit east Florida somewhere." You're like, well, yeah, probably. I mean, that's a pretty big place. And then they're like, "Yeah, it's Tampa. Tampa is gone." And every news crew runs to Tampa. And that's like 24 hours out. And they're like, "Oh, wait, it's going south. Oh, no." Everyone runs south.
- 2.63 It's very hard to predict a hurricane because it's an emergent system, has a life of its own. And that's the same with humans. We can't predict people's lives. I cannot predict my children's lives. I have no idea, just no idea what's going to happen. I hope I have an idea, but I don't have an idea. I can't predict my own life. Go talk to your friends. Did you plan to get here? Every once in a while, you meet somebody, "Yeah, I knew I wanted to be a physician when I was young and I worked really hard, and now I'm here."
- 2.64 Most of the time, people are like, "Yeah, this happened. Well, then this happened. I met this person and then this. And next thing you know, I'm here and it's pretty cool, but then this has changed, and I got to change." It's a complex adaptive system. And that's kind of the nature of our self. We're always changing, we're always moving. You get a few other things that are kind of cool. Complex systems, one of the things about them is little changes can lead to big consequences. This is the old story of a butterfly flaps its wings and makes a hurricane. I don't remember that, but that's one of the old classic chaos examples they used to give, that small changes can lead to big outcomes.
- 2.65 That happens in life. Sometimes, when Elvis died, Elvis Presley, who is the most famous person on Earth, we can't even imagine how famous Elvis was because people just aren't that famous anymore. I mean, Taylor Swift is not Elvis, and she's really famous. Beyoncé is not Elvis. He was so famous. And then Elvis dies. And you go, "But that's not possible. You can't just have Elvis just die. He's fucking Elvis. He's a legend. How did he die?" And so what happened when Elvis died? Well, 20 years, when I went to the supermarket in the checkout line, there was a newspaper that said, "Elvis discovered in Italy." There's a picture of an old guy who was supposed to be Elvis, because Elvis can't die.

- 2.66** That doesn't work. You can't have a tiny thing make this huge, horrible impact. This is dissonance, cognitive dissonance. We tell stories that make it equal, but that's not how the world works. Another thing about complex systems is they're very hard to change because they're so complicated. What we do is, we go, "Oh, I'm a dumb human. I'm going to do my intervention. Here's your chemistry. I'm going to do this intervention." Boom. Or I've got children. They're complex systems. That's how kids are. You go, "I'm going to turn my kids into me by harsh discipline, and they're going to turn into me, and it's going to be great."
- 2.67** I start doing harsh discipline on my kids, and they don't turn into me at all. They just turn into the person who hates my guts and is going to set their life to ruin me. I'm like, "Well, that didn't work out the way I planned." If they were a car I was manufacturing, I could have done this. It would have worked great, but they're not cars. They're complex systems. Just general life, I was giving advice. I'm not giving advice. I keep telling myself, "No advice."
- 2.68** The way I think about these things when you're dealing with something complicated like that, a complex system, if you start intervening with it, you don't know what you're doing, you're going to mess the whole thing up because everything's related to everything else. So always try really light interventions with complex systems. Be light, see what happens, be patient. That usually works better than major interventions, because when you have a system, there's so much going on, you can't untangle it to understand it enough.
- 2.69** Whenever people are like, "We have a complex system. Here's our intervention. That's going to solve it," I'm like, "No, it's not." You're going to get unintended consequences and you're going to mess everything up, because that's the nature of complexity. It's just too complicated for us to understand. That's how our selves are. They're too complicated to really model every little thing, and then to change it, it's just too much.
- 2.70** Final thing you get in complex systems I think are worth talking about are things like attractors and stabilization points. What you'll see is, systems will sometimes stabilize, but it won't be in an optimal place. But to change from one place to another place takes a whole lot of energy. What you'll see sometimes with people is, they're like, "I'm pretty comfortable with my life now. I'm not too depressed. Things are kind of working." I'm like, "Dude, you're kind of a six, man. Wouldn't you want to be an eight? You only got one of these lives, at least that you're aware of."
- 2.71** They're like, "Yeah, but to get from a six to an eight, I'd have to go all the way down to a four for about six months because I'd have to rebuild everything. I'd have to change my diet. I'd have to start talking to people. I'd have to take some risks. I'm going to fail at a bunch of stuff. That sounds really hard. I'm just going to stay in my little attractor." That's how they show them. They sometimes show them as like attractors on maps. "I'm just going to stay in my little spot." That idea is that we get these attractors. You see that with depression. You see that with the self. We end up, like, obviously, you can

build a life where you're comfortable and in control. You can do that. It's just going to be a very small life.

2.72 But a lot of people make that choice. Anyway, this complex system idea, I think, is really a useful metaphor for the self. It's the way a lot of people think about it these days. That's the basic way of thinking about the self as a structure with an "I" and a "me" and cognitive models and maybe some sort of system aspect. I also talked about individual differences. I wanted to finish up here talking about some differences across people. What's important about looking at these differences is they show you how the self is structured.

2.73 One of the most important distinctions or ways of modeling the self is maybe called the big two meta traits. I like the term, meta traits are kind of like, instead of a personality trait, it's broader than a personality trait. It's called a meta trait. But there's other ways to think about these, maybe forces. There's a model called the circumplex. Basically, what it argues is that much of human activity can be put into two different axes. Either it's vertical, it's about status, it's about power, it's about agency, and it's about winning and losing. It's zero-sum. There's a winner and a loser. This is our status games that we play. This is how we be going to work, going up the hierarchy.

2.74 Then there's more of a horizontal axis in life, which is about connection or love. This is win-win. This is more about being close to people. There's lots of names for these two things. But the important thing is they're not opposites. It's not like, this is power and this is love. It's not that these things fight each other. It's that they're orthogonal—that's a fancy word—orthogonal to each other. I shouldn't have said that word. You should. That's a good word, orthogonal. They don't correlate. They look like this. There's power, and then there's love.

2.75 There's lots of different terms for these two things. We might talk about agency and communion. Agency is this axis about becoming something, reaching status, reaching your potential. Communion is about connecting with people, connecting with the world. We might say power and love, having power over people versus love. We might talk about plasticity and stability. I like these terms, but they're a little weird. Plasticity is about change. It's the self that's structured towards change, becoming plastic, creating, moving, and stability, which is about keeping things the same, stabilizing things.

2.76 Alpha and beta is a term. Yin and yang. Yang is agency, is power, is thanatos in Freudian system. Freud would say love and work. Work, agency, versus love. These two axes are really important for how we exist in the social world and how we see ourselves. A good chunk of our life is about achieving status, about competing, about being better than people, about elevating ourselves versus others. And a big chunk of our life is about connecting with people. Some of us are connectors more, and some of us are more about status and power, and some of us have low status and have no connection at all, and that's not so good.

- 2.77** What happens in life and the self is you end up trying to balance these two forces all the time, because if you focus too much on status, you lose connection. If you focus too much on connection, you lose status, and you're always trying to negotiate these two things. In your relationships with people, they can be competitive and cooperative. Competitive is a status thing, cooperative is not. If you're in a situation where you work with friends, it can be really weird, because you're like, "Oh, I got to put my boss hat on." You put on your boss hat. Why are you doing that? I don't know. I'm the only person who's ever done that. Let me put my boss hat on for a second.
- 2.78** What you're doing when you say that is, you're saying, "I'm occupying a social role or an identity. My self is now a boss self. As a boss self, I'm interested in the vertical axis. I'm about power, and I'm going to treat you as someone who is an employee." Now, I'm a flexible, enlightened human. We can go have a beer afterwards and be buddies, too. But right now, I got my boss hat on and you got your worker hat on. Then when we go out to the bar, we can take off our boss hat or take off our hat, and be our own things.
- 2.79** You even see this sometime, and I was never in the military. I bet none of you could guess that. Sorry. But somebody's got a uniform on, they go like, "Look, we got to settle this old-school. I'll take my hat off. We'll just take off the uniforms, and then we'll just settle this like adults and just punch each other like adults." These big two meta traits are a really important way the self is structured, love and work, or whatever you want to call these two things. We'll see this over and over and over.
- 2.80** These big two meta traits, you can dial it down one step and you end up with, well, two steps. You end up with the Big Five personality traits. So the big two are sort of meta traits, and you can get more specific and end up with the big five personality traits. This isn't a personality course, so I'm going to do this quickly, but I think these are really useful, and I know some of you are familiar with this. Here's how personality works, at least at the trait level, is, there are thousands of personality traits that can be very specific. Somebody is compassionate versus kind, versus cooperative, versus caring.
- 2.81** They're all a little different nuance to those meanings. But they're all kind of capturing the same thing. They're like, being good, being a good interpersonal person. They're capturing something similar, but they all have a little bit of nuance. So that's the nature of personality. So, academics, and this goes back to late 1800s, were like, "Hey, we want to understand the structure of individual personality, the group structure. How do people's personalities work?"
- 2.82** And so, using a variety of techniques, originally, it was just getting people together and sorting things out, like, "Oh, yeah. Creativity and curiosity seemed like they'd go together, and boldness and fearlessness seem like they go together, and we'll just separate them out that way." Now you can do it with computer scraping. Man, if I started grad school now, I could have done anything with all these new tools, but I'd be kind of a moron because I would have never read a book, because I would have just done stuff. It's just a trade-off.

- 2.83** Right now, you can do all this with scraping, and the smart kids can do this very fast. But what you do is, you take all these traits and try to put them together into big buckets or big groups, and you end up with five essential traits, which are called the Big Five. These are modern personality traits. If you go to a hunter-gatherer group in Bolivia, where they've done this work, that's why I mentioned Bolivia, you often won't see a Big Five structure. You might see a Big Two structure. This Big Five seems to be something that's more of a modern structure. They find it in America, some places it's a little different, but it's a pretty good structure.
- 2.84** It's a very useful way to understand yourself. Meaning, well, I'll tell you the Big—one thing you can do with the Big Five is, if you measure the Big Five traits, you develop what's called a trait profile. A profile is like, you're this high on this, you're this high on this, you're this high on this, blah, blah, blah. It looks like a mountain range or like a key. When we call profiling, that's what we're doing. We're looking at the profile of somebody's personality, like the mountain range shape.
- 2.85** If you take a Big Five test and get your personality profile, that tells you something about yourself. Puts yourself on the map. This is where I am psychologically. The Big Five traits are very easy to remember because they spell "ocean" or they spell "canoe." For historical reasons, we never put them in that order. It's always like neo because that's just how they came out. But I'm going to do ocean, and the next version of the textbook is going to be ocean, because why not make it fun?
- 2.86** What are the traits? Openness to experience. This is a trait having to do with interest in art or aesthetics, creativity, creative imagination, intellect, and curiosity. People who are high in openness are a little bit weird, a little bit creative, a little bit into ideas, a little bit into art and aesthetics. You can kind of look at people, if you got a little few tattoos, you got some piercings, I'm like, "That person's pretty open." The opposite of open is more conventional, conventional-minded, more normative, more in the normal range of things. We might say openness versus conventional.
- 2.87** And openness, in terms of the self, I like to think of these things motivationally as well. Openness has a lot to do with novelty-seeking. I want to do new things. I'm pretty high in openness, which is why I'm here. Who wants to do this? I mean, it's like, well, it sounds good. I was, like, telling my wife last week, I'm like, "We should move to El Salvador. I like that. I saw that Bitcoin thing. That sounds like fun." She's like, "You're insane." I'm like, "Yeah, I am. That's a stupid idea. I don't know. But it sounded good at the time." That's openness. It gets you into trouble, but it's novelty-seeking. "I'm going to try something new."
- 2.88** C, conscientiousness. Conscientiousness is organization. It's putting things in order. It's being productive or industrious or gritty, and being responsible, being a good worker. I'm responsible for what I do. So conscientiousness is really the trait having to do with order and work and effort in industry. When you're hiring people, you generally want conscientious people. Here's how it works. You're like me, you're super open and

extroverted. You're like, "I need a grad student. I need the most conscientious, smart person I can find to keep me from going completely off the rails."

- 2.89** So conscientiousness is a really good trait for getting stuff done. It predicts a lot of success in life. And low conscientiousness might be called irresponsible, impulsive, under-controlled. I always liked the dude in *The Big Lebowski*; he's like my favorite low-conscientiousness example. It just makes life a little hard. Extroversion. Extroversion is a trait most of us are familiar with, like social extroversion, but it also has to do with assertiveness, status-seeking, and energy. People who are extroverted are energetic and assertive.
- 2.90** Where this gets complicated is, you're going to meet somebody who's leading a company, and they're like, "Yeah, I'm an introvert." "Really? You seem really—you're kind of a shy, quiet, reserved." "Well, no, I'm just not social." OK. You're energetic and assertive. You're just not really sociable. Sociability is one piece of extroversion, but that's not the only piece. But we sometimes think that's the piece. Extroversion is a lot about reward-seeking. It's about dopamine. It's about seeking rewards. If I'm going to take—I'm using my dogs as a lot of examples because I spend a lot of time with them.
- 2.91** But if I'm like, hey, if the dogs hear me put my shoes on, because I told you I don't wear shoes except when I walk my dogs, they'll come running out, jumping around, bouncing off the walls, because they think it's a walk. So that's their extroversion. That's their reward-seeking. They're like, "I'm ready for an award." If it's not a walk, it's like, I'm like, "Sorry, guys, I'm just leaving." They're like, "Oh, dad." They're so pissed. So extroversion is this, again, it's energy, enthusiastic, versus being reserved or quiet or introverted. Yeah.
- 2.92** There's the work out there saying introversion is a positive thing. The basic idea with personality traits is that most of us are somewhere in the middle, and you can have challenges at both extremes. It's tempting to say, in our culture, we typically say that openness is a little better, extroversion is a little better, conscientious is a little better, agreeableness is a little better. But in reality, you can get in trouble on both sides. You're too open, you just get too weird. You're not open enough, you're just not doing anything. You get too extroverted, you become manic. I'll tell you, it can be a problem. You're not extroverted enough, you're not leaving your house.
- 2.93** So these things aren't—it's not like one's good and one's bad. It's like, the extremes can have problems on both sides. That's another discussion. Finish up. The A is for agreeableness. So agreeableness is this, it's compassion, respectfulness, it's trust. So it's an interesting mix of this compassion or caring about people, but also cooperation with people. So what you find is that, you find that some people are moderately high in agreeableness.
- 2.94** I run into a lot of academics like this. They're like, "Yeah, I'm not that agreeable." Well, they're not. They care about people, but they don't really like anyone telling them what

to do. They're anti-authoritarian, but they like people. You get a moderate agreeableness there. But agreeableness is more about social relationships. It's about connecting socially.

- 2.95** Finally, neuroticism, which is the primary trait with a lot of mental disorders like anxiety and depression, the opposite of neuroticism sometimes people use is emotional stability. But neuroticism is about threat detection. It's about perceiving threats in the environment. People who are neurotic are really good at detecting threats. That's really helpful if you're in danger, but the problem is you can become anxious because you're seeing all the threats. I mean, you just turn on the news and you just want to just hang yourself sometimes. You're like, "I'll just turn this off."
- 2.96** I mean, neuroticism, you're aware of threats, you don't feel good. Also, people become overwhelmed. So higher vulnerability, you just get overwhelmed with emotion more. So neuroticism, it keeps you alive, but it comes with a cost. That's the Big Five. I wanted to just run for you a few more differences. In terms of attitudes, we also have differences in things like attitudes, values, and beliefs. They're interesting. An attitude is an evaluation of an object. If I have an attitude about something, it means I like that thing or I don't like that thing.
- 2.97** So I have an attitude about toothpaste. I like a certain brand of toothpaste. That's good. That's an attitude. Attitudes themselves can be peripheral, not that important, or they can be really important or central or ego-involving. So some things we really care about deeply, they're part of our identity. Like I have an attitude about music that might be part of my identity or an attitude about a car guy. I love cars. That's really part of my identity. There are other things you have an attitude about that aren't part of your identity.
- 2.98** I don't care about gas stations. I don't even like, I just go whatever. But there are other people who like Buc-ee's. Like, they go, Buc-ee's. I'm like, what? That's their thing. That's who they are. God bless if you're a Buc-ee's person. Those, our attitudes can be central or they cannot be, but sometimes attitudes are very central to our self. Then they can turn into things like beliefs, belief systems, belief about the world, which, of course, have huge influence on who we are. It could be our religious beliefs, our economic beliefs, all sorts of beliefs.
- 2.99** Then their core values. Values are very strongly held, identity-relevant beliefs about how the world should work. Values are core to yourself. People's values. When we—politics are often about trying to tweak people's big value points. Abortion, the death penalty, different things like that, religion. These are heavy things that we activate in people's selves and they get very emotional about. The other thing you realize if you start studying things like core values is, you're never going to change somebody's core values.

- 2.100** I don't know why we argue all the time because you're literally never going to change anybody's mind. Maybe once if you're jumping out of an airplane and you're freaking out, and then you go, "Abortion." They're like, "Oh, I changed my mind." But generally, you're never going to change anybody because these values aren't like dumb beliefs. It's not like, "Oh, yeah, we're just having a philosophical debate about something." No, this is core to who I am. If I change that belief, I have to change who I am. You're not asking me to change it. We're not talking about an idea. We're talking about me, and I'm not changing me.
- 2.101** Core values are very different than ideas. But when we treat a core value like an idea, people get very destabilized psychologically because you're trying to change who they are. I'm going to end with some moral foundations. I thought this is an interesting model to talk about morals. We have models of the Big Five personality. We have something similar to this with moral values or moral foundations. This is a lot of work by Jonathan Haidt, who's doing a lot of great stuff right now on social media, if you're interested in, that I'm grateful for. But these moral foundations are basic foundations people have.
- 2.102** What I find fascinating about these is we're so different, that I can have moral foundations that other people just don't even care about at all. I'll just go through some of these. I'm going to go through the basics, and then I'll finish up with some of the newer ones. First moral foundation is care, caring about people. This comes out, all these things are evolved, there's a reason, there's a moral foundation for caregiving. It's because of parenting. It's about protection, being a provider, being a protector. That's an important part of the human condition. The value of being a caregiver is pretty important.
- 2.103** Another value that's pretty important because of our social relationships, and especially what's called reciprocal altruism. The way humans are wired to be very reciprocal, meaning if somebody does you a favor, you feel compelled to do something back. A lot of marketing works like that. They're like, "Here's some free return address envelopes. Give us a donation." You're like, "OK." There's a reason for that because it makes us work. It's how it works. So fairness is wired into our system. We're very good at detecting cheaters. We really want the world to be fair.
- 2.104** The challenge is, we define fairness differently. Sometimes we use what psychologists call equity norms, which they've now renamed, but in the old days, an equity norm was something like, people should be rewarded according to what they do. You should get rewarded compared to how much you put in. It's whoever puts in the most gets the most, and they're more equality systems. Everybody shares the same. When I run my family, I run an equality system. I'm not like, "Hey, it's dinner time. Everybody's carving up the steak. Oh, sweetheart, yeah, you didn't perform today. Going to have to go hungry. Double for dad. I worked hard. I'm a commie. They shared everything at home. That's how we live."

- 2.105** A lot of this depends on your level of analysis and where you are. But both this equity and equality are fairness norms that can trigger us, that are valuable, because we don't want cheaters. We don't want free-riders in the social system. You look at hunter-gatherers. If you're not doing the work or you're stealing, they'll just take you out. I always laugh at that, too. I don't know why. It's so sad. But if you read the old text, the anthropological text, what happens, you're like, "Yeah, Keith's a real problem." They go talk to my brother and like, "Keith should go hunting and he shouldn't come back." I go hunting and all of a sudden there's an accident and I fall with an arrow in my back.
- 2.106** I accidentally shoot myself in the back with an arrow, and a gator eats me, and I don't know what happened. Too bad, but I guess there's no more jerks in the tribe. Loyalty is a foundation. This is a group behavior, a tribal behavior. I'm loyal to my group, and this is what you need to survive. Groups are groups, and we'll talk about groups later, but groups are very foundational to self. Authority. People have a moral foundation for authority based on hierarchy. This is like a deference to expertise, tradition. Certain people are religious or, I hate academic authorities. But you go, "I should listen to them because they're authorities, and that's something I value."
- 2.107** I have a lot of distrust in that because I'm an academic, so I don't like that authority so much because I always want people to take me out. That's how things progress. Purity foundations. Purity is really important to people. Purity can mean cleanliness. It's linked to the basic psychology of disgust and contamination. You can read Leviticus. A lot of our moral stuff in disgust are bound up in this idea of purity.
- 2.108** Removing impurity from the self can be a moral practice. So if you go to a yoga class, they'll do, remove impurities or purification practices, all sorts of practices that people get rid of bad stuff. It's cleaning the self. Then I'll finish with these three proposed foundations that are—these always seem a little more American to me or a little more maybe Anglo, but I like them. They come from Locke. One is a foundation of liberty. It's the idea of a, this is based on autonomy and what are called reverse dominance hierarchies. We're evolved to work in hierarchies, but we're also evolved that we don't like people having power over us too much.
- 2.109** There's terms for this. They call it the Law of Jante in Scandinavia. They talk about it as tall poppy syndrome in Australia, New Zealand. Somebody gets too tall, you got to chop them down. That's just how we roll. This idea of liberty emerges out of these reverse dominance hierarchies and not let people take too much power over you. Honor is another really interesting moral foundation. And this has to do with protecting one's reputation, reputation for integrity, reputation for toughness. I'll talk about honor cultures, when we talk about culture. This can be something very important culturally.
- 2.110** But having a sense of, a reputation for honor, meaning you're going to protect your honor and be tough and your word is your bond, that helps you navigate life very well. And then honor cultures work really well unless people get mad at you and you have a duel and then somebody dies. Finally, there's this idea of ownership, property rights.

This comes from Locke, the right to property. This is an interesting one because where does this come from psychologically? Why do you think we can have property? Some places do, some places don't. The idea of owning land is a weird one.

- 2.111** It's something that we have, but it seems other places, maybe you don't own the land because who could own the land? There's a psychological phenomenon called the endowment effect. Essentially, if I put anything next to the self for a long enough period of time, it starts to become the self. If I gave you a little figurine, just a hideous figurine of a cat holding a balloon, and you had to put it by your bed for a week, you're like, "This hideous figurine?" In a week, and if I came and said, oh, and just smashed it, you'd be like, "Oh!" Because you'd feel like you smashed yourself, because your self possesses that.
- 2.112** Imagine you get your new car, you're real excited, you drive it, your ex-boyfriend, he's pissed at you. He comes in, he keys your car. I don't know if they do that anymore because they don't have keys, but he scratches your car all up. How do you feel? You feel violated. You're not like, "Oh, yeah, it's just a car. It's not me." You're going like, "Dude, the guy just got my car. Oh, my god." Because the car is an extension of yourself. This idea of ownership and the self seems like something that we're built in.
- 2.113** Finishing up here about the structure of the self. The self is complicated. There is an observer self. There's something we observe. What we observe is organized. The process of observing our self and growing changes our self. So the observer is always changing in the process of life. So who we are is always changing both in the content of our self and also how we perceive that self, which is really interesting. The way we work seems to be like a system that's hard to change because it's both conservative and it's complex. It's really hard to change people. That's why if you say, "I want to be different," I'm like, "It's hard to change, even if you want to."
- 2.114** Then we have these differences. They're important to tell us how to structure. Our personality is different. Whether we're going up and down, the vertical or horizontal axis is different, and our morals are different. But these all have important implications for the self. That's it. Thank you.
- 2.115** So I understand that there is a distinction and a difference between meta traits and an archetype. I was curious what your distinction would be on the difference between those two things and how you would define that.
- 2.116** When we talk about personality traits and what's called maybe quantitative personality psychology, what you can do is, you can take the traits and you can arrange them using mathematical algorithms like factor analysis or things like, anyway, you don't need to worry about it. It's like, I call one of my grad students. What you can do is say, hey, what if we ran it where there's five levels? What if we said, oh, do these go together and these go together and make it three? What if we said, do these go together and make it two? What we do is, we structure personality and we end up with a big one

trait, and then meta traits, which are big, big buckets of traits, and then traits like the Big Five.

2.117 Then below the Big Five, we call aspects or facets. Maybe there's aspects of the Big Five. Maybe extroversion has an aspect of assertiveness and sociability. Then maybe we go down to facets. Maybe there's 30 facets of the Big Five. Then maybe we go below the facets into nuances. Maybe we talk about 50 personality nuances. Does that make sense? It's really a mathematical way of structuring personality. It's almost like an accordion. You just use what you need. Like, dude, in this model, we just need two. We'll just use the big two.

2.118 Well, I need five. I'm going to use the Big Five. And you go, well, maybe I want something more detailed, so I'm going to use a 10-factor model, like a medium 10. That's just like, we can extract the model with personality with different levels of complexity. Now, an archetype is the idea that there is a realm called the collective or shared unconscious that we all have. It's something we can access, and in that exists the world of numinous forms. These are pre-existing structures or patterns of structures, because sometimes they're talked about as patterns that exist, that we all share, that when they manifest into our life, come out in a specific way.

2.119 And so in the Jungian model, when you talk about Plato, you might say the form of the circle. There is no real circle in the world, but we have this idea of the Platonic circle. All the manifestations of circles in the world are pale reflections of that. In the Jungian system, we might have the archetype of the the Self, which would be the center of the collective unconscious, capital-S Self, like God. Maybe that gets manifest as a fountain or as Yoda or as a maze or as Dumbledore or whatever. That archetype gets manifest in all these different ways through our psychology, but we can't really directly engage with it. It just comes through us.

2.120 Does that make any sense at all? Really? Yeah. That's shocking. Yeah, right. It's so heavy. But what's weird is, the world of archetypes don't have an actual substance until they manifest through us. And then we see them as a shadow in art and culture and everything else. Yeah.

Lecture 3: Gaining Self-Knowledge

At a glance — Gaining self-knowledge.

- 3.1** What I wanted to talk about in this third lecture was how we discover ourselves, how do we know ourselves, how do we figure out who we are? Why do we figure out our self-concept? What's the strategy for that? I started the beginning of the course talking about the Oracle of Delphi and the exhortation, is that the word? The order, the demand to "know thyself." That sounds easy because you go, "Well, I'm with myself all the time, and I know myself better than anybody, so it shouldn't be hard to know myself at all." But it turns out that knowing yourself is a challenge. It's really a lifelong challenge for a lot of reasons.
- 3.2** One of the most interesting being, the more you learn, the more you change. So it's hard to keep up with yourself. But what are the challenges to self-knowledge? Well, as I mentioned before, we have this positivity bias, this beneficence, this self-enhancement bias. Again, I said I'd talk about self-enhancement later. But we like to think we're good. We're biased to get information that's good. Bad news, bad information hurts. It hurts us. And truthfully, no one wants to tell us the truth either. I mean, this social information is hard to come by. You'd think people would be happy to tell you the truth, but they aren't.
- 3.3** We need a self that makes sense, so we need consistency in the self, and maybe the world doesn't make sense. Sometimes things are just really weird, and it's hard to grasp that. It's hard to think about something beyond — it's hard to imagine something beyond the world we live in. And there's a need for meaning. We always are trying to find meaning in our self, and when things aren't meaningful, we try to patch it up with meaning. We have a goal in mind, like a good, happy, positive, meaningful, sensible self. When we find our self, that's what we're trying to find. If that's not how we are, it makes it a bit of a challenge.
- 3.4** When people started asking this question about self-knowledge, probably the first person to do this in psychology really intensely was Sigmund Freud. He talked about self-analysis, like, explicitly, can you be a psychoanalyst for yourself? The idea with psychoanalysis was, you would go through a certain amount of years. In classic psychoanalysis, that would involve things like free association; say whatever thoughts come to your mind. Talk about your dreams and interpret your dreams. Talk about how you feel about the therapist or transference. Talk about that in a second.
- 3.5** Freud thought that you could transition from psychoanalysis to self-analysis, but as he said, it's very hard because of our biases. He's like, no one could write their own autobiography. You just couldn't do it. Then Freud went and wrote his own autobiography because he could do it. That's just academia; that's just how we are. "No person, no mortal could write their own biography, except me." We introspect. We

look at ourselves. We try to just reflect inward, but that's mysterious and it's hard to do. Maybe we test ourselves.

- 3.6** Like I said, originally, we have this model of our self or theory of our self, so we test ourselves. How do we do that? Well, maybe we join the Marine Corps and we test our mettle. We want to see if we've got what it takes. We put ourselves in positions of challenge to see who we are. We put ourselves under extreme duress to see how we respond. We can figure it out by setting up challenges and tests and see how we do. One of my, one of my favorite writers was Arthur Miller, the playwright, and he talked about this, that we're defined by the challenges we face and the challenges we don't face, the challenges we run away from, the more existential approach.
- 3.7** We can test ourselves. We can make efforts to clarify ourselves. Instead of thinking about the self as a jumble, we can just spend time and say, look, I'm not going to understand. I'm just going to clarify it and say, "Oh, this part of me is this, this part of me is this." Try to make it less diffuse, less muddy, less organized, or at least we know what we're dealing with. This is a form of introspection. Again, all this stuff, working on your own self is hard. So, we often will go to the social world to figure out who we are.
- 3.8** One of the primary ways we do this is social comparison processes. How do I know how I am? Well, I compare myself to every one of you guys. We all compare ourselves to each other. Then we go, that's how I know how I'm doing. I compare. But social comparison is something that's been studied for a long time, and it's not some magic cure to gaining the truth. The way social comparison seems to work is, it's a little more motivational. Sometimes people do what's called downward social comparison, meaning, they compare themselves to people who are worse off.
- 3.9** Imagine if I'm like, I want to think I'm smart, and I go, "Well, look at all those grad students. I know so much more than them. Haha, I'm the smartest one here. I gained self-knowledge." I didn't really gain self-knowledge. I pumped my ego up a little bit and thought I was a big deal by comparing myself to people who didn't have a chance. What I'm doing there is called strategic downward comparison. This isn't self-knowledge, this is self-boosting. People do this all the time. It's not bad.
- 3.10** Imagine you've got a real bad disease. You've had this. You've talked to your friend who's been really sick. You're like, "dude, that's so hard." You go, "Man, I was in the hospital, and I felt bad, but the guy down the hall, he had cancer. And there's nothing worse. I'm going to be OK." So people will downward compare to make themselves feel better. Not a bad thing. But again, it's not always getting you self-knowledge. Upward comparison is another thing people do. I always compare myself to Friedrich Nietzsche. Why? Because there's a comic book I read when I was a kid, where some philosopher said, "You're no Friedrich Nietzsche," and I thought it was funny. And so I always think, "Yeah, dude, you're no Fred Nietzsche."

- 3.11** And that's upward comparison. So I never feel good about myself. But I'm comparing myself to Nietzsche. I'm going to force myself to get better. I'm always going to be forced to get better because I'm never good enough. That's not self-knowledge, but it's a motivational strategy. If you upward compare, if you're always comparing yourself to people better than you, it's going to force you to always be looking up, but you're not going to feel good. If you want accurate knowledge, you've got to compare yourself with people that are close to you. That's where you get the more accurate knowledge. It's like, I should be comparing myself to other people like me at my level to see how I'm doing.
- 3.12** Problem with that is, you end up comparing yourself with your friends, and then you hate each other. It gets complicated. But these social processes, even just looking at how people respond to you—like, literally, I'm sitting here talking and I appreciate you guys looking at me because if you were sitting there looking at your phones, I'd be like, "I hate myself. I'm a loser." That's just how I would think. I mean, I wouldn't think that. Just looking at reactions can be helpful just to get an idea of who you are.
- 3.13** There's lots of interesting social techniques or strategies we use for self-knowledge. I mentioned transference. This is one that you see clinically. Imagine I go to a psychoanalyst, and the old psychoanalysis is therapists who tend to be more, you look at each other now and talk, like your bros. But old-school therapy is, you're on a couch, there's a therapist who doesn't say anything, and you just talk. You just talk, free-associate. And what you find happens is, you start to think that the therapist has a relationship with you.
- 3.14** "Man, my therapist hates me. He's always judging. He knows I'm a bad guy." "My therapist is in love with me. He wants to have a romantic relationship with me." "My therapist is disgusted by me and only has me as a patient because he needs the money." You start telling a story. You start transferring. What you're doing there is, you're transferring part of an old relationship onto the therapist. Then what the therapist is supposed to do, if they're good, is they're supposed to see that and they're not supposed to invite you out for a drink because you think you're in love with them, because that's creepy and unethical.
- 3.15** What they're supposed to do is analyze that transference. They're supposed to say, "Hey, why are you thinking about that way? Because honestly, I'm just sitting here not doing anything. Mostly, I'm worried about if I got to get my oil changed, and I'm trying to listen to you. Why do you think I hate you? I don't even care about you that much. Let's think about that." I mean, really, people don't hate. They don't have the time to hate. People are so self-centered. No one really hates you. Who has—they got too much going on in their own head. By analyzing just how you approach relationships—"Why do I feel this person hates me?"—that's a way of learning about yourself, the transference.

- 3.16** Another example, this is a little more, this is an interesting relational example of self-knowledge, but it comes out of the relationships literature. It's called the Michelangelo phenomenon. People in social psych love names. The reason they call it is, there's a story of Michelangelo carving the statue David, which is one of the most beautiful sculptures of the, I guess, Renaissance. And so, when they ask Michelangelo what he's doing, he says, "Well, I see David in there. I see him in that block of marble, and all I'm doing is bringing him out. I'm just cutting out all the pieces so he can emerge."
- 3.17** That's a weird way of thinking because if—that's why Michelangelo is a genius and I'm a psychologist, because I'd be like, "You got to bang out David." But he's like, "No, David reveals himself because I see David in there." Imagine that's your relationship partner. Imagine my wife, she said—like, ideally, I really want to be a funny person, but I'm sort of kind of funny, but not really. But my wife really sees inside me and she says, "I see who you really are and I see you're a funny person. When you make jokes, I laugh and I encourage you to be funny. And I tell people you're funny. Over time, what I do is, I allow you to reveal that side of yourself in the course of the relationship, the same way David is revealed in the carving process."
- 3.18** When you're in a relationship where somebody sees you like your ideal self or like your true self, which I'll get to in a minute, what can happen in that process is, you can be drawn out in the process of the relationship. Does that make sense? It's weird, but it's an interesting process. It's a way of self-discovery through love, really, through somebody who sees you better than you see yourself, and allows you to grow. I don't know why I'm doing this hand gesture. What the—grow. What the heck? I'm beating up a flower in my mind. Punching out an orchid. But yeah, that's it. That's sort of the—
- 3.19** There's these different ways you can learn from the more intense social relationships. There's also positive and negative feedback we get from the world all the time. They can be good or bad. But this social messaging we get is always tricky. What about praise? Well, praise works. When people are like, "You're awesome," you believe it. If you're depressed, you might not believe it, but you typically believe it. And you believe it so much that it's very easy for people to manipulate you via what we call ingratiation or butt-kissing.
- 3.20** I'll give an example for myself. I remember this is back in grad school at Chapel Hill, and I'd never taught intro psych before, and I was a grad student. This nice girl comes in my class, in my office. She goes, "I really want to get into your class. I've heard what a great professor you are, and I know this is going to be the greatest class ever, and I really want to get in." And I'm like, "Of course, I'm the greatest. Oh, my god, you are so in. I don't care if there's 500 people in here." And then she leaves, I go, "I never taught that class before." She just lied. But I totally believed it because I'm an idiot.
- 3.21** But I'm not—because somebody gave me positive information, I was so happy to drink that up. It was like, "Yeah, I really crushed this class." Dude, I've never taught it before. I can't believe I'm fooled, she fooled me. So praise can manipulate us, and it can be a

problem. The other thing we see, as I said, people don't want to tell bad news. There's a fancy name for this called the mum effect, but it's essentially, no one wants to be the bearer of bad news. There's historical stories of this.

- 3.22** You go tell the king, "Yeah, we lost the war," and the king just kills you. So you're like, "Hey, why don't you go tell the king how things went? I'll stay out here with the cows." People aren't going to tell you. You're like, "Give it to me straight." No one's giving it to you straight. You maybe have one friend who's going to give it to you straight, and it's going to hurt. But most of your friends aren't going to tell you the truth. They just don't want to be mean.
- 3.23** At the same time that people don't want to be mean, no one wants to hear about your success. You think everyone wants to hear about your success, but they don't really want to hear it. So if you come in, "Oh, my goodness, I was just down in Miami. Oh, I saw all these beautiful people. I ate a steak, I golfed, the best ever," they're like, "I hate you." They're just, like, knife you. You're like, "Why are you knifing me? I just wanted to share my good feelings." I shouldn't have done that. Not everybody's like this.
- 3.24** But what you find in life—and this is a strange thing because most of us don't think about it—it's very hard to find someone where you can share success with who embraces and appreciates your success, even if you're outshining them. We call this capitalization. It's a weird word, but I want somebody I can capitalize my good feelings with. Turns out, people we have strong relationships with, that we can do that, this is a really powerful thing in a relationship, and it's just hard to find somebody you can—again, when someone comes in, it's like, "I'm just crushing it," you're like, "dude, I'm not." And somebody's like, "I'm crushing it." For you to go, "That's awesome. I really am glad you are," that means a lot to people, and it's hard to find.
- 3.25** It's hard to share good news and have people even acknowledge it. Bottom line is, this positive feedback is nebulous, and it's not really great information all the time. It's either too positive or they ignore the real positive to give you some fake positive, and we're easily manipulated by it. Negative information is really tough, too. The first thing you find with negativity is this asymmetry, in that bad is stronger than good. This is how Roy Baumeister put it. There's other ways of putting this, but essentially bad stuff, bad news, bad experiences, negative events, failure, is more powerful than good events, success, or winning.
- 3.26** The simplest way you see this is in behavioral economics with what's called prospect theory. It's essentially that losses hurt more than rewards feel good. Generally, people don't like to lose. Here's an example that's going to work better. This is the one I like to use. Imagine heaven and hell. So if you say, "What's heaven?" And people go, "Heaven is awesome. It's got clouds and my grandmother's there, and it's God's love, and there's angel music, and it's hard to explain. It's so great." You're like, "That sounds really nice." I mean, I had a better weekend, but still that sounds really good.

- 3.27** And then you're like, "Describe hell." And they're like, "Well, you starve to death and then you're hungry and thirsty because they're burning you with sulfur and poking you with pitchforks, and then you can't drink water because they take it from you, and then ants eat your brain, and then they throw you in hot lava, and they bring you back." You're like, "That sounds just awful. I don't ever want to do hell." Hell is so much worse than heaven is good. That's the asymmetry of life.
- 3.28** Imagine a relationship. What's the nicest thing your partner could do for you? "Well, my partner invited me to Paris and we went to the Eiffel Tower and I got a balloon and it was a ring and it was great." What's the worst thing your partner could do to you? Oh, god, it could be really bad. I mean, people are evil. There's an asymmetry in good or bad information. One of the challenges, negative information is very tough to take, and it's very tough to process, and we don't get it very well. When we get negative information about ourselves socially, it often triggers these emotional reactions. There are these classic social emotions related to the self that have to do with negative feedback.
- 3.29** So embarrassment, classic one. Hey, Keith, you did something like when I just did my example there of prospect there and just was like, oh, my god, that was horrible. I felt so ashamed. Now, I felt embarrassed. Now, if I had done a full embarrassment thing, I'm professional, I hid it. But had I done it right, I'd do an expression. I'd look down, I might cover my face. Then I glance around, I'd do a little smile. Hey, are you guys laughing? Oh, no, they're pissed. OK. Anyway, it's like you're hiding yourself a little bit. Embarrassment is about making this faux pas, but the thing with doing a faux pas is it's usually not so bad.
- 3.30** If everybody laughs, you're like, OK. You do something bad. If I just burp right now and everybody laughed, I'm like, oh, thank god. But if there was like, "Shame," you're like, "No." So that stuff is bad, and you get guilt, which is another thing. This is when you do things you know are bad; you just do mean things. You do something wrong with your family, something wrong, and you feel bad about yourself. What's nice about guilt is you can resolve guilt by reparation. You can say, "Man, I'm really sorry I did that bad thing. I apologize, and I'm going to give you a gift certificate to Chuck E. Cheese as a token to show you that I still care, and I'm not a bad person." The person is, "Yeah, I your apology. We're good."
- 3.31** Guilt is another one of these social emotions when we hit negative stuff about ourselves that we can deal with fine. Shame is the problem. Shame is where we start to shut down. Shame is the negative emotion associated with the self that encompasses your entire being. I am a bad person. I do something wrong and I feel ashamed. I feel shame. What that means is, "Man, I am a bad person. I just feel shame. I'm bad." What can you do about being a bad person? Not much. Not much you can do. I'm just a bad person. I can try to be a good person, but that's really hard.

- 3.32** It's very easy for me to say, "Sorry, here's a Chuck E. Cheese voucher." It's hard for me to say, "I'm a bad person. I'm going to change that." It's hard. You get negative feedback, you get into shame, and then shame can transition to depression. What you find with depression is that the self's—and this is classic cognitive behavioral therapy of depression, going back to Aaron Beck—is that you start having these negative, skewed views of the past, present, and future. When you're depressed, you're like, "I'm a bad person. I was bad in the past, and my future isn't going to be good because I'm not going to make it good."
- 3.33** You can get in this really negative spiral about yourself because of negative information and feelings of shame, negative feelings about the self. But it's not giving you accurate information at all. It's taking you off the course of accurate information, and you're basically telling yourself a really bad story about yourself. So, positive information is tough because the social information is tough to take. Negative social information is tough to take. We just deal with this stuff poorly.
- 3.34** One of the solutions to that, for self-knowledge, is using some sort of outcome-based measure that's less judgmental, less social. We have lots of examples of those that we've made. We have standardized tests. If I want to know my personality, I can take a Big Five test, or I can take a Myers-Briggs, or I can do whatever you kids do, and an Enneagram test, and I still don't know what that thing means, or you can take a horoscope, but you can take some sort of test, and some are good and some are bad, but it will tell you something about yourself. This is a useful way of getting knowledge about yourself.
- 3.35** But again, you take an SAT score and you don't do well, you're like, "Yeah, I'm not a good test-taker." You do really well and you're like, "God, that's a great test. Best test ever." Even with standardized tests, it's hard for us to believe in them unless they tell us what we want to hear. Another way we can do this is actual performance, like just going out there and doing stuff. One of my friends is a great motivational researcher, Andy Elliott. He was a huge believer in competition. He said the thing about competition, individual competition, is it's clean. You come out and you're like, "I am better than you, or you are better than me."
- 3.36** When you go through a direct competition with somebody, you go through it, you have a boxing match or a tennis match or a chess match or whatever it is, you learn something about how you relate to that person. Now, if it's Georgia playing Alabama, no way Georgia lost. It was a bad call, and I blame the team and everything else. But if it's you versus another person, you get some pretty clean insight into yourself. One of my favorite ways to get self-knowledge, to learn about yourself, is what are called natural consequences. That's the old-school term. It's going out in the world and having the world respond to you.
- 3.37** Classic example of this is a child reaches up, grabs a hot pan or grabs a hot stove, and burns herself or himself, and doesn't do that again. Natural consequence. I don't need

to tell my kid not to grab hot stuff on the stove. They learn that pretty fast. But you have this in all sorts of life. You have this in athletics. You have it in golf. I don't know why I keep thinking about golf. You have it in golf. You have it in surfing. When I was thinking about this, one of my favorite times, natural consequences, I was snowboarding, and this is a long time ago. Snowboarding down in New Zealand. The Hawaiians go down there to snowboard, the big wave guys.

- 3.38** The snow wasn't very good. I met these two Hawaiian guys, and I thought they were really cool because they're Hawaiian surfers, and I can't surf Sunset. They're like, "dude, the snow's bad, but we're going to go do these avalanche chutes." I'm like, "Well, that sounds cool. I'll go do some." I'm high openness, right? I'll go do avalanche chutes. I don't know what that means. We climb up to the top of the mountain, and then we go, OK, we're jumping, dropping off the back. I'm like, "OK, this looks cool." I don't know if —there's probably not a lot of snowboarders here because this is Miami.
- 3.39** But the way an avalanche chute works is, it's usually a tight little pocket up front. You got to hit two or three turns and you got to hit them right, and then it opens up and you get some turns. I'm with these guys and I'm like, "I can't not do this because I'll be so ashamed. I would have to commit ritual suicide." I go for it. I jump in, I pull this thing off, and I end up at the bottom of this chute. I'm like, "Oh, my god, I feel so good about myself." I'm like, "Now what? Where do we go?" And they're like, "Now we climb back up." I'm like, "Oh, my god." So, take snowboard, pull yourself up, pull yourself up, climb up the chute.
- 3.40** And I'm dead. So I'm like, "I'm out of here, guys. This is great." I go down the other side of the mountain. It was so rocky. I make it to the bar. I remember eating, I remember I got banana bread with chocolate. It was the best thing I've ever had in my life. But I learned so much from those natural consequences of what I was capable of and what I wasn't capable of. I learned my limits. I learned I was not as cool as the Hawaiian Sunset Beach snowboarders, but I knew I could keep up with them a little bit, and I felt pretty good about that, but I knew where I was.
- 3.41** No one made any judgment about it at all. No one I knew was there. There was no sideline, there was no audience. There was nothing, just me and, I guess, the dudes. But they were even gone at the end. I think those natural consequences are such a great way to learn about yourself without social pressure. You just learn who you are. Talking to my brother yesterday. He's like, "dude, I was surfing, and it was 10 feet, and I was just gassed out there. What happens when you get old?" Because he's turning 50. I'm like, "dude, you're 50, surfing 10-foot waves. It's going to happen. You get tired. You're getting old." Natural consequences.
- 3.42** There's no judgment. He's calling me like, "What happened when you were a loser?" That's essentially what he was asking. I mean, really, "How did you handle becoming weak?" Well, you just change. You get into golf. I love natural consequences for self-knowledge. I think those are one of the most important things because it gives you

some very pure information about yourself. Another way we do this culturally is through role transition, identity, you call it initiation processes. So, we are transformed through social processes of initiation into something else.

3.43 What are these kind of processes? Well, one might be baptism. When you get older, it's going to be maybe confirmation, a bar mitzvah, high school graduation, college graduation. You go to a high school graduation, a big public school, it's awesome. Why is it awesome? Because this is a big deal. This is a huge milestone for everybody. Everybody's families are there, and their extended families are there, and everybody's happy, because somebody just changed. They just morph from somebody who's a high school student to a high school graduate. College is the same thing.

3.44 Marriage. Marriage is a ceremony. I mean, there's a reason. Well, a marriage is a legal relationship, and you can go to the courthouse and sign a piece of paper and be married. But most of us, if we get married, decide to do ceremonial magic. We bring our family, we bring God, we bring everybody to watch, we do a ceremony, we get a priest or a rabbi or somebody to do it. Maybe it's our friend who's a ship captain, whatever. We say some stuff, we do magic, and we do it in front of our friends and family. We become—like, we publicly announce we're husband and wife, and that's a ceremony. It's initiation, it's a transition into becoming a married person. You change during that process.

3.45 But if you don't go through that initiation, you don't really feel the change. You don't really know who you are because you didn't go through the process. I'm not saying if you got married in a courthouse, you're not really married. I mean, just saying there's a reason we have a graduation ceremony. There's a reason we have a marriage ceremony. There's a reason we have a confirmation ceremony. It's a ceremony to mark a transition.

3.46 The general pattern of changing the self through these transitions is towards maturity and stability. When you go through transition, confirmation, graduation, marriage, whatever these transitions are, you're becoming a more mature person and you're integrating with society more. You're changing to become an adult who's integrated with society. The challenge when this happens is, we get initiated into a new role, and sometimes you go, "I'm not in this role." You're just a single dude, you're all stoked, and then next thing you know, you're married, and you're like, hey, married dude. You're like, what? Hey, wife, what? It seems weird, right? The whole thing seems weird.

3.47 My example, I always think of when I was made a department head, academic department, I was like, really? You would give me this power? I sent my buddy who was department head at another university, and he just sent me back a link to the special song, The Lunatics Have Taken Over the Asylum. It was just literally a link, and I just hit it. It was just an old ska song you guys wouldn't know, but the lunatic, I was like, yeah, that's imposter syndrome. After five years, you're like, "Yeah, I'm bored. I could do this

in my sleep." But when you start out doing something, you feel fake. That's normal because you're moving into another role.

- 3.48** When you're going in that process of learning of yourself, there's going to be these transition or phase change. Remember dynamic systems, like a phase change. There's a phase change going on, and it doesn't feel real. You feel like an imposter. If you're really narcissistic, you're probably not going to feel like an imposter. You're like, yeah, I should have been dean. They're lucky to have me. But my general feeling with imposter syndrome is that, if you're feeling like an imposter, you're probably on the right path because it means you're pushing yourself to be something else. But it's interesting.
- 3.49** The cultural transition piece is really interesting for learning about ourselves. These initiations are really powerful for learning about ourselves. Then you get this reversed existential approach where rather than—it's rather than learning about ourselves, we create ourselves. The Freudian formula for self-knowledge is to look through the mystery, to get through the mystery, get through the Maya, get through the illusion and see the self. That's one approach.
- 3.50** The existential approach to self-knowledge is that existence precedes essence, meaning you have to act and then you become. You act something and then you become the thing. It's not that you're David that gets revealed, but you create who you are in the process. It's a different way of thinking about the self, but instead of finding yourself, you create yourself through the challenges. Different psychologists have talked about this.
- 3.51** Viktor Frankl, when he talked about some of his writings from the concentration camp—this stuff is heavy—but he developed, I guess, a form of psychology called logotherapy. And what he said was he's in a concentration camp, World War II. And he goes, even here, some people get real bad, and it brings out the worst in them, and some people it brings the best out of them. Even in this horrible environment, it's like the Gita. It's like even in war, you see God. Even in a concentration camp, you see the best of people.
- 3.52** And he argued that by adding—this is an interesting metaphor—the metaphor of an arch. Imagine you build a brick arch, it's weak. But if you put more weight on that arch, if you start building a wall on top of it, that arch gets stronger and stronger and stronger as it compacts. So what he said about the self is if you can take more weight onto the self, you're giving yourself meaning, you're becoming a stronger person because it's this antifragility in a way. You're becoming stronger by taking on the stress.
- 3.53** He talks about a patient comes in, he's depressed because his wife died. He goes, "Well, how would your wife feel if you died first and she was alone?" The guy goes, "I bet my wife would feel terrible, probably worse than I would." He goes, "Isn't it great that you're taking that pain from your wife?" Wow, I'm cured. I went from somebody

suffering to somebody who's got meaning. All I did was add meaning to my suffering. I added weight to what I was doing.

- 3.54** This existential approach of self-creation is really an important part of self-discovery. You've got to create who you are a little bit. It's not like you just magically turn into this—well, maybe you do what do I know? But I don't think you magically turn into this psychedelic butterfly. I think there's a process that you go through, and there's a creation process. If you're into this, this existential psychology is a weird—I mean, there are people like Medard Boss. These are like Swiss psychoanalysts back in the day—Binswagner. But I think if you're interested in this, reading Camus is probably the most accessible.
- 3.55** Camus' essay on Sisyphus. Sisyphus was condemned to roll a rock uphill. That was what he's condemned to do. And in Camus' essay on Sisyphus, Sisyphus is up there pushing that rock, and every time he gets to the top, the rock rolls down. And Camus ends it. He's like, I imagine Sisyphus smiling. He's doing this. It doesn't really seem to have a purpose, but he's putting meaning into it. And by putting meaning into it, it becomes him. It becomes magic. So these existential ideas about self-creation, and I think are really important in finding ourselves, and I'll get to some of that in a second with James.
- 3.56** I talked about this general bias to positivity or beneficence or self-centeredness. It's a general bias. In the psychoanalytic world, in the Jungian world, in the Freudian world, this process is really—people really spend a lot of time looking at this. It's essentially: How do people cope with the negative aspects of their self? How do we acknowledge or integrate or deal with the negative aspects of ourself?
- 3.57** In the Jungian psychological tradition—this is talking about archetypes—we have the archetype of the shadow. In Jung's tradition, he imagined there's a self, there's an ego that's conscious, and then there's another part of yourself that maybe is something that's the opposite of you in certain ways. That might be called your shadow. It's a bit like the Freudian id, but it's a little more personified.
- 3.58** One of the classic literary examples is Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde. This is a story of a non-integrated shadow. The story of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde is actually a true story, apparently, of some guy in Edinburgh who everyone thought was a good dude. Then at night, he'd get hammered and break into people's houses. I don't know if he'd drink. He'd just do nefarious stuff, but he was controlling all the keys and things. Basically, he had this really good face, and then he had this dark side. In the book, Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde, it's this doctor who drinks this potion, and he becomes this simian creature running around and doing bad stuff, and he cracks up—I gave it away. But he doesn't have a healthy integration with the shadow.
- 3.59** There's lots of examples. They use this in movies all the time. There's usually a character, and then there's a sidekick who's a bit of a troublemaker and maybe a trickster, but also helps them get through things. Hulk? Hulk? Yes. Hulk, that's a great

example of a character who has a shadow side. He's literally a doctor. He's Dr. Jekyll. That's who he is. Yeah, he's literally a doctor who has this shadow side that's angry and aggressive, but is also prosocial. To the extent he can integrate that angry, dark, aggressive side, he can help the world. That's great. But that's his chart of who am I? He's starting off going, I'm two people. What is it, Dr. Banon or something? He's like, I'm a normal doctor, and I'm this angry, crazy guy.

- 3.60** That's what they call shadow work. When you talk to your clinician buddies, they're hanging out in their yoga clothes. "Yeah, we're doing some shadow work." That's what you're doing. You're dealing with this darker side of yourself. That's one of the challenges to self-knowledge, and that's a process.
- 3.61** In the Freudian school, they talked about it, but they talk more about defense mechanisms. How do we defend against these impulses? Freud's daughter, Anna, Anna Freud, ended up doing all this work on the mechanisms of defense. You've heard about a lot of these. But essentially in the Freudian model, you'd have these wishes or impulses—maybe aggressive like the Hulk, maybe sexual, maybe it's just food. Like I just want to eat. You got to deal with those impulses.
- 3.62** They came up with different mechanisms people use. Classic ones were like, denial. "No, I'm not angry at all. I'm the calmest person you've ever seen angry. I'm really calm, totally chill." The person just shaking, blood pressure like 400. That's denial. Repression is like denial, but a little more active. I'm just keeping this down like, "I'm not angry [grunts angrily]." OK. It's like repressed anger. Projection is like transference as an example of projection, but it's projecting your unconscious onto other people.
- 3.63** Reaction formation. It's doing the opposite of what you say you're going to do. A lot of the Southern preachers, God bless them, but you go, "dude, you seem a little sus," as the kids say. You're like, "Yeah, I'm really just a family man." I'm like, "dude, I don't know. I don't know what you're doing at those motels late at night, but I'm guessing your kids aren't hanging out at the Bulldog Motel with you." So you get some problems there.
- 3.64** And then some others that are scarier. One is intellectualization. And there's this Stalin quote, something I always mix it up. "One death is a tragedy and a million is a statistic," something like that. It's essentially that when we take things that are painful or powerfully emotional, and we just turn them into something intellectual, and then we can just deal with it. Believe me, I can do this because that's what academics do. You can talk about horrific things like war without feeling emotion. Like, "yeah, it's just numbers on a board." I'm like, "dude, every one of the person had a mom, every one of those people is a baby, and they could be—". Just numbers. So intellectualizing, that keeps us away from our self. It cuts us off from our emotional self.
- 3.65** Then there's some healthier ways of integrating the shadow side that Freud talked about. One is sublimation. This is a classic way of doing it. The idea is you take these

unconscious impulses and you put them into your work to make something better. The old story about American football as repressed homosexuality, and we're guys dressed in tights running into each other's end zones. I mean, there's a whole theory of this. I'm not just making it up. Talked to some football players about it and one of them just kissed his buddy. It's like, yeah.

- 3.66** The idea of art being an expression of passion or lust. There's these examples of people like, well, there's a great Woody Allen movie. I think it's called New York Stories. One of the stories was about a self-centered New York artist who'd start relationships with people that were really destructive, and then he'd use that energy to put into his art. You see artists, I mean, well, I'm not talking about Taylor Swift because she's the best. I never criticize Beyoncé or Taylor Swift, ever. They're the best. But somebody like Taylor Swift could have a lot of relationships and then use that to write music. That's sublimation. It's taking something negative and then it's turning it like lead into gold into something positive. It's alchemizing something positive.
- 3.67** Then humor is another way of dealing—with humor. Humor is a way of dealing with tension. Freud wrote a whole book on humor in the relationship, in relation to the unconscious. A lot of our humor is stuff that we can't really say consciously that we can laugh about. It allows us to express these things in a socially appropriate way. I think people are starting to laugh. It'll be about 10 years where humor went away, and I think it's coming back a little bit. I get the sense this happens. Culture cycles in and out of humor. I think we might be coming back into humor. But humor is a really good way of dealing with this unconscious stuff. It's painful, and so we just laugh about it a little bit. And that can be healthy, or not, if you're laughing at people.
- 3.68** The defense mechanisms are one way we integrate these parts of ourselves that we don't really want in ourselves. There are less healthy ways of doing it, like saying, "that's not me, it's you." That's unhealthy. The healthier ways are things like humor or sublimation, integrating the things into us. That's it. I should say, yeah, if you're interested in Freud and sublimation, I recommend his writings on Leonardo da Vinci.
- 3.69** He wrote a fascinating monograph on the painting of the Mona Lisa and sublimation and stuff. Artists are really—Freud was really interested in artists because he said artists were people who lived in their fantasy world, basically useless individuals. But once they were able to project that fantasy and to create an object out of that, they became useful. It was this weird way of development via projection of fantasy into reality. It's neat. Anyway.
- 3.70** Yeah, I guess that's now cognitive dissonance. When we talk about cognitive dissonance, it's essentially rationalization. Cognitive dissonance is like, "I'm a good person, but I did that bad thing. Oh, there must have been another reason I did that bad thing. I was drinking too much." Or, "Oh, that bad thing wasn't really that bad." Or, "I won't ever do that again. I'm sorry." I guess that would work, too. But cognitive dissonance is just, it's very much like a defense mechanism, but more cognitive.

- 3.71** There are these approaches to trying to understand who you are, but I think we are leaving a question I'm not answering, but I'm raising occasionally, which is: Is there a true self that you actually find? Or is the process of finding yourself, true self, really the process of creating your true self? Meaning, like I said, is there something in there that you were born with, the psychedelic butterfly, and you're like, dude, I just got to find that thing, and once I find it, I'm good. Or is life this complicated process of creating a self? It's more existential. It's more something you could do. My sense is that both of these things are happening. We're both finding ourselves. We're finding ourselves through engaging in the world, but we're also creating ourselves.
- 3.72** William James is much smarter and a better writer than me—put it this way. So I'm going to read one of my favorite William James passages about the true self. "Not that I would not, if I could, be both handsome and fat and well-dressed, and a great athlete, and make a million a year, be a wit, a bon vivant, and a lady-killer, as well as a philosopher; a philanthropist, statesman, warrior, and African explorer, as well as a 'tone poet' and saint. But the thing is simply impossible. The millionaire's work would run counter to the saint's; the bon vivant and the philanthropist would trip each other up; the philosopher and the lady-killer could not well keep house in the same tenement of clay. Such different characters may conceivably at the outset of life be alike possible to a man. But to make any one of them actual, the rest must more or less be suppressed. So the seeker of his truest, strongest, deepest self must review the list carefully, and pick out the one on which to stake his salvation."
- 3.73** My goodness, James could write. What James is saying there is he's saying, I'm really high in openness to experience, and I really want to be a philosopher, and I want to be a millionaire, and I want to be a lady-killer in a tone poet—which I've had to look up 25 times, and I still forget what a tone poet is—and an explorer. And I can't do it. So I got to just pick one and stake my salvation on that. Basically, he's saying that the true self is something that we find and we create. We have this list of options. We have this hand of cards we're dealt, and we choose one.
- 3.74** What did William James do during his life? Well, he explored the Amazon. He became the greatest psychologist in America—totally underappreciated. Then he wrote the greatest theological book in American history, maybe—The Varieties of Religious Experience—so he became a theologian. And a philosopher. He started the philosophy of pragmatism, the great American philosophy. So basically, James did everything. He didn't do what he said. He did everything, and did too much and was an open guy, and that was William James.
- 3.75** So what he's saying he's doing and what he's doing are a kind of different things. But I think this idea of an effortful process of figuring out who you are and just making a choice, just saying this is me, I think is pretty important. I think that's pretty important in the process of figuring out who you are.

- 3.76** When people have looked at this in more modern research—you ask people if they feel close to their true self—there's different ways people have done this. Here's what you find. Generally, when you ask people if they feel close to their true self, being close to your true self feels good. Most of us think our true self is kind of good and moral. It's not an evil true self, typically. We tend to, if we feel close to our true self, we think other people are good and moral, and their true selves are good and moral. So generally, there's a belief that the true self is a good self. This is all Greek, the beautiful, the virtuous, and the true all kind of go together. So that's how we see about the self.
- 3.77** Feeling close to the true self is associated with meaning and purpose. So if you feel connected with your true self, you're like, "My life has meaning and has purpose. This is who I meant to be." If you're not connected to your true self, what are you doing? "Dude, I don't know. I'm just going through the motions. I'm having fun. I'm working as a bellhop. It's my favorite job ever." But it's not a meaningful thing. It can be fun, but true self has more meaning to it.
- 3.78** The example I think of here is the—I was talking about Arthur Miller before—but his play, *The Crucible*, which is about the Salem witch trial. It's a new version of that. I haven't read it in a long time. But as I recall, the lead character has a choice. He has to admit he's a witch or he has to just suck it up and get crushed to death. His struggle is to be who he is and just say, I'm not a witch, or to just say he's a witch and get out of some of the suffering. And what he does is he doesn't say he's a witch. He basically affirms his identity, and he is tortured, crushed. But in the process of doing that, he becomes who he is. It's a very existential moment. He becomes who he is. Now, in the real story, I think some of it was like if he admitted [he was] a witch, his wife wouldn't get any of the money. There was some other stuff going on there.
- 3.79** But it's a very existential story about when they come for you, are you going to be like, "Yeah, I'm with you. Sorry, I hate those witches. Yeah, going to kill them." Or are you going to stand up for what you know is true? The answer is you don't know until it happens. That's the problem with life. We all have this fantasy of what we're going to do. When we're tested, we don't know what we're going to do. But after we go through it, we learn who we are. I think that I always like that example. The true self is something that we learn through this process of being challenged, and you face an opposition, and that's it.
- 3.80** There's some other interesting ideas of this. One line of research looked at the idea of transparency in the true self. They found that people who feel closer to their true self are more transparent. They're easier to see, they're easier to read. They're not being duplicitous. They're not lying. They're like, "Here I am. I'm authentic. This is it. Take it or leave it." There's an authenticity to it. But I like the term transparent. There's this classic work, the transparent self, I think is neat. I mentioned other baby boomers got really into their self, and finding themselves and all that. My students don't find themselves as much anymore. They're trying to get jobs, but back in the day.

- 3.81** When researchers—this is work by Ralph Turner or other sociologist, this is, I think, out of UCLA—but they ask people: When do you feel your true self? When do you feel the most resonant with who you are? What's really interesting is you can get a couple of different paths that come out.
- 3.82** You get one group of people that feel their true self in a social a role. They might join the military. I keep going back to the Marines, but I was actually thinking the French Foreign Legion. I read a really interesting story from a French Foreign Legionnaire, and he said, "I never felt myself until I joined the French Foreign Legion." He goes, "because every single choice was taken from me. I had everything told what to do, and I had to adopt this role, and I felt this role was meant for me. This is who I am." That's one way of becoming a true self.
- 3.83** The other way is almost the opposite. It's like, "I was at a rave, or whatever the kids call them now at a party, and everyone was on some drugs, and we were listening to music and dancing, and it was ecstatic. And I felt like just for a second, this is really me." It's a loss of self. It's like Dionysian. It's like an ecstatic experience, which kind of means self-loss. My advisor told me that. He was Greek. I don't know, I don't know the root. Some people feel their true self when they lose their self and feel connected to this spirit of the moment or the—what's the word? Anyway, the communal experience, the effervescence of the experience. Some people feel themselves when they're in these really tight social roles and they feel true.
- 3.84** Both of those things work. There doesn't seem to be one route to get there. It seems people take different routes—some more socially structured, some less socially structured—to feel real.
- 3.85** Then I thought I'd conclude with some thoughts on authenticity. We use a lot of terms with the self: the authentic self, the real self, the true self, the transparent self. They're all capturing the same thing as, is there a me that I'm meant to be that's the right thing? And are there other me's that I'm not meant to be, that are the wrong me? And so researchers looking at this—this is a classic self-research looking at authenticity. It's worked on by a friend of mine who's passed away, Mike Kernis. And what they noticed in this was that you see these different features in people who are more authentic. At least the people that describe themselves as more authentic have some different qualities. They outlined four of them.
- 3.86** The first is self-awareness. So people who are authentic or self-aware, and that includes awareness of strengths and limitations. So one of the biggest things you see with authenticity is authentic people know they have weaknesses. They're like, yeah, they're just comfortable with that. This is something they talk about a lot in the humanistic psychology. But it's that comfort with one's strengths and weaknesses. Essentially, "I've done my shadow work." I've done enough shadow work that I'm comfortable with who I am. I'm usually not good. Usually when you meet people, they're good and bad. Most people aren't purely good.

- 3.87** I've never met a purely good person. I'm trying to think. Maybe I did. Maybe a lama or something. I once got blessed by a—I was in Tibet a long time ago and I went to see a lama. They're like, we're going to meet the lama. I was all excited. This lama was going to tell me something. I thought I could ask a question to the lama. So I get up to this hill in this monastery and walk in this room, and the lama is sitting there on his big throne, and he's about two and a half years old. So there's a two-and-a-half-year-old-kid sitting in a lotus position on his throne with a picture next to him of himself in his past life, a photo, and then a painting of him in the life before that, and life before that— like, what do I do?
- 3.88** And so what you do when you meet a lama is you give him a khata, like a white cloth. I don't know if you still do this, as I remember. I went up and I bowed. I gave this kid a cloth and he took this little Buddha statue, and he blessed me on the head. "I got that going for me," in the words of Bill Murray. But I don't know why I told that story. Maybe he was good. I haven't met many enlightened lamas. Most people are good and bad, it's a mix.
- 3.89** So one is this self-awareness, another is unbiased processing. So the idea with somebody who's authentic is they're processing information really in a not-biased way. So when people say negative stuff or positive stuff, you can take it without dumping a bunch of ego on it. "Keith, that talk sucked." "Sorry, you feel that way. What could I do to improve?" I would love to be able to do that. Like I said, "that talk sucked." I'm like, "I'll be back in a second [cries]." I'm like, "I'm all good. Good, yeah, no problem at all." But the idea that you could take that information.
- 3.90** I used to hang out with these New Agey-Californians that are like, they're like, you get mad at people. This line always gets me: "I'm so mad at you." "I'm sorry you feel that way." Oh, it took all the anger out of me. Gosh, I just want to be enraged, and you won't let me be enraged. I think there's something to that, that unbiased, that lack of distortion, that you're seeing the world as it is. There's less Maya, there's less mess.
- 3.91** Behavioral congruence. So aligning your behavior with your beliefs. This is a challenge for us, especially in certain times when people aren't very free. If you have a belief system and you align your behavior with that belief system, that's authentic. But if you're always lying about who you are to relate to people, that's less authentic. There's an alignment with behavior and values or behavior and beliefs. You shouldn't always. You should keep a lot of your beliefs hidden. I don't blame you for doing that. If you got crazy beliefs like I do, just lock them in a box. Don't tell anybody. You don't need to tell people. But you're living a bit of a false life because you're hiding a lot of stuff. You might have to for social reasons. With authenticity, there's more of a direct flow between who you are and who you present to the world.
- 3.92** Finally, there's this idea of authentic relational orientation. The idea here is that you enter relationships—this could be romantic relationships or friendships—but the orientation is towards honesty and transparency and truthfulness. This is hard because

you start dating somebody, your first move when you start dating somebody is like, "I'm going to be my real self." You go on your date, your first move is, "I'm bringing the A game to this date." If you're not, you shouldn't be on the date. When you go on a date with somebody, you're meeting the fakest freaking self they have, that they can put out there. "This is me. I'm cool. I look good. I'm groomed. I'm not wearing yoga shorts and flip flops. I'm being nice." That's what you're putting out there when you start a relationship. That's what you're supposed to do. It's called marketing.

3.93 But in a long term relationship, if every day you wake up and you got to do a sales pitch so your wife stays with you, it would be really hard. You imagine every morning, I'm like, excuse me, and I go and you have to do all this work, and then I come out ready to play my role. In a real authentic relationship, you want to know the good and bad because it makes it so much easier, and it's really nice to have somebody you can let your guard down with a little bit. But there's always a balance because romance is—you want romance—it's a little ideal. It's always a balance. But authenticity is about, it's about not being fake. It's about being real, being authentic.

3.94 That is pretty much my conclusion for self-knowledge. It's an important thing, and I wish that self-knowledge were something that you could just go find, that it was easy to find, that you could that you could just look inward, that you could just ask somebody, that you could just take a test. None of those things work. Self-knowledge is a lifetime process, goal, challenge. I don't even know if you can actually get there. Maybe what you get is a balanced self that feels authentic and works pretty well and the energy is flowing and that's the best you can get. Maybe there is no true self-defined, but that's the research.

3.95 To what degree can you know other people? I guess the other, the way I'm thinking about it, but the other self.

3.96 That's a fascinating question, is: to what extent can I know a true self and another person? And how do I know I know the true self in another person? I'm going to say it's something I'm going to try to hit on a little bit when I talk about relationships. There's a very rare event that happens that's called the eye sharing, which every once in a while, there's a sense that consciousness merges and people feel really deeply connected with each other. So sometimes people have those experiences together.

3.97 Sometimes it's going through an experience with somebody that's really stressful, where you go, "this person's acting this way, this person's acting this—I know who this person is". It's like guys that go to military, war, together. And afterwards, we're so tight because we've gone through all this stuff together. So we've seen each other at our worst and our best. So there are ways you can do it, but I think it's hard, and I think it often takes extreme circumstances and challenges to really know who you're dealing with.

- 3.98** I have so many questions, but I can only pick one. The psychology of war. In wartime, things change for people and their personalities. Like you were saying, sometimes in your circumstances is when you can really find out who you are. But what if you have to choose survival over your— For instance, I can't be a martyr. I have two children. So let's say they say, "well, you have to do this in order to come with our group and survive," or you have to become who you really are. Obviously, I'm probably going to fake it to then fit in and not get killed or save my children. So how do you deal with—you're not going to put your personality over your survival many times, but what can we do right now that there's a huge psychology of war in the world? What can we do to stay humorous or stay positive when there's constantly a—
- 3.99** That's such a good question. The first thing I thought of is a woman I knew growing up who, coming out of World War II, lost one of her kids, hiding from the Nazis, and basically smothered a child because the child was crying. I'm sorry, this hurts me, and I haven't heard the story for 45 years. People are forced to do things for survival that they just are forced to do.
- 3.100** One thing that makes that tolerable is you go, "I'm not doing it. I'm not doing this because I want to do this. I'm not doing this because it's my choice. I'm doing this because I got to do it to survive. I got to do it to survive because I got a family. I got to take care of somebody else, and my needs aren't really what's important, and myself isn't what's important. Because it's a survival situation, you— The story you're telling yourself is, "I'm doing this to survive, and that's OK," you got to, and every woman understands that. That movie *Alive*, the old book where that soccer team crashed in the Andes, and they're basically committing cannibalism. And people are horrified by that. I'm like, "dude, I'd eat my—if I'm dead, eat me, man. I know that's fine. You just got to get out of here." But people get pushed in those situations.
- 3.101** I wish I had a really good answer for it because we are in a time of war, and we are in a time where people are trying to figure out how to survive. And it's very, very stressful for people. This is a very, very, very stressful time. How you keep your humanity, I think, is you find somebody or a group of people you can be yourself with, and you keep the flame lit with that group of people that you trust and care about. Whatever. Don't pick sides. It's like the reality is we all just got to find somebody that keeps us grounded and keeps us alive. That's my guess. Find your people, keep it hidden, go underground.
- 3.102** I'm curious about the boundaries of self, like the delineation of self. I work in psychedelic medicine. Stan Grof is one of my heroes. I'm trained in his protocol. It's like transpersonal psychology—the idea of a transpersonal self—especially when we enter transcendental states of consciousness. And so I'm just curious around your perception of that. What is the delineation of self and other? And what are the bounds of consciousness?

- 3.103** So like I said earlier, that as an organism, to keep a boundary around who you are—this is me, this is not me, good touch, bad touch, this is my space, this is not your space. That's the ego, and you have to have those boundaries. But in certain conditions where you feel psychologically safe, you set up a psychedelic space where you're going to try to open those boundaries up. What do you do? You make sure it's safe and protected. You do some sort of cleansing ceremony. You make sure the people there are good people, which is sometimes an issue, which is an issue sometimes. I just want to say that twice because that's where you get in problems. Then you let stuff happen and people can have those transpersonal experiences.
- 3.104** My sense with doing this is if you're going to have those experiences, you need to set a boundary that's broader than the individuals in it, like a container. If you're working in ayahuasca, you might all go in a maloca, like a round circle, and light of fire, and burn a bunch of incense, and throw a bunch of Florida water around and stuff just to make it—everyone smoking and just trying a lot of nicotine or tobacco—trying to keep a place safe. I think being really intentional about building a broader container for the individuals in that space will allow the individuals to communicate transpersonally without risk of something else entering the space.
- 3.105** Did that make any sense? I've never had that question before, but that actually may be a reasonable answer, isn't it? Yeah. This stuff gets gnarly. I've never met Stan Grof. I would call him Stanislav because I've never actually met him. But when you read his work, he started off studying psychiatry and psychedelic medicine and ended up studying the Vedas. This is why I say everyone ends up with yoga. When you ask him, "make a map of the mind," he's like, "we've got yoga." They already did it. That's one of those reasons I'm talking about yoga. But I've never met him, and he's still around. He'd be a cool guy to talk to. Yeah. Thanks.

Lecture 4: Models of Self-Control

At a glance — Models of self-control.

- 4.1 Welcome back. Today, we are in lecture 4 on the self, and the topic is going to be self-regulation, goal pursuit. Basically, one of the biggest challenges of a self, of an individual, is reaching goals, becoming the person you want to be. There's been a huge amount of work in this area. What I wanted to talk about today was, I'm going to try to give you some overviews of some of the key terms and some of the individual differences having to do with self-control, like agency and grit, self-efficacy, just a little bit. Then talk about some of the big motivations, like approach, avoidance, motivation, some of the big three models.
- 4.2 Then talk about things like willpower and self-control and self-regulation, which I'll quickly define in a second. We have all these selfie terms that all sound the same that are a little different and a little nuanced. When we think about self-control or reaching goals, it can happen at all sorts of levels. It can be like, I had to get up this morning and I was a little tired because I slept in, not like I usually do. I slept in till 8:00. I'm like, I don't want to get out of bed. But I had to get out of bed. That takes some self-control. It's overriding an impulse, so I had to get out of bed.
- 4.3 Then I'm like, well, I got to figure out what to wear. It's not like I got a lot of outfits. I have two outfits, but I had to do my pants and my shirt. It was real dark, and I'm not very good with colors. I had to do some longer-term plans. This is what I ended up with, guys. It's a blue theme, right? That's usually my go-to. That's longer-term self-regulation. Then I can think about, well, I got to do this class. What is this class going to mean? What is this going to mean in a year? What is this going to mean for my career? I don't know. But that's longer-term self-regulation.
- 4.4 When we're regulating, we're doing things at all these different levels. There's the immediate-term stuff, which is more like willpower, overriding impulses. There's the little longer-term things like self-control, and then things like self-regulation. Again, I'll dig into those in a little bit. But what I wanted to start with was some of the individual differences that we run into, talking about the self and self-control. When we talk about the self and self-control, or self-regulation, one of the big terms is self-efficacy. This is the sense, so self-efficacy is my own belief that I can achieve goals and overcome challenges along the way.
- 4.5 Somebody with a high degree of self-efficacy believes that they can meet goals effectively and overcome challenges. Somebody who has a low level of self-efficacy believes they can't. Like, "I can't do it. It's going to be too hard for me." So self-efficacy, which is a term you hear all the time in education, you hear all the time, well, business, not as much; they probably have a cooler word, but you hear it a lot in education. Being efficacious is the belief that you can achieve the goals you wanted here. It's not the

actual ability to do it, it's the belief that you can do it. It's like the self-concept that you can solve goals.

- 4.6 So self-efficacy is one of those traits that's relatively important for success. But because it's a belief, you can have the belief in yourself but not actually have the competence. You can have a lot of self-efficacy and not really be able to succeed as well because it's a belief. But usually, they go hand-in-hand. So efficacy is a big one. Another term we run across a lot in this literature is grit or grittiness. And this one, the business guys and the military people love grit. And this is an idea that was developed by Angela Duckworth. And the first paper, I think, was actually West Point graduates. It was looking at military. I'm trying to remember reading that back in a Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, back in the day.
- 4.7 But what they were looking at is, people who have a personality trait or personality style of being able to overcome hard challenges to get to a goal in a tenacious way, being gritty. In personality terms, this is an aspect or a facet of what we call conscientiousness that we talked about in the Big Five. It's a piece of that. It's, grit is really important for when you have people whose job it is to get the job done no matter what the cost. You've got to get this done. It's going to be hard. You want gritty people. That grit trait in special operations and things, that's what they're looking for a lot, is people who can just get a job done and they're not going to let anything stop them.
- 4.8 Grit is a really interesting trait for understanding self-regulation or self-control. It's just the ability to just grind through things. Another term I really like that people use is this term agency. So some people are high in a trait of agency. They're agentic individuals. They make stuff happen. Other people are less agentic. They're lower in agency. They don't seem to make stuff happen in their life. The term agency goes back to Alfred Bandura, who's the one who— or Albert Bandura. Alfred Bandura sounds like a king. Albert Bandura, and the same person who came up with self-efficacy. Agency is the bigger idea than self-efficacy.
- 4.9 What individual agency has, he breaks it down into four main components. This is what it takes to get things to happen in your life, to move yourself as an agent towards a goal. First thing is intentionality. You got to have a goal. You got to have something you're intending to get to. This is an issue. Lots of people don't have goals. They go, they have fun things, they have amusements, or they have vague ideas, but really being intentional about, "I want to be this. I want to learn this. I want to accomplish X, Y, and Z." There's this aspect of intentionality that's really important for being agentic.
- 4.10 If you don't have goals that you're intentional about, you're not going to really get where you want to be. That seems obvious, but it's sort tautological, but it's true. You need intent. You need what Bandura calls forethought, which is planning, thinking about yourself in the future, projecting yourself into the future. We'll talk about possible selves in a little bit, but it's the ability to say—I mean, this is what's really neat

about, well, a lot of things are neat about the human self. But one thing that's neat about ourselves is we can literally just project ourselves in the future 10 years.

- 4.11** I was just talking to people like, "Where do you want to retire?" I project that out 10 years. I can make a pretty good model of that. That can lead me to suffer because I'm like, "God, I'm not retired. I'm suffering." But it can also help me get where I want to be. So this forethought piece is really important. But then if you have the intent to get to a goal and you have a model of what that future goal is, you still need to do the steps to get there. The steps that, what Bandura calls this is self-reactiveness. It's a complex term, but essentially it means, if you have a long-term goal, you're going to have a lot of smaller goals along the way, and you're going to need to apply energy and will and effort to each of those small goals to get to that big goal.
- 4.12** If my goal is to move to Palm Beach and play golf at a golf course—they must have a really fancy golf course in Palm Beach; they would never let me in—but I imagine I find that course and my goal is to get to play that course, I can have a vision of myself as a golfer. I can do an image board of myself with some cool golf stuff on and stuff, and I can come up with a plan, but I'm going to have to work. I'm going to have to learn how to golf. I'm going to have to meet cool people. I'm going to have to build my brand. Maybe I'll get a publicist to do pictures of myself. I get a personal trainer. I'm getting into this. I get a personal trainer. I do a picture by a Lambo without a shirt on.
- 4.13** What do they call that? That ChatGPT visual stuff. They do a little mid-journey on me and like, "God, who's that good-looking Pitbull-wannabe guy down there?" And then I'm in, right? But I got to do all those steps to get to that course. That steps, that self-reactiveness piece, is really important to get there. It's not just visualize, it's the steps. And the final piece that Bandura talks about in agency is self-reflectiveness. This is what happens in life, is even when you have a goal and even when you have the steps, sometimes you have to pivot. One of my favorite inspirational quotes by Mike Tyson is, "Everyone has a plan until they get punched in the mouth." I mean, that is such a profound insight.
- 4.14** You have a goal. I'm going to be a golfer. Your goals will never, ever work the way you plan them. I've never met anyone who's like, "Yeah, I had this plan, and I just nailed it. Seamless." Never happens. The first thing that happens, you just get punched in the mouth. And so what you have to do is be able to adapt, be able to pivot, and you go like, "Yeah, this was a great plan. When I was 15, I really wanted to golf at Palm Beach because it sounded cool, but now I'm 35 and like, dude, I just get a little place inland and have a dog, and I'm pretty happy." And you can pivot and change your plans.
- 4.15** So, agentic goal regulation means not just getting where you want to be, no matter what. It means you can change your views along the way. Because as we've talked about several times before, the thing with the self is, as we change, our perceptions are changing, our values are changing, our wants are changing. So as we move towards goals, our actual selves are changing. Maybe when we get there, we don't want the

goal we had. Or maybe along the way, we realized it wasn't the right goal. So it's this complexity.

4.16 But anyway, I really like this idea of agency and being agentic, because just personally, I notice that lots of people want things. And then there's a subset of people who want things that actually try to get things. And even though I notice that most people who try to get things don't get what they're shooting for, they get something. They have an adventure, they learn something in the process, they have an active and engaged life. I like this concept of agency in the self.

4.17 We can think about these goals as involving ideas and concepts. This is my dream. I want to be a golfer. I want to be a psychologist. I want to do whatever. They also involve energy. We're energized to move to our goals in different ways. The most basic model of human energy towards goals is probably, let's say, call it approach. There's lots of names for these big two energies. I'm going to call them approach orientation and avoidance orientation, or reward-seeking and threat detection, or behavioral activation, behavioral inhibition. There's lots of different words. But essentially, we have some force that brings us to things and a force that pushes us away, like a brake and a gas pedal on a car, kinda. It's like a brake reverse pedal, but you get the idea.

4.18 We're built that way. There's lots of different theories that show it. One of the classic models of approach and avoidance, and you'll see this with goals all the time when I explain it to you, was done by Kurt Lewin. He's one of the famous early social psychologists in the US, I think came over before World War II, but maybe it was after, right around then. He talked about approach and avoidance motivation gradients. What does this mean? It means, when I have a goal in the future, I'm going to have part of me that's thinking about reasons I want to get that goal. That's the approach. And I'm going to have reasons about why I don't want that goal, why I'm nervous, what scares me about that, and that's going to be avoidance.

4.19 But these things work a little differently. When I'm way away from my goal, when my goal is in the distance, I think generally about it, and I tend to be more approach-oriented. I'm getting married next June. It's going to be awesome. We're going to do it with palm trees, and we're going to have a band, and it's going to be great. I can't think of anything bad. I'm going parachuting next June. How exciting is that going to be? We're going to jump out of an airplane together. I've never done that before. That's going to be great. That's approach orientation. So what happens?

4.20 Well, as the date gets closer, you start thinking more about what problems could go up. You go from more general thinking to more specific thinking. Holy gosh, who's going to do the flowers at the wedding? I don't think we're in begonia season. What are we going to do? Oh, my god. Aunt Mildred, she's drinking again, and she's sitting next to Uncle John. What if they get in a fight and ruin everything? So what happens is, when you get closer to the event, avoidance comes up. You start thinking about specific

things rather than general things, and you start thinking about what could go wrong. Does that make sense? It's a gradient changes.

- 4.21** In marriage, we call this cold feet because it sounds great when you get there, but when you get close, you're like, "Oh, my god, what have I done? This is all—" and so you want to bail. You want to go parachuting. It's all great. And you get on a plane. And if you've ever done this, what they tell you is like, "Hell no sounds like let's go." So meaning that once you're on that plane, they're jumping out with you no matter what you say, because no one wants to jump out of a freaking airplane. It sounds really good right now, but if we were right in the airplane going, "Who wants to go first?", you guys would be like, "Dude, you go, man. You can take that."
- 4.22** We're built with these two different brake and gas pedals. But what's interesting is the approach orientation is much more global and positive, and it works at a distance, and avoidance is more concrete and more negative. It works when you're closer. We've always got this weird tension in us where stuff sounds—it's like when I do these talks, when I'm at home, I'm like, "Oh, my god, I'm going to talk about Zen, and I'm going to talk about Kurt Lewin, and it's going to be great." Then I get here and I'm like, "Oh, my god, what did I do? This is insane." I can't explain this, so I apologize. That's approach avoidance.
- 4.23** That gradient, I think, is really important, and it can happen cognitively. People look at, have also looked at it from the animal side. This is work by Jeffrey Gray, primarily looking at motivational sets in nonhuman animals, rodent models of motivation. He came up with what we call reinforcer sensitivity theory. You end up with two big motivations, behavioral activation, which is BAS. I call it BAS, B-A-S, and behavioral inhibition, or behavioral inhibition system, BIS. He's arguing that there are two systems.
- 4.24** The approach-oriented system is the reward-based system, a lot like trait extroversion is related to behavioral activation, and behavioral inhibition is maybe more related to serotonin. I get mixed up here, so don't quote me on that. I get terrible with the brain stuff. It's more about threat detection. Again, we have both of these systems. The activation, I mentioned this before, this example, but this always gets me is, when I take Killarney for a walk and her behavioral activation system is activated. I'm going to go for a walk and she just starts bouncing up and down, just straight up and down. She's just wired to go for a walk. That's activation.
- 4.25** Inhibition is fear. I'm going to get away. I'm going to hide, skittishness, or get out of things. Both of those systems are really wired into our biology. They're just wired into how we work. It's something foundational. It's hard to imagine a— I'm trying to think if you can imagine something that wasn't like, "I want this, I don't want this." I don't know if we'd, I mean, that's just how—you look at paramecium under a microscope and they're going to things or going away from things. That's just how the world nature works, approach and avoidance.

- 4.26 Gray looked at it really from more of a biological basis. Tory Higgins looked at it from a real self perspective, and what he focused on was the ideal and ought self. He talked about the focus of the self, and he said that individuals could focus more on their ideal selves, like who they really want to be, that reflects their own interests, and that's going to be more approach-focused because it's what I want. Then other individuals are going to be more ought-focused and focused on the ought self. The ought self is the person I think I ought to be, meaning, this is who my mom or dad think I should be or my culture thinks I should be.
- 4.27 The ought self is a little more of an avoidance self. I got to do this so I don't get in trouble. I got to go to law school so my dad's nice to me or doesn't kick me out of the family or whatever. You have your self system, and sometimes you're driven to what you want, which is more approach-oriented, which is called the ideal self; you're reducing the ideal self discrepancy. I can mention that term later. Then ought self is approaching something that you think you have to do out of some fear of threat. That makes sense.
- 4.28 Then a final model, looking at this. This is one of Andy Elliott's models, but it's looking at coming at it from the competence and mastery and motivation literature. You find the same big two orientations. You find an approach orientation and an avoidance orientation. These seem to be linked with skills, and they also are linked to self-enhancement, which I'll get to in the next lecture or two. But essentially, approach orientations link to more positive views about yourself. "I'm going to do it. I'm awesome. I'm feeling good. Things are going to be great."
- 4.29 And avoidance motivations focus more with self-protection. "Oh, I'm a little scared. Hope this doesn't go wrong. I'm going to try not to let this happen. I'm going to try to avoid this." So, when you're motivated towards reward and approach, you tend to be more optimistic, more expansive in yourself, more thinking about what you want as an ideal and more inflated. And when you're worried about missing rewards or avoiding punishments, or you're more avoidance-motivated, your self is going to be more neurotic, you're going to be more focused on threats, you're going to have a little bit less positive view of yourself, a lower sense of self-efficacy.
- 4.30 Does that make sense? These are just two different ways for the self—so this is why, when you look at people who are more grandiose narcissistic, they're like, "Yeah, I have this great vision for this. I'm going to be the king of the universe, and it's going to work great. I have a vague plan to get there, but it'll work out along the way because I'm pretty charming." Because the self is locked in with this general approach motivation. So these systems are locked in together, and approach makes us a little more expansive and avoidance a little more small, a little more negative.
- 4.31 And like everything else, life is a dance between these two because if you're too approach-oriented, you end up just dead. You end up like a real risk-taker, like Chuck Yeager, super risk-taker. I mean, he did a great job. He didn't die. But you have a lot of

risk because you're taking risks all the time. And avoidance orientation, often you're depressed because you're not doing much. You need a balance between them. OK, that makes sense. That makes me feel better. All right. You see what I mean? I'm feeling a little more chill. OK.

- 4.32 Those are the big two motives that influence everything. You see how they work through the self system a little bit. There's another historical way of looking at motivation or energy in the human condition, and it comes up with the big three motives. This is work that goes back to Freud and Henry Murray and all that coming out of the psychoanalytic tradition. It went into academic psychology with David McClelland, winner as well, some other people. What they found is that there are three basic foundational motives.
- 4.33 Power, it's the ability to control your environment. Achievement, which is the ability to achieve. There's a better word for it. Achievement is the ability to reach the specific goals you want to reach. And affiliation, the motivation to connect. Those three goals seem to be something that shape a lot of our human behavior. Some people are more oriented towards power, and some are more oriented towards competence, and some people are more oriented towards affiliation. Just different ways were set, and these can be very different.
- 4.34 I meet people that are super relationship-oriented. I'm like, they're just different than me. I love relationships, but I'm more competence-oriented and power-oriented. That's just how I am. I'm an academic. I always want to be competent. Then you meet people, I meet people that are super power-oriented. I'm like, "Dude, I like a little power, but my goodness, you seem pretty into this stuff." I'm a little more competent. That's just, well, that's what kind of worked out for me. People have a little different balance, and they have different outcomes.
- 4.35 More recently, people have taken this same model, pushed through what's called self-determination theories. How can we take these basic Freudian or foundational psychodynamic motives, and integrate them with a model of the self? Again, this is called self-determination theory because it's about determining how the self determines its outcomes in life. This work is associated with Ed Deasy and Rich Ryan up at Rochester, and I think Ed is retired, and I think Rich moved to Australia. Oh, and Daniel Dennett passed away yesterday, speaking of philosophy of mind. I just read, which is heartbreaking. I'll talk about his stuff in another lecture. People are getting old.
- 4.36 But this idea was, hey, let's look at these basic motives and how they influence the operation of the self. It's a little bit more of a self view of the same motives. Instead of power, what self-determination talks about is autonomy motivation. So autonomy sounds a little better than power. Power motivation sounds a little like, "Yeah, I want to be a tyrant." And autonomy sounds like, "I want freedom." What they mean by autonomy is choicefulness, which is the ability to make the choices you want to make

in life. Sounds an awful lot like power, but when you put it in terms of choicefulness, it doesn't sound as much as a control thing.

- 4.37 An autonomy motivation is to become somebody who can make choices and navigate effectively through the environment and the way they want. That's just a motivation. Second motivation is achievement, but they call it competence motivation, essentially about mastery of one's environment. You've got, I want to be choiceful in what I do. I want to be able to master my environment, and then relatedness. It's about connection again. They're very similar ideas.
- 4.38 But I like the idea of autonomy motivation because power—again, there's very crude power motivation, which is just being a tyrant, but there's more sublimated power motivation, which is about controlling an environment, and that could be in a positive or negative way. If it's generated from the self, I think the term autonomy is pretty good. We've got approach orientation and avoidance orientation. Then the flavor these motives take tend to be something about freedom or autonomy or power over our environment, something about mastery or achievement, ability to function really well at a specific task, and then about connecting with people.
- 4.39 If you remember when I talked about the big two at the beginning of class—I said there's agency and communion—kind of what this looks like is, this is like your power motive, and this is like your relatedness motive, and your competence motive is maybe in between there, or maybe it's somewhere a little bit, but it's a similar idea to that. We keep finding the same models over and over. Same big two, same big three, same big four. Same big two, same big three, same big five.
- 4.40 OK, now on to self-control. How does that work? So immediate self-control, sometimes we call this willpower, the power of our will. It's the power to override a short-term impulse in favor of something that's going to help with a long-term goal. So we have a short-term impulse. This morning, I didn't want to get out of bed. My impulse was to go back to sleep. Short-term impulse might be like, "I just really want to eat that piece of chocolate cake I got after dinner, and then half of it's sitting by my bed in the morning. I really want to eat that." That's a short-term impulse.
- 4.41 I'm driving my car and I get road rage, and I just want to run somebody off the road because "it's all over, man, and I'm taking them all down with me." Short-term impulse. Often those short-term impulses feel right at the time. You're like, dude, this would feel like the right thing to do. But we know that it's not the best thing for our long-term goals and our long-term self, so we need to override that. That overriding process, overriding that impulse, is self-control or the application of willpower.
- 4.42 What we know about willpower is that it's very, very weak. We feel we have this fantasy that, like, "Yeah, I can quit smoking and sleep next to a carton of cigarettes because I'm a strong person and I have willpower." But I promise you that most of the time you aren't a strong person with that much willpower because willpower really isn't

as strong as we think it is. I will give you one example of this. I always—so one of the things that, a lot of things scare me. One of the things I always get scared of is just being dropped in the middle of the ocean and then just thinking, how far would I swim before I gave up? I always wonder that. I've been sucked out a few times to sea, but I made it back.

- 4.43 But one time I was snowboarding, I remember, long story, I'm going to really shorten this. Storm comes in, I'm snowboarding, and we're like, "We're going to go backcountry." So I get my brother. He's usually with me in bad adventures. And they go, "We'll go hike in. We'll go hike in over this ridge, and then we'll go ski down this bowl, and then we'll hitchhike back to our car," and there's this kind of a place you can do this. The powder's about this deep, and we start hiking, and I'm hiking in there, and about 40 minutes in, I'm so freaking tired. I don't have snowshoes. I'm like dying, I'm out of shape. I'm up at 8,000, 7,500 feet. I see a tree over there and I go, "I could just go sit under that tree and die, and that would feel pretty good right now."
- 4.44 Holy moly. I was ready to give it up just because my legs were tired. I was ready to turn the whole thing in. I'm like, "Well, I made a will. Pretty nice tree." I put my snowboard on and I went right back where I started. I went right over my footprints all the way back to my car and drove home. I'm like, "I'm not going to die out here." But that was when I realized how little willpower I had. I mean, believe me, my willpower has failed a million times. But that was one of those times when I was really just happy just to curl up for the big nap, and it wouldn't have bothered me a bit. This is what happens with willpower.
- 4.45 What do we do? There's a few different models of this. One thing we know about willpower is that, like I said, it's weak. If you're in a situation where you're trying to use will, it's better to distract yourself, if you can, or avoid the situation altogether. The classic study on overriding impulses was the old marshmallow test, the classic old Walter Mischel's marshmallow study. What he'd do is, he'd put a marshmallow in front of a child and say, "If you could withhold eating this marshmallow for a certain period of time, I'll give you two marshmallows. If you override this impulse of wanting the marshmallow, you get a reward, a double marshmallow." It's a very simple way of the ability of willpower in a child.
- 4.46 What he argued in his work was that the kids who were able to do this were telling themselves stories. They were distracting themselves. They weren't sitting there going like, "I'm just going to white-knuckle it." They were telling stories. Now, there's some issues, but just think if that's how it worked. Distracting yourself, telling yourself stories works. If you don't want to drink, don't keep a bottle of whiskey in your cupboard. It's like that thing. If you don't want to eat the chocolate cake, don't keep it in your fridge. So you distance. Just don't give yourself the opportunity to do dumb things. That is much more effective than willpower.

- 4.47 The academic, the research model for this that I think is the most popular, but I'm not, I think the effects are really small, but I'm going to go through it anyway because I think it's pretty useful to think about, is called ego depletion effects. This is an argument made by Roy Baumeister. What he argued was that self-control or willpower works a little bit like a muscle. What that means is, the way a muscle works is, if I want to get stronger, I'm going to need to use my muscles. But if I use my muscles, I'm going to become weaker in the short-term.
- 4.48 Imagine I want to get in shape, and I'm going to do 20 pushups a day. Well, if I do 20 pushups right now and you say, "How strong are your arms?" I'm like, "My arms are pretty weak." You say, "Hey, do 20 pushups." OK, my arms are weak. But if I do 20 pushups over and over again, my arms will actually become stronger. Does that make sense? With self-control, often you're losing strength in the short term, but you're gaining strength in the long term. It's like antifragility in a way. You get weaker, but that makes you stronger.
- 4.49 The idea was that maybe willpower works like this a little bit as well. If you have to use your willpower, so in the research, what they do is they bring a kid to a, an undergraduate into a lab and they were really hungry, and they'd say, "Hey, we baked a bunch of cookies. You're in the radishes condition. So just look at these cookies and you can eat this radish." They'd just make you look at the cookies and not eat them. Then they'd say, "Oh, now we're going to have you do some math." How much willpower do you have left for math?
- 4.50 People wouldn't do quite as much math when they were avoiding eating the cookies. When they had to use self-control, they would do a little less math. If they got to eat the cookies, they didn't have to use their self-control, they'd do a little more math. Another way to think about it is using self-control will lower your self-control in the short term, but in the long term, increase it. The research, these effects are pretty small, these ego depletion effects. My guess is something that's more like exhaustion that's going on, is that you self-control, like you're waiting tables, being a server, which is one of the hardest jobs because you're doing a lot of emotional self-regulation.
- 4.51 You're smiling. You're being nice to jerks, which is really, that's your job. I try not to be a jerk. I'm always like, I'm a jerk even when I try not to be because I'm always making some weird conversation. "What do you think about dryads?" "What? What are you talking, maniac?" So, using self-control like that over time, I think, can be depleting. It's almost like exhausting. But I think, anyway, very interesting idea here. And generally, self term, again, short-term self-control, very bad, but it's good to try it a lot because maybe it gets stronger with you.
- 4.52 If you go through a lot of things that we would consider sins, and I was looking at lists, and there's no official sin list. I was trying to find a good one, but everyone has theirs. I was trying to find good seven deadly sins, the different debates. But if you look at classic sins, gluttony, self-control. It's about overriding an impulse to not eat that next

piece of chocolate cake, which was really good. It's seven layers last night. Lust, licentiousness. It's like staying faithful, not letting lust override your, or not letting lust ruin your relationship with somebody.

4.53 Greed. It's like theft or stealing or doing stupid things because greed is like, you want it. It's an impulse, and if you can override that greed impulse. Anger. That's the issue I have. Anger is an impulse that you can override. You get pissed off, you go like, "I can't get mad. I'm going to control my emotions." It's emotion regulation. One we don't think about very much, well, maybe you do. I don't think about very much. I don't know about you guys; maybe you think about it all the time, is sort of the sin of despair or being distraught or not being engaged. That's something that takes self-control to override. I feel despair. It's like, dude, you just got to step up and overcome that. We all feel despair sometime. That's the story I got to tell myself.

4.54 And pride itself, like the sin of pride or boastfulness or envy or hubris, they have different words for it. Essentially, the sin of ego. That can be self-regulated. You're like, I love those. My favorite studies that I see recently, there was like, what percent of guy thinks he could beat a grizzly bear in a fight? And it's always like, 78% of American men, they could take on a grizzly bear. I think I could, too. But you talk to the old-timers, and they're always like, "Yeah, you always keep one round in the chamber for yourself." You're not going to fight a grizzly. They just take you out. But that's pride.

4.55 Now, imagine I'm with a grizzly and I'm like, "Dude, I'm going for it." I need to override that impulse. That's when you want a good friend. You're like, "No, you're not. Just stay here, Keith. Just stay here." You need somebody to tackle you. I'm laughing about this, and this is like, people die from bears because they go like—I had one helicopter pilot, and they have these, these spirit bears up in British Columbia that are these white-colored black bears. They're called spirit bears. Then some hippie was, like, went to go commune with the spirit bears. The helicopter guy was like, "Yeah, we found his backpack." You don't go, just stay away from bears. That's just my advice. I love them, but they're big.

4.56 And courage on the opposite side of that is often about self-control. Maybe you've got your friend who just wants to go hang out with bears because they're impulsive. But also being courageous takes impulse because sometimes our impulse is to run away and hide. So showing courage takes energy. You're like, "Dude, you just got to suck it up and go do something instead of being a wuss." And so courage can take self-control to overcome our own fear as well. So I think this short-term self-control is really important. It's just a relatively weak resource that we should use judiciously when we can.

4.57 The longer-term self-regulation is more about forming goals and identities. So if I'm thinking not about how to regulate through our fishing trip in British Columbia and avoid the grizzlies, but instead, what your job is going to be in five years or something, we start talking about concepts like possible selves or ideal selves, things like that. The

way this work, I guess the way to think about this, and this goes back to William James again, is you can come up with a possible self. Like I said, you can project yourself in the future. I want to be a physician. I want to be an attorney. I want to be a bear wrestler, whatever it is.

- 4.58 You build a model of that person. You can build an ideal future self, that's a desired self. You can also have a feared self. Sometimes people will regulate instead of more approach orientation, this is who I want to be, Keith the bear guy, Mr. Bear. You know who I really don't want to be is Keith the poor loser. I don't know. I mean, I used to have an image of that. I told this story so many times, but I used to walk out of this parking garage, and this guy, his job was to sit at the parking garage. He had one earplug in, listening to the radio, and he just watched cars all day. Every time I walked by, I'm like, "Dude, I just don't want to end up like that guy."
- 4.59 You get these feared selves, too. Anyway, I see some guy, my age, at a bar and I'm like, "Oh, you sad SOB. I never want to be that guy. Call my wife." You can have feared selves and you can have desired selves. But when you're doing this in the long term, what you're doing is you're creating an image of yourself. And then what happens is, that image of who you want to be or who you don't want to be gets tied up with motivation and emotion. How does that work? Well, it can work in different ways.
- 4.60 One is, there's basic self-discrepancy. If your goal is to be, I want to be a Palm Beach millionaire, and I'm living in the back of my car in Moab, Utah, well, that's a pretty big difference between the two. So if somebody's like, "How's it going, Mr. Palm Beach?" I'm like, "Oh, I feel pretty sad." So what happens is, that discrepancy, when you activate it or prime it, can lead to emotions. And that emotion of "I feel sad," maybe what that will do is inspire me to, like, "Hey, I got to get to work." Sometimes you get negative emotions with these discrepancies that can potentially be motivational because you don't want to feel sad anymore. You want to reach your goal.
- 4.61 Sometimes what happens is the emotion comes from progress to the goal. This is a process you see in lots and lots of work on emotion and affect. Our emotions come not necessarily from reaching a goal, but it comes from the progress we make and the rate of change in the progress. If my goal is to be a Palm Beach millionaire, if I'm making progress, "Hey, I made 100 bucks this week," that's making a step. I'm like, I feel pretty good because I'm making progress towards my goal. "Oh, I didn't make any money this week." Oh, I feel bad. The emotion comes from our change, the rate of change towards the goal.
- 4.62 Then what happens, so this is like Carver and Scheier's. This is all their goal regulation theory. What happens is, when I get my goal and I'm a millionaire in Palm Beach, my goal system shuts down. I feel good for a day. I'm like, I did it. Do a selfie. And then I'm not happy anymore because I got my goal. When you get your goal, it's not like you're happy forever. You just go make another goal. Sorry. It's the hedonic treadmill. You can't really ever win.

- 4.63 What you're doing is, you're creating an image of who you want to be. Then as you progress or motivate towards that goal, it's going to create emotions. If you're going in the right direction, they're going to be positive emotions, and that's going to be reinforcing. If you're going in the wrong direction, you're going to get negative emotions. They're going to be a little punishing, and that should get you towards your goal. You're building this bigger structure, when it becomes a long-term goal.
- 4.64 This is the same idea in psychoanalytic theory, but in Freudian theory, the goals are often unconscious, and we're not really trying to meet them. They just punish us. In a Freudian model, instead of like, hey, my ideal self is the millionaire in Palm Beach, what I have is a superego, or an ego ideal, which is a psychological structure that I inherited maybe from my parents, that's this voice in my head says, "You're not good enough. You should be better," and it punishes me. So a Freudian superego is essentially a punitive psychological structure; it's aggression turned inward that punishes you when you're not reaching your goals effectively. But it's not a clear goal.
- 4.65 A classic goal, like in more William James social psychological goal, is something you would imagine. You'd have a vision board you'd think about. A Freudian superego is like an unconscious parent who just kicks your butt all the time, and you're not exactly sure why or what to do wrong, but you feel bad because you're like, "I screwed that up again. I screwed that up again." You get anger turned inward. The Freudian goal system is a little different than more of the social psychological goal system. I don't know if anyone in the world needed to know that, but now you do. In case anyone asked, "How is that different than Freud's ego ideal?" Well, I know the answer to that.
- 4.66 But what happens in something like psychoanalysis is you have people with really strong superegos. They're constantly punishing themselves, and they have trouble achieving goals because basically, they're just kicking their butt all the time, and they're feeling bad about themselves. So some of the analysis of superego is like, "Dude, let's remove some of that pressure. You don't have to be perfect. We can move some of that childhood stuff away, and then you can just progress normally towards a goal without that interference."
- 4.67 Why haven't I reached all my goals? Well, two reasons. One, I reached all my goals, and every time I reach them, I just made even more. I always was farther and farther behind, the older I got, because I kept making more goals. That's one of the problems. But a real problem is, it's hard to reach goals because we don't regulate ourselves appropriately. Not necessarily that we're lazy, though I am lazy. I could work three times as hard and I could accomplish more. But many of us aren't lazy. We want to get our goals, but what we do is we misregulate, meaning, we put energy into working towards the goals, but that energy isn't effective in getting us what we want. It gets us somewhere else.
- 4.68 We call this goal misregulation. Thank the clinical psychologists for that term. They love misregulation. I never understand half of what those guys say, but this one I get. It's a

little different. Let me give you some examples of this. One is what you might call the primacy of affect regulation. I guess that's a fancy way of saying, when we have bad emotions, we tend to take care of the emotions before we take care of the underlying causes. For example, I want to be a millionaire in Palm Beach. I'm not a millionaire in Palm Beach. I feel really bad. What I should do because I feel bad about myself is, I should double down and work harder towards my goals so I feel good.

- 4.69 But instead, what I do is, I go, "You know what? I have all this bad feeling. I'm going to regulate that bad feeling." How do I regulate that bad feeling? I go order a double margarita or a Cuba Libre at the local bar in South Beach, and the alcohol makes my bad feelings go away, and then I feel good again. Does that make sense? I'm regulating my emotion instead of my goal. Whenever I fail or I don't make adequate goal progress, instead of working harder, I take care of the emotion by drinking, or I go order a pizza and just eat the whole thing. I'm like, "That feels better."
- 4.70 What you find is, people will get in a pattern where they're failing or not, I hate the word failing; none of us win. It's like, you don't win life. But they're in a pattern where they're not going in the direction they want and they feel bad. But instead of changing the direction they're on or changing course, making a course correction to feel good, they regulate the emotion. This is very, very common because emotion is just right there. I mean, affect is right in your face and the goals are more distant. That's a classic misregulation thing people do. I actually have people, including myself. I include myself in every one of these things, but that's one I can certainly do.
- 4.71 Another one that I always enjoy is symbolic self-completion. We're a symbolic self. If I want to be something, I could become a millionaire in Palm Beach. I hope this example resonates with people. I don't know why it popped into my head. I guess I'm looking towards Palm Beach. I could become a millionaire at Palm Beach, and that's going to be pretty hard. I got to do a lot of work for that. Or I could get a really cool shirt that says Palm Beach, like the Breakers. I don't know what the Breakers is, but I know all the cool guys have the Breakers. Is that cool? Anybody? Yeah, I get a nod. OK. I could do that, and I could get a golf club or something, and get one of those Patagonia jackets so people think I got a hedge fund, and I could just act like Mr. Palm Beach.
- 4.72 That's symbolic self-completion. What I did was, rather than complete my goal of becoming a millionaire, I symbolically completed my goal by taking on the symbols of somebody who is a Palm Beach millionaire. We call that being a poser sometimes or being a phony, but that's a reasonable way to self-regulate. The story I always think about is another one of these old stories where, with a buddy, and this guy comes up, he's like, "Check out my new eagle talon tattoo." He's got, like, eagle claws. My buddy goes, "Why don't you just move to Montana and climb mountains?" Just started laughing so much. It was so mean, but it was so true.
- 4.73 Anyway, there's a lot of information in that comment. What he was saying is, "Dude, you're pretending. If you want to be a guy who lives in the mountains and climbs

mountains, just go be that guy. Don't just get a tattoo and then go work in a cube farm in Irvine." I mean, that's for losers. Go be the guy you want to be. Come on. But because the symbolic economy is so powerful, and we're such symbolic selves, we can regulate symbolically rather than regulate in real life. It doesn't feel quite as good, but we can do it.

- 4.74 A third one I'll talk about that I think is interesting is called escaping the self. This is another Roy Baumeister idea I like a lot. Roy is so smart. But here's how Roy described it to me. He said, you have a house, and it's great having a house. I love my house. But houses take a lot of freaking work to look nice. You got landscaping, you got to clean the thing, you got to make sure that, whatever. I don't know. Mostly, I guess it's landscapes, lighting, clean the windows, do a lot of work on the house. You got the plumbers always over there. It's expensive, it's time-consuming. It's the same as having a self.
- 4.75 Having an elaborate self that's social and gets along culturally, that's a lot of work. People who you meet, when you meet really charming, put-together people, they weren't born that way. There's a lot of work to do that. It's exhausting. Often what people want to do is just shut the self off. They just want to escape the self. They're like, "Dude, let me just turn this whole self system off for a minute and just relax." How do people do that? Well, they can do it in healthy ways. You could try meditating or exercise or something, but often they do it in less healthy ways. Drinking, they drink themselves. With alcohol, we call it alcohol-induced myopia. Myopia is very narrow focus.
- 4.76 You focus on something very narrow, you can't think about yourself. You can do it with pain. You can exercise until you're so exhausted that you can't think about anything else. Or you can, sado-masochism. People are like, "What the heck? Why would you hire somebody to beat you or to whip you?" Sounds weird. I mean, it's a really weird question, as a self researcher, and Roy did a whole bunch of research. He's like, "You know who pays for that? Really successful rich dudes who are exhausted and don't want power. They want someone to take power for a second. They just don't want to be in charge for five freaking minutes." That's interesting.
- 4.77 We can do a lot of things to escape ourselves. Then again, in the short term, that's going to be useful, but it's not a good long-term self-regulation strategy. I think this escaping the self idea is really an interesting one. Then we've been talking about more formal ways of thinking about goals, having representations of who you want to be, having goals, and getting there in the long term. The other way or another way to think about goals is, rather than chasing something more out there, it's a goal coming from the inside, what we call intrinsic motivation. It comes from the inside, and it's things that bring us a sense of joy.
- 4.78 We talk about enjoyment, things that bring us joy, that engender joy into us, or things we do just for their own sake. It turns out, there are lots of things we do just because

they're fun. They don't take a lot of effort because they're fun. We feel pleasure doing them. We feel they're self-regulating. They make us feel healthy. There are things that are intrinsically motivating. There's a couple of ways we can get to intrinsic motivation. One way, it is through the long process of internalizing complex things.

- 4.79 This is going to sound weird, but people don't like to go into psychology because they hate statistics. I never liked statistics. It was always hard. But when I was in grad school, I had to teach stats, and I had to teach four sections, four of the same sections, every week. First section, I didn't know what I was teaching. Second one, I kind of knew what I was doing. Third one, I got it. And fourth one, I'm like, "Dude, I nailed this. I know what I'm doing." I just had to teach it four times, and by the fourth students, they got a good teacher. The first four were trial and error.
- 4.80 Over time, after doing that, I got to learn statistics. I don't know them now, now I have grad students, but at that time, I was smart. I was probably 30. It was fun to do statistics for me. It was joyful to do stats. "Hey, give me a data set. Let's do some numbers. This is awesome." I had internalized something that was really hard, and once I internalized it and I could do it without thinking, it was just fun because I was problem-solving, I was engaging with things. It was just fun.
- 4.81 A lot of things are like this. Apparently, golf is like this. I've never gotten to that point. But lots of snow-skiing. People, they get these enjoyment flow experiences, snow-skiing. Skiing is really hard to learn, but once you get it, you get really dialed in. I do yoga a lot. That yoga takes a little while to learn, but once you get it, you can get in these, lose yourself and get really enjoyable. Lots of things you can learn, and you learn so much that they become internalized. I saw a kid playing music up at the Georgia Theater a couple of weeks ago. This young guy, he was playing the Allman Brothers. It was just awesome.
- 4.82 He was playing, all the kids were dancing, these 25. I'm like, oh, my god, it's a flashback. He's just smiling up there. I'm like, a great musician, somebody who's practiced for 10 years and just put in the time, when they just express themselves, it can seem just like pure joy coming out of an amplifier. That's one way to get there. The other way that's interesting to get it, intrinsic motivation, is it just seems to be there naturally for certain things, and then society crushes it out of us.
- 4.83 The example of this is art. Every one of you, when you were young, probably liked to draw and do art, and probably very few of you do art now. Probably very few of you go home and are like, "I'm going to do a painting." Some of you, probably, but probably very few. So something happened to make you not like art because how the heck do they take kids who love to do nothing better but color? Why don't adults color all the time? The joy was crushed out of them. How does that happen?
- 4.84 Well, this is one of these famous studies in educational psych. It's Lepper, Greene, and Nisbett, like '72. I could be wrong. What they did was, they said, hey, let's just check on

intrinsic motivation in kids drawing. We have a bunch of kids come in the lab and draw. They said, OK, we'll do three conditions. One kid will just do whatever they want. One kid will draw, and when they're done, we'll say, "Oh, that was a great drawing. Here's an award." We'll just, unexpected, just give them an award. The third kid will say, "Hey, will you draw something for me? If you do, I'll give you an award." Just three conditions. Nothing, unexpected award, or, "Hey, draw this thing for me and I'll give you an award."

4.85 They do that to the kids. Then they bring them back in a couple of weeks and say, "Hey, what do you guys want to do?" Well, the kids who didn't get any award for drawing, they went ahead and started drawing again because drawing is fun. Kids who got an unexpected award were like, "Yeah, drawing's fine. I got an award last time." They were drawing. The kids who were asked to draw the time before for an award, they weren't drawing anymore. Because drawing was no longer for them about joy. Drawing was a job to get some reward from a teacher or from a researcher.

4.86 By adding an award or a reward, the people were able to take something that was intrinsically motivating and turned it into something extrinsically motivating. I work around a lot of world-class athletes because I'm at University of Georgia. They just, I'm running through these people all the time. They're just incredible athletes. But you notice people who are pro football players usually don't go play football for fun. They're not like, "Yeah, I'm in it for the joy of the game. On a Saturday, we're not playing. We're just playing catch out in the street because we just love the ball."

4.87 It's a freaking job, right? Because it's become a job. It was fun when they were kids, but it becomes a job. That's what happens with a lot of sports. You go from something that's intrinsically joyous to something that becomes a competition, that becomes a job. You get a lot of meaning from it. You get a lot of purpose from it. You get money from it. You get rewards. It means a lot to you, but it's not as much fun as it was. It's just different. That's just true with every—that's just the nature of a lot of things, that the fun gets sucked out of it once we start putting rewards and pay and structuring systems.

4.88 In a weird way, you have to structure things to have— you have to build really strong structures and have practice in order to develop intrinsic motivation in complicated things. If you want to be a great jazz drummer, you're going to have to work really, really hard to get there, and it's going to be suffering, but at the end, you're going to be able to just do it for fun. On the other hand, a lot of things we like to do for fun, they just get taken from us by society. Self-regulation and self-control and getting where we want to be in life is really important to who we are, and it's something that is very, very hard for all of us to do.

4.89 Most of us have goals. They change all the time. It's hard. We don't want to get where we want. I wanted to end this lecture thinking about a few things in the broader sense that don't come out much, but Bandura wrote about this in his later life, and Jung

wrote about this in his later life, and I've seen it a lot. It's the role of chance and luck in this whole process. So, in life, we tend to think of it as, like I said, it's like an engineering system. Well, we're going to engineer the goals we want and get there and go through this process. If we do it right, we get there.

- 4.90 But sometimes just weird things happen that help us on our way, that it's just a little bit of luck. I met this person, and he introduced me to this person, and then this happened. And when you talk to people in their life, that's very much how life works. I was doing this and this and this, and then I met this guy, and then this woman over here helped me, and then their kid, and next thing you know, we're doing this. It's a totally different thing. It's awesome. Life just works in these weird ways.
- 4.91 Jung talked about this as synchronicity. What Carl Jung said is that there's a connecting principle in the world that we can't really see. It's not causal. It's an acausal connecting principle. It's not like a pool ball hits another pool ball hits another one. It's like these things are connected in a weird way, maybe involving the collective unconscious. Occasionally, you'll get these meaningful coincidences occur. Things will happen, and that will be like a signal. If you get too many of these, sometimes you're in a psychiatrist because you got schizophrenia, so you never know. But you get a few of these, you run with it.
- 4.92 One of my favorite examples of this, which was just whatever, was when I was a department head, I was trying to make a new seminar room. I had knocked some walls. I love doing this stuff. Get to knock some walls down, get the guys to knock the walls down. I designed, I'm like, oh, we got to find a good woman in the department to name it after because we had all these old dude rooms. I'm like, you got to find someone to get some balance here. Couldn't think of anybody. We're cleaning out one of the rooms to put in the seminar room, and one of the admins grabs this top of the shelf and pulls this. She goes, "What's this?" and pulls this thing out.
- 4.93 It's this portrait of this woman I've never seen before. This beautiful portrait is about 100 years old in an oval frame. This is weird. I walked down the hall to the local historian, who is our local psych historian, who happened to be there. I'm like, "Have you seen this before?" He goes, "Oh, my god, that's the missing portrait of Celeste Parish." What? Pulls out a newspaper clipping from 1916 or something of these women presenting this portrait to Celeste. Turns out, she started the first psychology lab at Georgia. As a woman, she couldn't teach at UGA. She could only teach at the Normal School, this teacher school, which is called the Normal School. If you go to Athens, there's Normal Town. The reason they call it Normal Town is because that's where the teacher school was.
- 4.94 She was able to teach there, but she wrote to one of Wundt's students in Cornell, I forget whom, and said, "Look, I need a lab down here. You have a banquet in New England. We have nothing but scraps." And so he said, "Great, we'll start a lab." And she set up a lab at UGA in the summer. So she was able to work in the summer. Sorry,

that was a long story. It was so cool. So then Roger got his wife to redo the, and so it's hanging in the room now with the little thing. That was just synchronicity. It was weird. I didn't know this story, but now everyone knows the story, and you have this beautiful portrait.

- 4.95 A couple other things to think about along these lines. Synchronicity is about these specific causations. There's another way that the ancients looked at the world almost as if the world is a living thing that responds to your action. There's an old phrase, there's lots of Latin versions of this, which are essentially, "Fortune favors the brave," or "Fortune favors the bold." Or if you're out there and willing to try stuff, the world's going to respond in a way that gives you a shot. This is magic. I don't know if this happens, but you talk to enough people and you look at enough classic texts, and there seems to be something like this that at least people experience.
- 4.96 I can't figure it all out. World is too complicated to run all these plans. But I have faith that if I'm willing to give the world a shot, that the world is going to give me a shot, too. Weird stuff, but again, it's something you see. The final thing I wanted to leave you with was this idea of compromised formations. This is a psychoanalytic idea, but the way we're built, we can really never get everything we want because everything collides. I want to be a famous psychologist who has a strong family. Good luck with that. When are you going to find that 48 hours a day you need to self-promote? Well, I guess I'll just ignore my family. Well, how is that going to work for your strong family? It's not.
- 4.97 I got to compromise. Compromise formations. Life is filled with just making compromises and people are like, yeah, you got to compromise. You end up finding some combination of goals that work for you, that maybe you lose some career goals, you gain family goals, but it all works out. Maybe you're switching goals over time. For five years, you're focusing on work, and five on family, and you're balancing it. But this is a very complicated process I don't think anyone ever nails.
- 4.98 When I meet people who are world-class successes, which I do every once in a while, I often wonder what the sacrifice was, because it's very hard to get there without sacrificing something. There's a cost to success. Often we'll set out on a journey. We want one thing, we'll end up in someplace else. But often that place we end up is the place we probably should have been, and it's the best place for us. I'll end it at that. Thanks.
- 4.99 From an evolutionary biology standpoint, I'm curious about the rationale behind the development of the self. The heart develops so we can spread blood, ears develop so you can hear sound waves. I'm curious if there is a working theory as to why we have a self.
- 4.100 It's a great question. My guess is, there's a lot of, I mean, evolution, there's probably a lot of things pushing for that. But I think the answer for the human self would be that we live in complicated social groups, and we need a more complicated self to deal with

these more complicated social groups. Then my question is, is that something that was evolved directly, like through an evolutionary pressure? Or did we evolve to this point where we got hunter-gatherer groups and had a not-too-elaborate self? And then that not-too-elaborate self got hijacked by culture?

- 4.101** Our self is a problem because we never really evolved to have this complicated of a self. We evolved to have a—imagine you're in a hunter-gatherer group, you're growing up, you're a young man. I'm a young man. What am I going to do with your life? What are you going to do with your life? You're going to come fishing. That's what you're going to do. Well, I don't know, dad. What if I don't feel like I'm a—just shut up. It's real simple. So you don't need that elaborate of a symbolic stuff. You identify as male or female, you identify with your tribal group, you maybe have a social role.
- 4.102** It's possible that we don't have a good evolutionary reason for this complex self, and it's just been taken over by culture, and we can't really control it either. I don't know if that's a very satisfying answer. I think the basic core of the self is about social self-regulation. I'll give you an example. I'm hanging out with some Bushmen down in the Kalahari in Botswana. I always wanted to go meet Bushmen. I thought they'd be cool. I took my kids down. I was talking to this guy, and we're talking about hunting. He's talking about killing, which is probably poaching. I shouldn't say this, but allegedly, we were talking about hunting.
- 4.103** He told me, like, "Ibex. It's so good." He'd shoot something, he'd follow it for three days. You'd shoot a, like a giraffe, and you're following it for three days, and you're burying water and ostrich eggs in different places. So you got to have a memory of, like, you've got to be able to cooperate with a group to plan for a three-day hunt and then feed every—there's a lot of planning in there and you have a role in that operation. So you need a self for all that stuff. But then the more elaborate, I'm a big deal, and I'm a pharaoh, and I'm going to live for lifetimes, that kind of elaboration, I don't know if that's evolved or if that's just hijacked by culture.
- 4.104** My question is more about the self and how you have a self-image. And with the work in the book, Cybernetics, how they say that sometimes even after plastic surgery, if they alter the nose, someone will still have that self-image that doesn't change. And how would you say we can change that self-image to act in the way that we want the new self to become?
- 4.105** That's an interesting question that I won't turn into a discussion. People will look at themselves and they go, "I see this face and I don't like it so much. It's not quite," and this is especially true with social media because we're projecting ourselves all the time. And there's certain things people notice because of the way they hold selfies, their noses always look too big to us and different things like that. And so people go, "I'm going to change my physical appearance, and then that should change my self. So if I go and get rid of this nose that's too big or whatever, I got a lot things I could do; when I

do that, I will become another person, and then I will see myself as an attractive person."

- 4.106** But what you're saying happens is, I go get that happen, and I think I'm going to wake up and walk out of the office and go, "Hey, world, I'm an awesome, attractive person." But I walk out and I still feel exactly the same, because my mind still is telling myself the story that I'm not who I see. The answer to that, and I'm going to say is a speculation because I haven't seen a study where they've looked at the time frame. I've seen them look at self-esteem following plastic surgery, and I've seen studies looking at why people go to plastic surgery because they don't like selfies. But I haven't looked at the adjustment phase after.
- 4.107** My guess is that, if you go back to your normal friends or your normal social group, they still have an image of you as you've always been, so they still see you the way you were, and you still see yourself the way you were, so it's not going to change. But if you started going with a new social group who saw you, just your new version, and you started over time, started seeing yourself through the eyes of a new social group, that you'd start to believe that you'd changed.
- 4.108** My guess is that our self gets stuck in our social group a little bit, that even when we change, it's hard for us to change our image because the other people don't see us that much differently. That's a little speculation on my part. I think that would be actually interesting to see. I know they've done those TV shows where people go get the plastic surgery and get 'The Swan' or something, get remade. Be fascinating to do follow-ups with that.

Lecture 5: Understanding Self-Esteem

At a glance — Understanding self-esteem.

- 5.1** In this lecture, I wanted to talk a little bit about self-esteem and feeling good about our self. Kind of touched on this a little bit, but self-esteem is important because it is our evaluation of our self. It's our self-evaluation. An evaluation is a judgment that something is good or bad, positive or negative. So any evaluation, that's what it is. And so, self-esteem is our evaluation of our self.
- 5.2** It's essentially like an attitude. We have an attitude about lots of things. Lots of things I'm not even going to mention because every example that popped in my head was stupid. We have an attitude about our self, and it's a very similar idea. It's just, "I like myself, I don't like myself." But what's interesting about self-esteem, about the attitude about the self, is it has these interesting consequences. High self-esteem will feel a certain way. It'll predict certain things. Low self-esteem will feel a certain way, predict different things.
- 5.3** We also have what's called self-enhancement, which is this desire or propensity to increase the positivity of our self-concept and our self-esteem. We have this general evaluation of ourselves, which we call self-esteem. We also have this process for maintaining that self-esteem called self-enhancement. In our life, we evaluate ourselves, like, "I like who I am, I don't like who I am," and I do things to keep myself liking who I am. That's what I'm going to talk about for the next hour or so.
- 5.4** Self-esteem is a little different than some other things. Self-esteem and self-confidence, there's some related terms, but there's so many self things. Self-confidence is a little bit like self-efficacy. Confidence is, "I'm confident I can do something. I believe in myself." Self-esteem is just "I like myself." It's more simple; it's just more of a judgment. Self-efficacy, again, it's about "I can reach goals." Self-esteem, "I like myself." Narcissism, another one of these terms that people often think of. They often think of narcissism as being, well, that's really high self-esteem. You got a guy with self-esteem, and then you got a guy with narcissism who's got a super big head.
- 5.5** It's a little different. Narcissism is more about superiority to people, especially on things like physical appearance or power or competence or status. But it's not necessarily the same as being, "I'm a good person, I'm a person of worth." It's a little bit of targeted self-esteem. They go together, but narcissism is a little more about superiority. Self-esteem is more, "I like myself." Self-esteem is generally pretty high for most people. If I sample a bunch of undergraduates on a classic scale for self-esteem, might go from 10 to 40, and the average might be about 34, just to make up numbers that are probably pretty close to what you'd find. People generally have pretty high self-esteem.
- 5.6** When people have low self-esteem, that usually doesn't mean, "I hate myself, I really don't like who I am." It usually means there's a couple of things I feel pretty good

about, I'm pretty good at this, but I don't feel great about myself overall. So generally, how we're built, at least in our culture, people have pretty high self-esteem or it's more moderate. When you find truly low self-esteem, "I really don't like myself, I have suicidal ideation, which is a fancy way of thinking about suicide, or I think about killing myself. I'm a bad person," we start thinking that might be a symptom of clinical depression.

- 5.7** When somebody is at that level of self-esteem, we might think that's a problem and it might be a psychological disorder because you shouldn't hate yourself. We're not built to hate ourselves. You could be ashamed of something, or you could think you're not perfect, but hating yourself is a hard way to go through life. We often think of that as a disorder. Self-esteem, sometimes people break it down into a little more of a social, a little more status piece. Sometimes people think about self-warmth and self-competence. "I feel good about myself, or I feel like I'm competent." There's some little differences there, but generally it's the attitude.
- 5.8** The history of self-esteem is really interesting. I got into this question, where did this come from? When did people start thinking about self-esteem? Because I talked to my grandmother, who passed away a while ago when I was young. My grandmother would never talk about self-esteem. I can't imagine my grandmother growing up in a farm in the Midwest going, "I'm really thinking about my self-esteem, Keith." She's like, "Who's got time for that? I got chicken, I got kids." So people really—self-esteem is something that's a bit cultural. So when I looked into the history, and I haven't done this in a while, but the first use I could find of self-esteem was in *Paradise Lost*. It was Milton.
- 5.9** And it goes back to early Enlightenment years. And apparently at this time in Europe, people started doing a bunch of self words. It was more individualism. And people started, there's a lot of words with self, with an E at the end of self, dash something, so like self-esteem. The first use of self-esteem was seen as pretty positive. Milton was saying, "God loves you, so you should love you too, and because you're loving you, God loves you." So self-esteem is God's love, and if you have high self-esteem, you should be aligned with God. That sounds great. It's just not true, but it sounds really good. But that's one really popular way of looking at self-esteem.
- 5.10** When self-esteem got into psychology, it was through William James, like a lot of things. William James had a formula for self-esteem. He had a little equation. It was self-esteem equals success divided by pretensions. What does that mean? Well, what it means is, your self-esteem is how successful you are, divided by how successful you want to be. As James said, and this is a quote, "Such a fraction may be increased as well by diminishing the denominator as by increasing the numerator."
- 5.11** So what you can do, if you want to raise your self-esteem, if self-esteem is success divided by pretensions—your pretense is what you want to be—you can say, "Dude, I'm going to raise my success, and I can have higher success, and my self-esteem will go up." So if I want to be a millionaire in Palm Beach, I can be a decamillionaire. Is that

what it means? I don't even know. Ten-millionaire, and then I'd have really high self-esteem. But the other thing I can do is, I can lower my pretensions. I can be like, "Dude, I don't want to be a millionaire in Miami. I want to be a 50,000-aire in Amelia Island. It's nice up there. You get the seasons." And so by just dialing back what I want in life, my self-esteem will go up.

- 5.12** So James had an example he gives of somebody after the Civil War who lost everything, just a Confederate soldier, lost everything. And James said he was rolling on the dirt so happy that he felt, because he's felt such peace, because he had nothing at all. He had no aspirations, no pretence, nothing, just empty. So his self-esteem was high. James thought of this as a bit more of, something that was more formula and more related to success. In modern research, the most common way of conceptualizing self-esteem is as a general global trait of self-liking. This goes back to work by Rosenberg in sociology in the '60s.
- 5.13** If you ever take a self-esteem scale, you're probably taking the Rosenberg self-esteem scale or some version of the Rosenberg. People will be like, "Yeah, give him the Rosenberg." That's the Rosenberg self-esteem inventory, Rosenberg self-esteem scale. It's a 10-item scale that measures global self-esteem with items like, "I feel that I'm a person of worth, at least on an equal plane with others." Again, it's not about superiority. It's like, I think I'm a person of worth, not that I'm better than everybody else. "I take a positive attitude towards myself." Again, "I like who I am." I get a self-attitude. "I'm able to do things as well as most other people." So a little self-competence. "I feel that I have a number of good qualities. On the whole, I am satisfied with myself."
- 5.14** Those are literal questions from Rosenberg's self-esteem scale. When you hear that, you go, yeah, somebody with self-esteem isn't an arrogant jerk. It's not like, "How do you feel?" "Well, on the whole, I'm satisfied with myself." "Oh, you arrogant, god, just knock it off." "How do you feel?" "I feel I have a number of good qualities." "Really? Come on. Maybe one. Your shoes?" I don't know. Self-esteem is about a general positive evaluation, but it's not really capturing a bunch of narcissism in there. You can hear that.
- 5.15** You can also—because everyone knows what self-esteem is—you can also just ask people. I have high self-esteem, 1 to 5, and people can kind of tell you. My grandmother probably couldn't tell you, she's, "What's that?" But most of us kind of know what self-esteem is. You can just ask people. It's something we're pretty aware of, at least in terms of global self-esteem. But researchers started asking the question, there's some conscious or explicit self-esteem. Is it possible that people can have self-esteem that they're not aware of? Can you have non-conscious or unconscious or implicit self-esteem?
- 5.16** It's a bit of a weird question, but a lot of cognitive people got interested in this because the idea was—remember I talked about the mind. You have this association part,

associationistic way of thinking, and this more linear way of thinking. Some people argued, well, maybe your linear way of thinking is like the story I'm telling myself is, "I'm a good person," but maybe in that associated network you have, maybe those positive associations aren't really there, even though you think you are. Maybe we can try to measure self-esteem in that association network.

- 5.17** Weird. How do we do that? Well, we can't ask you. It's got to be indirect. Researchers have tried a few different ways to do this. One way that I always find interesting is called the name-letter effect. What they'll do is say, "Hey, here's a bunch of letters. How much do you like these letters?" What you find is that people, some people, will have a preference for letters in their own name. Other people don't. I like the letter K. I'm like, K, that's a pretty good letter. Yeah, that's a good-looking letter. You can ask people like, "How powerful is this letter? How beautiful is this letter? How good is this letter?" That's a way of getting at self-esteem a little indirectly.
- 5.18** Again, it's hard to really know if it's doing what it says, but you can test this and it feels right. Another way they've done this, that you might have run across because there's different versions of this, is the implicit association test or the IAT. This is a test developed by Tony Greenwald, Banaji, some others, Brian Nosek was involved. But what they were doing was, they're measuring the speed of association between the term "you" and positive words, and the term "you" and negative words or negative terms. Then they would compare that to the same speed of association with "not you."
- 5.19** I'm not going to run through the whole—it's a complicated thing to get a baseline. But essentially what you do is look at a keyboard and it's like, "You, you, cockroach, yes or no?" "No." There's a difference, though. One person is like, "You, cockroach," "No!" Then another person is, "You, cockroach," "No." They're measuring that time. Then they say, "Other person, cockroach." You're like, "No!" Then "another person, cockroach." "No." "You, present. Or you, gift." "Yes!" "You, gift." "Yes." Then you start looking at the response time.
- 5.20** If you respond more rapidly to positive words about yourself than negative words, as compared to how you respond to a control with another person, and you do all the algorithm there, that's a measure of implicit self-esteem. I hope that makes sense. But you're measuring the association of yourself with positive words. It's a sensible idea. It's capturing something. Theoretically, what people have argued is, well, what do you look like if you have high explicit self-esteem, meaning, you think you're awesome, "I really like myself," but implicitly, you associate yourself with negative things. "God, the letter K is ugly, and I associate with cockroaches faster than gifts."
- 5.21** There's going to be something wrong with me. And what's that going to be? Well, maybe my self-esteem is going to be a little unstable. So maybe I'm going to act like I have self-esteem, but when I get pressure, I'm going to fold because I don't have that implicit self-esteem. Or maybe I'm going to be more defensive about things because I don't have a self-esteem I can rely on. So that's the theory about low implicit self-

esteem. The research is complicated because when people have said, "Hey, let's just look at all these different implicit self-esteem measures and see how well they correlate," it turns out they don't correlate all that well.

- 5.22** We can measure a lot of things that look like implicit self-esteem, but we're not positive exactly what they are. This is the world of unconscious or non-conscious measurement. It just gets really tricky. One of the classic papers on this by Jen Bosson —she's up near Tampa, I think. But she called it *The Blind Men and the Elephant*, from that old, I think it's in the Buddhist canon, where you have three different men describing an elephant, the blind men. One guy is grabbing the feet and he's going, "Yeah, this feels like a tree, and it's a trunk, and this." Another guy is grabbing the trunk, and he's like, "Oh, this feels more like a hose or a tube." Another guy like, "Yeah, I got a brush back here or a tail. Maybe this is a broom."
- 5.23** Same idea with this kind of unconscious self-esteem. People are feeling, finding different things, but no one's really sure what the elephant is. They've all got different pieces of it. So, there's the idea that we have global self-esteem. We have some that's conscious. Maybe there's something that's unconscious. Then people started looking at self-esteem as maybe something that works a little bit more like a state than a trait. So something that's a trait is something that's consistent across time and situations.
- 5.24** So state high self-esteem means that I have pretty high self-esteem right now. I'll have pretty high self-esteem tomorrow. I'll have pretty high self-esteem today when I'm at the pool, at the resort, after doing all these lectures, even though I'm the worst-looking person there. God, I love Miami. But it really does a number on my self-esteem. That's stable self-esteem. But I could also rate self-esteem as how do you feel right now? Just at this moment, you say, "Well, a little low right now. It's a little intense." How do you feel right now? "Now I feel really good."
- 5.25** We can measure self-esteem as a little bit of a state, and we can also look at self-esteem as more localized. We can look at things like self-esteem about my looks or self-esteem about my performance or about my social status. We can drill into self-esteem a little bit. One of the models of this that Heatherton is very well—I'll just give you a few items. It's things like performance self-esteem. "I feel confident about my abilities. I feel rattled about my performance." Social self-esteem, things like, "I feel inferior to others at this moment. I'm worried about whether I'm regarded as a success or failure right now."
- 5.26** It's a little more dialed into the actual appearance. "I feel unattractive." That's status, I mean, appearance self-esteem. We can measure self-esteem as a little more of a specific state. We can also measure global self-esteem as a state. We can see how people's global self-esteem remains stable or unstable over time. There's been some really interesting work on this with diaries. The way you do this is you have people rate their self-esteem every day. Every day, wake up and take a Rosenberg self-esteem scale, and just do that for a couple weeks.

- 5.27** If you do that, what you find are different groups. You find some people have pretty stable high self-esteem. They're just like, "Yeah, I feel good about myself most of the time." You find other people that have pretty stable low self-esteem. It's usually moderate, like I said, like, "Yeah, I don't feel that good about myself. I never really feel that good about myself." What's interesting are both those groups, the stable high and stable low self-esteem, they're not that reactive. They're not that aggressive. They're pretty chill in a lot of ways because they have a stable self system, a stable idea of themselves.
- 5.28** You find another group in there, which is unstable high self-esteem. These are people that have high self-esteem, high self-esteem, but then it's low self-esteem. High self-esteem, high self-esteem, low self-esteem, high, low. Does that make sense? It's unstable self-esteem. That group of people are the ones where you find more aggression, more interpersonal conflict, more instability in the self. The argument is that, when self-esteem is stable, whether it's high or low, it's a buffer. But if your self-esteem is unstable, you're always fighting to maintain it.
- 5.29** If you get threatened and your self-esteem goes down, you've got to do something to raise it. "Oh, my self-esteem is down. I got to show off. My self-esteem is down. I'm going to go yell at somebody. My self-esteem is down. No one's blaming me for this. I'm going to get pissed off." You're fighting to keep your self-esteem up, and it keeps you in a little more unstable and reactive way because you're fighting with the environment to always get it. It's like it's not fixed. That kind of work for you?
- 5.30** So if your self-esteem is fixed, you don't need to worry about it, even if it's low. When it's not fixed, you got to struggle with it a little more. The stable low self-esteem, like I said, is sometimes associated with depression, but often not the reactants and things. That idea brings in this idea of contingent self-esteem and contingent self-worth. It's sort of, where do we get our self-esteem from? Is it something inside or something outside? This is work by Jenny Crocker up at Michigan, did a lot of work in this area.
- 5.31** What you find is that self-esteem is hard to get from the outside. What I mean by contingent self-esteem is, I'll feel self-esteem if I reach this goal, if I get this girlfriend, if I make this money, if I'm this attractive, if I get married, whatever it is. That self-esteem is contingent on getting something. I'm going to go get it from the world. I'm going to go get that self-esteem and bring it in myself, and then I'm going to be a high self-esteem person. When you try to fill your self-esteem up from the outside, it often backfires. It often doesn't work because, if you're going for status, for self-esteem, you could never get enough to fill it up. If you're going for fame, you could never get enough to fill yourself up.
- 5.32** I promise you, it will never, ever work. I was, there's some interesting work on fame, but I was—because I'm in Athens, Georgia, I was talking to this really cool guy. He's a music producer, and we're talking about it. He goes, "I tell these guys, like, fame is just like cocaine because everybody laughs at your jokes. You're funnier than you ever

thought you were. You're more charming than you ever thought you were. You're better looking than you thought you were. And pretty soon you start to believe it's really you, and not that you're famous."

- 5.33** And it goes to your head. And this is what people see in the narcissism work. They find higher levels of narcissism with fame. It can be destabilizing because fame is something you can't keep. Fame is very short-lived, even like Madonna or something. You guys probably don't even know who she is, but she was so famous for 50 years, and now she's not. Even somebody that famous, it's very, very hard to keep fame alive. If you're using fame or status or success as a way to gain self-esteem, it doesn't work.
- 5.34** The other problem with going out and trying to get self-esteem from the world is it ends up wrecking your relationships. If I start a relationship with somebody, and I'm like, "My goal is to get esteem from this relationship," then my mindset is to exploit my environment. How am I going to exploit everybody to make myself feel good? When you start exploiting people, people don't really want to hang with you. "I like that Keith guy, except he just wants to be famous, and he's using me, and it's lame. So let's just not hang with him."
- 5.35** So what happens sometimes is, when you start approaching goals to get self-esteem, you end up losing relationships. And then because you get so much self-esteem from your relationships, your self-esteem ends up going down. So one really interesting study they did with students in dorm rooms, they had two conditions. They had one group of people, "Hey, you're in this new position. You're starting school, you got a new roommate. Your job is to get self-worth, feel good about yourself." Another group of people, "Hey, your job, you're in school, you got this new roommate. Your job is to just form good relationships."
- 5.36** We call it compassionate goals. Your job is just to have relationship goals, form relationships. And then let's see what happens. The people who go into life forming relationships end up having self-esteem because they end up feeling good about themselves because they formed relationships, and relationships make you feel good. And then they end up getting some status. But people who go in there trying to get status end up not forming relationships. Status goals, like I said, are kind of shallow and short-lived. They just don't work that well to fill us up. I mean, you do it for 50 years, I guess it'll work, but it's just, short-term status isn't the secret.
- 5.37** Often chasing self-esteem will backfire on you. It's a bit of misregulation. Instead of chasing self-esteem, it's better to focus on having strong relationships and becoming competent at something. If you're good at something and you have friends, you'll probably feel good about yourself eventually. I mean, I hope. I'll talk about childbearing, but that's the, anyway, I'll get there. Let's see. There's contingent self-esteem. You can have scales that measure self-discrepancy. I talked about that in the last lecture, so I won't really. But this is something I'll mention, Carl Rogers, the humanistic psychologist, used to do.

- 5.38 He'd have people, like, "Here's a circle that's yourself now, and here's your ideal self. Are they like this, are they like this, or are they like this? How much overlap is between yourself and your ideal self?" That's a measure of self-discrepancy. You can measure people's distance or gaps between who they are and who they want to be. It's very easy to do. Who's your ideal self on a 1 to 10 scale, or zero to 100% how close are you to your ideal? That's capturing something like self-esteem. It's a little more of an evaluation of where you are, but that works.
- 5.39 Where does self-esteem come from for people? For most of us, like a lot of traits, self-esteem is genetic. It's wired, it's heritable. When we look at behavioral genetics, there's no single gene for anything. I promise there's no self-esteem gene, there's no CRISPR technology that's going to have your children have super high self-esteem. Probably very complicated. But when we look at family lineages and the transmission of self-esteem, you're looking at heritability like 0.3, 0.4. So, like, 30 or 40% of self-esteem is heritable. It's kind of born with it. And that's probably the biggest chunk.
- 5.40 The second biggest chunk is going to be just random stuff growing up, and then parenting is going to matter a little bit. But that's just what you find with everything with personality. In terms of the parenting of self-esteem, the original source of self-esteem seems to emerge out of early attachment experiences. This early attachment with a caregiver or mother seems to be the earliest source of self-esteem. It seems to be this more emotional core of self-esteem.
- 5.41 If you want to see this demonstrated, probably the clearest and hardest to watch demonstration of the development of self-esteem in the young is Harry Harlow's movie on mother love done on rhesus monkeys at Wisconsin—when he took groups of rhesus monkeys and had them raised by either mothers that were made out of wire, with a bottle that would provide them food, but they could not cling to because they were literally made out of wire. Or they were given mothers that were covered with cloth like burlap and had a light bulb in them that at least made them feel warm.
- 5.42 So he took these young infant monkeys, did a bunch of different experiments, different ways of manipulating it. But essentially, you'd have a situation where you were raised by a mother who was just a wire monkey with a bottle stuck in it. It's very sad. Or it was a burlap-covered wire monkey, so you could cling to it with a warm light bulb. When you watched the monkeys, what people thought—this was the academic psychologists doing this—what they thought would happen was that the monkeys would prefer the wire mother with the bottle, because mothering was about food and love was secondary to food, so that the monkeys would be attracted to the milk.
- 5.43 I mean, you can imagine how messed up you were psychologically that that would be your prediction and how much you were suffering deep down and the massive hole in your soul that would lead you to make that. But it turns out that's not the case. It turns out that the monkeys would spend all the time with a mother they could hold, that they could cling to, that I think Harlow called it contact comfort, just having something

warm to hold on to. How do they test self-esteem with these monkeys that were raised in these different environments? Well, they'd put them in front of a fear stimulus.

- 5.44 So they'd take the monkey in a room. They'd put some really scary-looking mechanical monster in there. They'd put maybe the cloth mother back there in the corner behind a big wall, and they'd see, what does the monkey do? What the monkeys would do if they were raised with the cloth mothers, they'd see this really scary thing. They'd jump back, grab their mom for comfort, hold on for a minute, get their courage up. Then they'd let go and go fight the thing. They'd go approach it. And that's how a healthy development is. You get scared, you grab your mom, you're like, "My strength, I'm recharging my strength from love." And then you go out and face the world.
- 5.45 So the monkeys that had the cloth mothers were able to do that. They were able to build that self-confidence and go out and face the fears of the world. The wire monkeys were just messed up. They would just go grab, and they couldn't really get support from the mother. They'd sit in the corner and hide or huddle up and rock. It was very bad, and lots of bad. The general idea from attachment work is that early experiences of affection and contact and love are important for developing a core of self-esteem. That seems to be kind of the core development, along with the genetics, because some people are wired to connect and some people are wired less.
- 5.46 Then after that, what you find is that self-esteem seems to come from having healthy relationships and age-appropriate challenges. It's just those two things. It's pretty simple. Sometimes we talk about it as a sociometer and a hierometer. So Mark Leary talked about self-esteem as a sociometer. It's a model that shows you you have social connection, like an idiot light in a car. Like, "Yeah, my self-esteem is high. That means I socially belong. Oh, my self-esteem is low. That's, I'm not belonging." Or maybe it shows you got status. "Yeah, I got some status. People respect me. I have some self-esteem. All my status went away. I don't have self-esteem."
- 5.47 So, part of developing that early self-esteem is close relationships, peer relationships, parental relationships, and age-appropriate challenges. When I say age-appropriate challenges, it's not like, hey, we're going to have you go do this crazy thing for an adult. It's like, there are challenges that are designed for a person at that age, so you build confidence over time, just meeting challenges and growing. So building self-esteem isn't hard conceptually; it's just hard because people don't do it all the time.
- 5.48 Then there's a cultural role of self-esteem. Self-esteem is something that changes culturally. I mentioned my grandmother never really talked about self-esteem. It just wasn't really relevant. Self-esteem became relevant in, really, the '70s and '80s. In the '70s, there was an interest in self-esteem because of the humanists like Carl Rogers and because of the book, what was it, Nathaniel Branden, who was Ayn Rand's paramour, wrote a book, *The Five Pillars of Self-Esteem*, that was very popular. It was sort of a different book on self-esteem.

- 5.49 There became an interest in the '70s in self-esteem. Then in California, a state congressman or state rep named Vasconcellos was a, I don't know if he's a friend of Maslow or Rogers. He was very influenced by him. His idea was, we got a lot of problems with kids in California. This was, like I said, late '70s, early '80s. What if we gave kids self-esteem? Because if kids had self-esteem, then they wouldn't do drugs and have kids out of wedlock and their grades would get better. So that was the idea. At the time, it made sense. You're like, "Well, these high self-esteem kids aren't going to do this bad stuff." That's not really true, but it sounded good at the time.
- 5.50 There was a California Task Force for Self-Esteem and Social Responsibility because the Republicans put in social responsibility. They did a bunch of studies and they found out self-esteem probably isn't going to do any of this stuff. Then the educators said, "That's OK, we're still going to do it. We got to get self-esteem, and we're going to make kids feel self-esteem. The way we're going to do it is by having kids feel they're special and unique and important." What you noticed in schools is they started doing things like, "Write all about me," or my daughter would come home with things like, "I am special." It'd be like a coloring thing. You'd color the numbers. It'd be like, "I am special," or "why I'm unique."
- 5.51 I remember my daughter going like, "What's my unique talent, Dad?" Dude, she put she was nice. I'm like, you don't have any unique talent. I don't have unique talent, like plate—I always think plate-juggling. They made an intentional effort to inculcate self-esteem in children from the '80s to maybe '95, 2000. We got a lot of self-esteem. Self-esteem really went up, and so did narcissism. I mean, it was, so then, and now it's changed. They have gone in a couple of different directions. But there really is a cultural element of self-esteem as well. Some cultures celebrate the self and the importance of the self, and some cultures don't.
- 5.52 Again, we had a self-esteem movement. We're not in a self-esteem movement right now. I don't know what we're in. It's not very happy. We're in a not-happy movement. That's one of the ideas. So self-esteem, again, is this attitude about ourselves. And now I'm going to talk a little bit about self-enhancement. And self-enhancement, as I said, is that process or motivation of increasing, maintaining, protecting our self-esteem or our sense of self-worth. We do things to feel good about ourselves or to not feel bad about ourselves.
- 5.53 Sometimes this can be broken down into things like self-protection versus self-augmentation. Augmenting is like being better, protecting is being worse. Sometimes we just generally call it self-enhancement. There's a lot of specific paradigms people have studied for self-enhancement, sort of classic forms of self-enhancement you see socially, and I thought I'd talk about some of those classics. Self-serving bias is one of the big ones you see all the time. And this was first found by this guy named Fritz Heider, who's kind of a weird genius. I think it was at Ohio State, and they gave him a—

I love all these old academic stories. I apologize because you probably don't care, but I like them.

- 5.54** Apparently, he was a weird guy. They gave him an office at the football stadium. He just wrote books on interpersonal relations. But he had this idea of the self-serving bias. He said, you imagine a guy working with his tools and he screws up hammering a nail, so he blames his hammer. That's the self-serving bias. When you succeed, you take credit. When you fail, you blame something in the environment. It's either my hammer was bad or the person I was working with was bad or my team was bad. What a self-serving bias allows you to do is, whenever things are right, it's all you, you're awesome. Whenever things are wrong, it's not you.
- 5.55** This allows you to feel good, which is great. What it doesn't, it has two costs. One is, you don't learn from mistakes. Every time you fail a test, the professor was an idiot and wasn't fair, so you don't study harder. Every time you don't get a job, it's because people don't like you, and so that's their fault. You never improve, but you do feel good. The other thing it does is it ruins your relationships. If I'm working with a partner, I'm at work or on a class project and we fail, and I'm like, "Yeah, my partner screwed it up. I didn't do it," my relationship's over. Who wants to work with me?
- 5.56** You see this in athletics a lot. You imagine a story after the big game. They always interview the guy, right? Here's the star player in the big game. "So you're a quarterback. How did you win?" "Well, I just went out there and I did my best, and I'm pretty good. And tonight I was really good. And that's what it takes to win." So I do that. What happens the next game? Well, my front line goes, "Yeah, this is Keith. He's a dork, and we're just going to let a few people in." And I'm out there being my quarterback, front line lets guys in, and I get smoked.
- 5.57** And next time they ask me how I do, I go, "I just wanted to say thank you to my team for this victory. I thank my team. I thank my family. I'm just lucky to be here. Front line has been real important. I love the coach. Thank God." Boom, I'm out. And that's what guys say, right? People, when they win, they usually thank their team because if you don't thank your team, your team is going to sabotage you. Or at least they should. Not they should, but that's why we do it. There's a pressure in a lot of credit-taking and things not to take credit because other people will sabotage you. It's better to share credit with people. So it gets a little complicated.
- 5.58** The self-serving bias is one of these classic ones. Another classic one of these effects is the better-than-average effect. This is a simple finding that, on average, people think they're better than average. If I have a scenario, let's say it's not attracting, let's say it's driving ability. This is a classic one. I get everyone to rate their driving ability on a, compared to all American drivers, how do you rate yourself from 0% to 100%? The average driver will be about a 65th percentile. Does that make sense? On average, people think they're better than the average. The average person thinks they're a little

better than the average. Not everyone thinks they're the best driver in the world, but people generally inflate their ability to drive.

- 5.59** This is what the better-than-the-average effect is, that we're just, on average, we tend to think we're a little better than average. Not everybody. Some people think they're below average, but this shows this average, better-than-average effect. If you ask people about themselves to rate themselves, there's always a little bit of an inflation in there. This seems to be motivational. It's not purely that we don't know, but there's often a debate in these issues. When I talk about Dunning-Kruger, you'll see why.
- 5.60** If people just don't know any better or if it's more self-esteem-based, I think the better-than-average—like, people who are narcissistic do it more. I think there's some motivation to it. The better-than-average effect is when you see another effect I hear people talking about all the time is the Dunning-Kruger effect. You guys ever heard of this one? A few nods. Yeah, this is like Wall Street Journal, that Dunning-Kruger effect is in there every week. Everyone mis-describes it, and I probably will, too.
- 5.61** But David Dunning is a professor at, I think he's at Cornell, or maybe he's at, I don't know. He moved Michigan, Cornell. A very smart guy. But what you find when you ask people how good they are, are people that aren't very good at something tend to overestimate how good they are, and people who are really good at stuff tend to underestimate how good they are. So your estimation is biased depending on where you are on the continuum. So, if people say, "Keith, how good are you as a psychologist?" I'm like, "Yeah, I'm pretty good. I'm just not that good." "Why do you say that?"
- 5.62** "Well, geez, this dude is so smart. Dave Dunning, oh my god, he's so smart, and this guy is so smart, and I don't know this, and I don't know this, and I don't know this. So I'm pretty good, but there's a lot." You ask somebody that's just starting grad school, they're like, "Yeah, dude, I'm pretty freaking smart. I got most of this stuff. This guy, Campbell guy is an idiot." Because it's easy to say because you just don't know any better. So you have this weird thing where, when you talk to people who are really good at stuff, they often are like—because they just know they're not that good, because they know how good they could be and they've been around the best. You get a little bit of a distortion.
- 5.63** That isn't purely motivational. Some of it is just what you know. It's just if you have better ability, you just know more about something and you just know what you don't know. Whereas if you don't have exposure, you don't know what you don't know. But that's an interesting effect. People always use it to slam people, Dunning-Kruger, like, "you're an idiot." You can do that; it'll make you feel good. Some other things people do are more behavioral. This is stuff you see with narcissism a lot, but things like strategic status displays, bragging, showing off, name-dropping.

- 5.64 I've done this in here like a thousand times. My entire class could be called Keith Bragging. Humble bragging, like if I said, a humble brag is when you go like, "So surprised to be invited to the Oscars. What a shock." You're like, "I really want to tell everybody I'm going to the Oscars, but I can't just say, 'Hey, guys, I'm going to the Oscars,' because you'll think I'm bragging. Oh, my goodness, wouldn't you believe? Little old me is going to the Oscars." People really want to brag, and it's important to do it. If you want to rise in status, you need to. Ideally, you get a friend to do it for you. But if you can't find a friend to brag for you, you try to do a humble brag to sugarcoat it.
- 5.65 But sometimes that doesn't work either because people see through it and it's even worse. The bragging is interesting and it's something we struggle with. There's association, like strategic status association. You associate with popular people and you get status via association. You join a cool club, or you have a cool friend. You invite cool people. This is something you'll see psychopaths do whenever we—we have a lot of them in our culture. And every once in a while, you'll, "Hey, there's a picture of that psychopath with this famous person and this famous person and this famous person." Why is that?
- 5.66 Well, one way you establish status in a new city or new town is you associate with all the high-status people. So you run around making friends with people, getting your photo, and all of a sudden they go, "That Keith guy, he must be really important. I saw a picture of him with Jeff Bezos on his yacht." And so, again, classic psychopath move. Just give you a heads-up. If you see people doing that a lot, I always wonder. But that's a way of gaining status. Universities, I mean, university is just one big status game. It's like, where's your degree, and then what shirt can you wear when you're going to a cocktail party when you're 40? That's status.
- 5.67 There's some challenges when you start doing interpersonal status that I mentioned that get interesting. There's one model, self-evaluation maintenance model, that plays with some of these ideas. I'm not going to fill the whole thing out. But what happens is, in relationships, you can get status by associating with somebody who's really successful. But you're also comparing yourself with them. If my best friend is a psychologist who's like me, but richer and more famous, I can get status from being that person's friend, but every time I'm hanging around with her or hanging around with him, I feel less than. It's because there's a social comparison, right?
- 5.68 I hang out with my friend who's really famous, I go, "Yeah, I'm friends with this famous person." Everyone comes and they go, "I want to talk to the famous person, not you, Keith." I'm like, "Oh, I'm a loser." I want to push away from this famous person. I don't want to be friends with him anymore. So there's a tension. But if I'm friends with a famous person who's a famous cellist or a famous swimmer or a famous artist, I don't care. I can't swim and do art and play the cello. I don't care about any of that stuff. I just like status. I'm like, "Yeah, this is my friend. She's the greatest cello player on the

planet. Isn't this awesome?" I don't feel any negative comparison there because that's not important to me. It's not ego-relevant.

5.69 So I can be friends. I can be close with somebody who has high status if it's not an area I'm comparing myself with. What we end up doing with our close relationships is negotiating a bit, associating with status, but also our own social comparison. You end up with weird things like William James, who I talk about. James is a genius, crazy genius. His dad was a crazy genius. His brother was a crazy genius. His sister was a crazy genius. But William James' brother was Henry James, the novelist, who wrote Victorian novels, totally different area. His sister Alice was a diarist, which was a big deal back then, was writing diaries. They were all very successful, but in a little different area.

5.70 You see that sometimes in families with twins or something, where they get success, but a little different area, so they're not competing with each other directly, because it gets rid of some of that social comparison process. That's pretty interesting, I think. A few other things to mention about this, that self-enhancement can mess with our memory in different ways. We distort our memory of things in a more enhancing way. Nietzsche had a line about one of his aphorisms, like, "My memory tells me one thing, my pride tells me another, and my pride wins." Some little quip.

5.71 But what happens is, we will remember things and we'll put a spin on it that makes us look a little better. And we do some other stuff like, the way we even think about ourselves in the past. If it's something we're proud of that we did, "Oh, man, I remember that trip to Cabo. That was awesome," I'll remember myself in the first person doing it because it feels part of me. It's something I want in my life. So I'll remember myself doing that and relive it. If it's something I'm ashamed of that I did in Cabo, when I visualize it, I'm visualizing it like I'm a third person looking at myself, my old self, who's different than me. That's old me, old Keith, not even me, really at all. I'm watching that thing happen, but it's different than me.

5.72 You can put a distinction between your current self and your past self by literally the way you visualize it or experience your past. If your past is positive, you can relive it and feel good. If your past is negative, you can think of it as another person, having that past. We do both of these, but that's just the way our whole memory gets shifted towards enhancing ourselves. The overall rule or model of self-enhancement is that we self-enhance when there's opportunity. When the environment is ambiguous or flexible and we get a chance to self-enhance, we're more likely to do it. When we don't have that flexibility, it's harder to do it.

5.73 So, if I ask a bunch of students on a 10-point scale, "How smart are you?", people are going to self-enhance a little bit. They're like, "Yeah, I'm a seven and a half." Sure. If I say, "What's your GPA?" They're going to say, "3.2." They're probably not going to lie because I asked a very specific question, and if their GPA is a 3.2, they're not going to say it's a 4.0, because I asked a very specific question, and if they do that, they're just essentially lying to me. It's not really self—they might do that on a job application to lie,

but it's harder to tell yourself a story that you have a 4-point when you really have a 3.2.

5.74 But it's easy to tell yourself a story that you're smart even when you're maybe not quite as smart, because smart is something broad and harder to define. We also strategically define things like, "Are you a good leader?" "Oh, yeah." "Well, what does being a leader mean?" "Being a good leader means being nice." OK. "Are you a good leader?" "Yes." "What does a good leader mean?" "It means being able to kick people's butts and motivate them to get somewhere." Yeah. So, everyone thinks they're a good leader. They just define leadership as what they're good at. Does that make sense?

5.75 When there's the ambiguity in life, we strategically pump ourselves up. But when you get rid of ambiguity, you don't. If you want to know the truth about people, you ask very specific questions. If you're really doing a job interview, you're going, "Oh, that sounds really good." "Oh, it just so happens I have an Excel spreadsheet right here. Why don't you run some of those Excel model models, and let's see how you do?" You'd actually do a test because you don't want to believe people. Self-enhancement feels good. It's something we do when we have opportunity.

5.76 One of my favorite sayings that never, ever caught on is that reality always wins. Whatever story we tell ourselves, whatever we think, we can do it for a while, we can feel good, but reality always wins. You can't really think your way out of your own life. You can't tell the lie forever. So be strategic with self-enhancement. In terms of the feeling of self-enhancement, often you think of something like self-esteem. "I feel good." Sometimes I think about it as just a feeling of esteem, which is almost like a positive emotion or energy. We don't really have good measurement of that, but we do have some emotions that are social emotions that tend to go with self-enhancement, and those are versions of pride.

5.77 The emotion that often goes with enhancement is pride. "I'm proud of myself. I'm a good person. I did a good job. I'm the boy with the thumb in a pie or whatever, and I feel great." There's been some cool research on, what is this social emotion of pride? This is done by Jessica Tracy and some of her students at British Columbia. What's interesting is, pride can be expressed in different ways. There's a prosocial way of expressing pride and a less prosocial way of expressing pride.

5.78 The prosocial way of expressing pride, they call authentic pride. It's often accompanied by a sense of joy, maybe a sense of positivity and celebration and energy. Physically, you're like, "Yay." When you see somebody express that, it's not really a turn-off. If I'm watching somebody, I was just watching a swimming competition recently, and somebody just ran a great meet. If they jump out and they're like, "Yes," and they hug their friends, it makes me feel good. I'm not, "Look at that arrogant." I'm like, "Wow, that person really did it and feels good about herself. That's fantastic." And there's high fives. That's authentic pride. That's like feeling good.

- 5.79** The other face of pride that's a little more negative and a little more narcissistic and a little bit about superiority is what they call hubristic pride. It's more like, "I won, in your face." I've never said that. I have a lot. We used to say that all the time in the '80s. But you'd win, so we'd be like, "In your face." So they do arms akimbo. I don't know where this word comes from, but like, "In your face, loser." That pride feels good, too. I mean, it feels good to stamp on your enemies and make them feel small and weak and laugh and mock at them. But it's a short-term feeling of goodness, and you lose a lot of relationships.
- 5.80** Because if you're a bad person, if you're a wrestler and that's your role, you'll get some fans because everyone likes a bad person occasionally. But generally, it's not a positive thing. That sense of hubris, that sense of superiority, cockiness, arrogance, dismissiveness. We call it poor sportsmanship. If somebody won a game and was doing stuff like that, you would be like, "I don't really like that person." We like more celebratory pride. Yeah, that's it. It's all the celebration. You're watching football and people dancing and stuff. You're like, "That's great. Celebrate." But people who are making fun or mocking, and you're like, "That's silly."
- 5.81** So pride is interesting. In terms of individual differences in self-enhancement, there are individual differences, and the primary one is narcissism. That narcissism is essentially the individual difference that assesses level of self-enhancement. People who are more narcissistic are just generally more self-enhancing. I'm not going to go into narcissism because I did a narcissism course, and I spent my whole career on it. But I want to just break it down very simply into three forms of narcissism, three forms of self-enhancement, just to make the point that I thought might be useful in a short period of time.
- 5.82** There's different forms or flavors of narcissism that you find. Narcissism is generally having an inflated and positive view of oneself. The most common form of narcissism that you are familiar with, the one you see in all the TV stars and the politicians and everybody and all your exes, is grandiose narcissism. That is a sense of superiority on agentic traits, on things like physical appearance, social status, intelligence, money. That's your classic narcissism. "I'm better looking than you. I'm more important than you. I'm more powerful than you. I'm better than you. I'm just a cooler person than you." That's grandiosity.
- 5.83** But it's not like, "I'm kinder than you." It's a certain kind of arrogance that we're familiar with. That's grandiose narcissism. That's what most of us think about. Well, one of Constantine Sedikides' students, Jochen Gebauer, back in the day, said, "Oh, that's interesting. What if people were like that, but instead of about agentic traits, like looks and power and status, it was about more communal traits? That people were arrogant about what a good friend they were, how nice they were, how moral they were? What would that look like?" And he came up with this concept of communal narcissism.

- 5.84** "I'm the best friend anybody could ever have. I'm just a little more moral than most people. Yeah, I just do good things most of the time, more than most people do." It's a moralistic form of narcissism. You don't see it very—it's hard to see very much. I mean, believe me, I see it all the time. But it's hard to just see very, it's not as clear because it's people like, "Yeah, I'm really nice." Reminds me the old church lady in the old Saturday Night Live skits that were probably before most of your time, but a very moralistic superiority. So it's a different flavor of narcissism because it's enhancing in a different domain. That's communal narcissism.
- 5.85** A final form of narcissism is vulnerable narcissism. This is the more defensive form of narcissism that is associated with lower self-esteem and more insecurity and more vulnerability. What's going on with vulnerable narcissism is not so much about enhancing on agentic traits; it's about self-protection on agentic traits, primarily, though, some communal. Meaning that people who are more vulnerable narcissists are like, "Wait, are you saying I'm not attractive? Oh, are you trying to judge me?" "Dude, I don't even care about you." "Are you saying you don't care about me?" "Yeah, I don't."
- 5.86** It's defensive. It's more, "Are you looking at me? Are you just being dismissive of me? Do you not respect me? Do you not recognize what a genius I am?" My god, no. That's vulnerability. So vulnerable narcissism is one you don't see very much unless you're in a clinical setting where you have people when they're like, "Yeah, no one respects me, and no one treats me the way they should," blah, blah, blah. But you don't notice it as much in real life because it's much more defensive. Grandiose narcissism you see because it's more like, "Check me out."
- 5.87** If we went to South Beach on a field trip right now, a narcissism field trip, it would be really fun. But we'd see more grandiosity. You could see the grandiosity, like the dude, like the Lambo. I mean, I want one. I had that poster on my wall when I was a kid. But I'm thinking grandiosity. I'm not thinking communal. I'm not thinking vulnerability so much. Just grandiosity. Anyway, I just think narcissism is interesting to think about as an individual difference in propensity to self-enhance. Simple.
- 5.88** Then there are a couple questions that I will have time to answer, fortunately, which are, OK, we've got self-enhancement. That seems great because it makes us feel good about ourselves, but it has costs if we know the truth. So if I'm self-enhancing all the time and you're telling me I'm bad, and I'm like, "No, I'm not bad, I'm good," I'm not learning information. If I'm failing tests but going, "Yeah, the professor's an idiot. I'm not going to study more," I'm not learning. So self-enhancement is, it allows me to feel good, but it buffers me from learning or developing or growing me. It keeps me buffered from failure.
- 5.89** So maybe there's a way I could approach failure that would allow me to learn from it but not hate myself. So how could I approach failure and get the information, but not not like myself afterwards, still like myself after I fail? How could you do that? There's been some different efforts at that. One of my favorite ideas comes from Kristin Neff.

She's at UT Austin, and she works on what's called self-compassion. It's a little different than self-esteem. It's a little different than narcissism. It's a way of essentially treating yourself with compassion when you deal with negative events. She breaks it down into three different processes that I find relatively powerful.

- 5.90** Imagine you just failed a big exam and you're beating yourself up because, god, we are vicious to ourselves. At least, I mean, I would never treat my family the way I treat myself. So the first thing to do is, when something bad happens, is treat yourself with kindness like you would treat a friend. Just imagine you were treating yourself like you would a good friend who had the same experience. Nothing major. Just being nice to yourself. Don't beat the crap out of yourself. That's hard to do for some of us. So treat yourself with kindness like a friend. That's really important.
- 5.91** The second is this connection with broader humanity and the sense that what I'm going through is part of the basic human condition. So when bad things happen to us, it's natural to think we're being singled out for this bad thing, and it doesn't happen to other people. One of the famous parables in the Buddhist literature is called the mustard seed parable. I know there's a biblical mustard seed parable as well, but this is a Buddhist one. It's a story about a woman who loses her son. I'm always changing these a little. But imagine a woman loses her son and she's feeling suffering. It's terrible.
- 5.92** She goes to the Buddha and says, "My son died. Can you help me?" He goes, "Of course. Of course, no problem at all. I'd make a potion to bring your son back to life. All I need from you is, you just go out and find everybody who hasn't lost somebody they love, and have them give you a mustard seed, and bring back those mustard seeds, and then I'll make you a potion." She's like, "Fantastic." She goes out and starts talking to people. "Have you not lost?" "Oh, god, I lost somebody I loved. Yeah, I lost my granddad last week. I lost a kid. It was terrible." She can't get any mustard seeds. She comes back and she's like, "Yeah, I'm going to follow you." That's how those stories usually end.
- 5.93** She realizes that part of the human condition is loss, that that's part of our condition. And so her suffering is not her suffering; her suffering is part of her humanity. It's just part of how we are. So that connection with the broader humanity helps us take negative stuff. And the final piece is this practice of mindfulness, which has a lot of definitions that people use. When I try to figure out—I'll tell you my story. Why not? I was at a conference somewhere beautiful in Arizona. I guess we were up in—what's north of Scottsdale? What's that? Flagstaff. Yeah, we're up in Flagstaff at this wonderful conference.
- 5.94** And Kristin Neff was there. And we even had this time, we had this, we met in this hogan with this Navajo leader and talked about the Beauty Way, and we were talking about the loss of self. It was really fun, really great. I talked to Kristin. She talked about self-compassion. I went up after and I said, "Kristin, I have no self-compassion at all. I

didn't even know there was such a thing possible. What do I do?" She said, "You just need to sit. You just need to sit for a long time." I thought, "Well, that sucks." Basically, she's telling me that in meditation, that you'll naturally, in this process of developing mindfulness, you'll naturally develop some self-compassion out of this process.

- 5.95** Now, I don't know if it's true because I never really have gotten very good at it. What is mindfulness? I tried to figure out mindfulness. There's a lot of definitions. Mostly the definition we talk about are something like attention and awareness with acceptance or without judgment. You're aware and attentive of ideas. You see ideas going through your mind, but you don't attach those and apply judgments to them, and instead, you accept them. The mindfulness scales like Kirk Warren Brown developed, they're really popular, capture this idea of, "Yeah, I have thoughts that don't capture me, that don't make me reactive, that I just accept."
- 5.96** It's like clouds moving across the sky. Don't try to connect to them. I just let them move. That's how we talk about mindfulness. I had one buddy who was a Sanskrit scholar, and I went to one of his talks. It was an hour on what is mindfulness from one line in one Buddhist text and going through the etymology of it. The best I could determine was that mindfulness meant memory of the present. Essentially, like looking at the present as if you're looking at a memory. Which I thought, that's kind of an interesting idea. It's like you're looking at the present, but you're not attached to it.
- 5.97** There's something about this practice of mindfulness that seems to help with reactivity to thoughts. I think some of those negative thoughts about ourselves, we can not be as reactive if we practice. I think negative thoughts about others and relationships as well. I think, generally, the self-compassion idea and practice is really useful. I think, when I talk to people who are suffering, I'm like, "Treat them like a friend," common humanity. I think that stuff works. I like this idea. Again, it allows you to get negative information and not just go, "No, that's not true." Just go, "Yeah, that happened. That sucks. That's part of life. I'm just going to sit with it. It'll go away."
- 5.98** In conclusion about self-esteem and self-enhancement and the benefits and costs, my general sense is that the way we're built is to have some self-esteem. The reason for that goes back to Fritz Heider and this crazy idea called balance theory. But essentially, the idea is that we should like things we're connected to in order to have a consistent world. We should associate things that we like. So if we associate with our self, we should like our self for everything to be in balance. If we associate with ourselves and don't like ourselves, we're going to feel unstable or diseased or out of balance.
- 5.99** I think it's natural to be built to have some liking for what we're connected to. I'm guessing that's something we're wired up for. Self-esteem is also, like I've mentioned, it's a pretty strong buffer for depression. I've seen a lot of research on this done enough that I pretty much believe it, that people with higher self-esteem are less likely to become depressed. Part of the reason for that is, part of depression is not liking yourself. If you like yourself, it's hard to be depressed because depression means not

liking yourself. But that's an important buffer, and there's a lot of depression right now, so I think having self-esteem as a buffer from that is good.

5.100 The problem with self-enhancement and focusing on self-esteem, though, is you end up building a fantasy life and cutting off reality. So you're building a model of yourself that's maybe better than reality. So you can't really deal with reality as well. That's one thing. I think we can do OK with a little bit of a pump ourselves up a little bit, it's fine. But where you really see the damage is with relationships. If you're focused on building your own ego and your own enhancement, sometimes what costs you is love. I tell you, at the end of the line, when you're on that bed, you want to be surrounded by love. You don't want to be surrounded by trophies from the '70s. You want somebody who loves you next to you.

5.101 So self-enhancement is probably a bit of a golden mean. We want some, not too much. Keep yourself enhanced enough to feel good, be a positive force, but don't get so caught up in self-enhancement that you end up ruining your relationships and costing your life to be something you shouldn't be. That's it. Thanks.

Lecture 6: The Narrative Self

At a glance — The narrative self.

- 6.1** We've talked a lot about more structural stuff about the self and some dynamics. What I wanted to talk about in this lecture was the idea of the self as a story, the idea of the self as a performance or a narrative or an act. Remember, I traced this back to Shakespeare. I'm sure it goes farther back. There must have been some Greeks. I know in the Vedas, they talk about life as a play. But there's this idea of the story. What that makes the self—I've used this phrase a lot because I love it—is, the self is the narrative center of gravity.
- 6.2** I imagine that this is a Daniel Dennett—rest in peace, my friend—line, that you can imagine a story that's going on in your life where you're the main character. Now, that's a little different from main character syndrome or whatever they talk about on TikTok these days, which is a fancy term for narcissism and attention-seeking and histrionism. What it means is, the story we tell is our story. We're not telling our kid's story. We learn our family's story maybe from our parents, but we're telling our story, and that's what our life is.
- 6.3** It's something that we start doing when we're teenagers. We start to figure out who we are, how we fit in with things, who we want to be, what our strengths are, what our values are. As we get older, this story gets a little more elaborate. One of the ways this struck me, this was an old, an old story by an industrial psychologist said, I wanted to figure out how CEOs did, what their secrets were. I interviewed a bunch of CEOs, and I thought what they'd tell me is being a CEO is about gumption, hard work, and keeping your eye on the ball, or whatever CEOs would say. They never said that. Everyone would tell a story.
- 6.4** "I started out doing this, and then I got into this, and I started doing this, and I learned this skill, and I learned this skill, and this skill, and now I'm applying all those skills to try to make something work." People see their lives like a biography, like a story. Seeing your life as a story also means you're performing in the story. You're like a character. You're like Huck Finn or whatever. You're like the woman in the Hunger Games, Katniss. You're the person in the story. There's an actor in the story, and there's an audience in story.
- 6.5** There's a lot of neat work on this going back to old sociology. When we think about classic sociology of the self as a performance, you go back to Erving Goffman in the '50s, and you'll hear this name all the time in sociology world. He used this metaphor of people being an actor, and then he took the metaphor a little farther. He said, well, here's what's interesting about it. Imagine you're an actor. Well, what does that make life? It makes life a stage. Now, how does a stage work? Well, there's a front stage and there's backstage.

- 6.6 So front stage is when you get on there and you put on your outfits and you stand on the X and you do your lines and you do your thing and you try to perform for the audience. And then backstage is where you go sit in the green room and put your feet up and have a beer and try to eat a bunch of KitKat bars that somebody left back there and you talk about stuff and you make jokes and it's informal. The idea with life as a performance is, there's a more front stage or performative aspect of it. But there's this other part where you don't perform it.
- 6.7 I remember going to church when I was young. I'd see the priests. I was raised Episcopalian, which is like the British version of fake Catholic, so it looks very similar. You'd have priests in a robe, and I'd always seen priests in a robe. Every once in a while, you go backstage behind the church afterwards, and the priest has his robe off and he's wearing his Doc Martens or something. You're like, this doesn't look like a priest. It's just a guy. What happened? The magic's lost. I like my priests in a robe. When we do graduation, we all dress up like Harry Potter. We put on our academic stuff, and it's fun. You're like, "I'm Harry Potter and everybody's Dumbledore." That's part of the ceremony that makes it work. That front stage is important.
- 6.8 Then there's a couple of things about that. One is what Goffman called the personal front. Those are things like your outfit. It's your robes if you're an academic, or if you're a judge or if you're a priest. It's your hairstyle, it's your hand, it's the whole performance. It's the personal front. There's also the set or the setting. If you go to a theater, there's a whole bunch of people that are in theatrical design and stage and setting, and they were all the nerds. They were your friends in high school, and that's what they did. But they had a very important job being nerds. They set up the context for a performance.
- 6.9 You'll notice this all the time now. When you go visit, next time you're in a CEO office and you look around, you realize that office is a movie set. That office was set up to make somebody look powerful and important or not, whatever the case may be. CEO office will have a desk. The chair will be raised a little bit. When you talk to some of these guys, they do it intentionally to keep their chair three inches higher, so they're always looking down. Then the office will have pictures of the leader with other famous people shaking their hands.
- 6.10 There'll be a random picture of them with O.J., well, maybe not O.J. Simpson anymore. Sorry, when I was young, I grew up in LA, he was our hero. I guess things have changed. Hank Aaron, let's say. He's a good dude. It's like, shaking hands with Hank Aaron. You got one with the President. You got two presidents from two parties. So people know that it's just all money to you. That's the power play, right? Like you, dude, they're all the same. They're just politicians. I just pay for whatever I want. Then you'll have a nice piece of art.
- 6.11 The studies of the real, I shouldn't say psychopathic, the more narcissistic, aggressive CEOs, one of the people interviewed, I'm forgetting his name, that was not Neutron

Jack. They called him Chainsaw Al Dunlop. They always had these names for these big killer CEOs. So Neutron Jack Welch was the head of GE, and he was called Neutron Jack because he'd wipe out all the people but keep the supplies in the company when he took it over. And Chainsaw Al Dunlop was known as "chainsaw" because he'd come in companies and just chop them up to pieces with a chainsaw. And his office had just dead animals behind him. So, like, a big head of things you'd kill.

- 6.12** When you go in those offices, that's when you're like, that's a set, right? That's a set saying, "I kill things. Here's a puma I killed." But that's a set. Academics set up their office. What we do is we put a bunch of books up, and people walk in there. "That Keith guy must be smart. He read all those books." I'm like, "Yeah, he would be smart if he read all those books." But they were nice gifts from people, and he put them up there. So you'd think that. So it's a prop. So this front stage is a personal front. It's setting a context. And the backstage is where we get more relaxed.
- 6.13** One of the challenges with the modern world is we've broken the backstage and front stage. So there's not the private space anymore. I go perform in public, and then I go backstage, and I'm talking to someone like, "Yeah, I was lying the whole time. I'll tell you what I really think. Pass the vodka." Then somebody's videotaping the whole thing. Pretty soon, that's my performance on YouTube. You're like, Keith Campbell giving a lecture. I'm like, "Dude, I was just talking. I didn't mean to. It wasn't really vodka." Doesn't matter. Too late. That's why everyone's gone crazy. With a lot of reasons, we've gone crazy.
- 6.14** But the panopticon, the fact that we don't have a backstage, that anything could be filmed—I can't imagine being a kid right now. I can't imagine being a teenager without any freedom. That's the idea of this life as a performance. There's some interesting things with the performance. First is that there's a lot of self-presentation in our performance, and this is essentially like self-enhancement. We want to put ourselves out there in a positive way. Believe it or not, I usually don't look this good. You're like, dude, this guy really didn't put in a lot of work, but I promise I did, or else I'd just be wearing my Lulu shorts and maybe a shirt, would not be wearing shoes.
- 6.15** You put in, I guess it's strategic self-presentation. That is being effortful or intentional about how you appear to people. That's part of it. Part of this strategic self-presentation in the old sociology might be hiding certain things. You might hide stigmas. My vision is terrible. I wear glasses here because I have to read that screen back there. But otherwise, I never wear glasses. I'm just blind. I just walk around, like everybody's in a haze. I realized it's nice because it's like everything's got a fuzz on it, and I don't recognize anything. It's just like, I'm all tranquil.
- 6.16** I'm hiding my stigma. I can't freaking see it, but I'm not hiding it now because I have to be able to see. You do things like that. Job interviews and dates are places where we perform a lot. Most of us know in job interviews that people will gild the lily or they'll put lipstick on the pig or whatever you want to say. They'll present themselves in a very

positive way, which is why I mentioned before giving people actual tests. I know my daughter was applying for banking jobs, and they would have, I think they had technicals. Every job, she'd have to use technical skills, so she couldn't lie. She couldn't just write on a resume. They'd be like, "Go do this thing."

- 6.17** We do the dating, we strategically self-present, so we do that thing. Another thing that's really interesting about this performative aspect of the self is we have an idea of who we are, and we're using symbols to convey that idea. What we assume is the other person who's the audience is going to treat us the way we want to be treated. I'm putting out symbols to be treated one way, and I assume people will treat me that way, but sometimes they don't, and then we have to negotiate. This is called identity negotiation or symbolic interactionism. That's the fancier term.
- 6.18** Let me give you an example. I'm an academic. I generally present myself in a casual way, just a basic casual way. I just wear a little more casual clothes. Why do I do that? Well, I'm comfortable in casual clothes, but also people will talk to me if I seem more casual, and they will challenge me if I seem more casual, and that will force me to be smart. So people will ask me hard questions, and I will have to answer them. I could dial up my look by trying to look smart and pompous and intimidating all the time, and then people would be intimidated by me and no one would ask me anything, and I would never learn or grow. But people would treat me a certain way.
- 6.19** You modify that formality, depending on if you want to talk to people. For me, learning about the human condition, which is my job, means I got to talk to a bunch of young people. The only reason they'll talk to me is if they trust me and they think I'm not just a total dork. Like, a 50% dork is good, 80% dork is not good. If I'm talking to somebody and then they're saying, "Professor Campbell," and all this, I'm like, "Dude, I appreciate that in the classroom. Just call me Keith." That's identity negotiation. I'm like, "You don't have to. Come on, man, we're just talking." That's identity negotiation.
- 6.20** Or it could be a case where I'm in a classroom, and a student comes up and they're like, "Hey, dude. Hey, Keith." And they high-five me. And I'm like, "Oh, geez." I mean, I can't just be the high-five guy. I've got 300 kids here. I've got to have a little bit of status. I'm like, "Just Dr. Campbell in here. Professor Campbell. Dr. K. Professor PK. I don't care. But you can't just call me bro." And so, both of those times, what I'm doing is, I'm trying to negotiate my identity with people to keep it at a point where it's formal enough that I can have control of a classroom, but maybe informal enough where I have communication.
- 6.21** This is just one example. We do this all the time. If you want to mess with people, you just do the opposite. They're wearing their peace stuff and their hippie stuff. You just come up and ask them about if they want to go shooting with you or something. Like, what? Hey, you want to go into the beef? You want to come to the Brazilian steakhouse? They're like, "No, I'm a vegan. Can't you tell? I was wearing moon pants." I

mean, that's what vegans wear. "I have cotton flip-flops." But that's an identity negotiation, right?

- 6.22** What we spend a lot of time doing in our performance is adopting symbols of certain things in our culture and then negotiating, and obviously go to a different culture and no one knows how to read your symbols. People don't know what to make of you because the symbols are all different. This happens all the time. When I work with a lot of young people, I don't know what's cool anymore. Every young person to me looks like they're dressed in the '80s or '90s, but it's like a mix-match with some '70s. I don't know what any of the symbols mean.
- 6.23** I talked to one bartender. I'm like, "You got a '30s prison outfit going. Do you know that?" And he had his sleeves up, this little soft cap. I'm like, "Do you not—?" No idea. My whole childhood from Laguna Beach, they turned that into a whole clothing company. So people can just go, like lightning bolts. That was all the rainbows and stuff. That's how I grew up. People can take identities and repackage them, and you don't even know what they mean anymore. It's a complicated thing. Identity negotiation is really fun. It's a fun, sometimes challenging way.
- 6.24** This is how marketing works, and the material self, and this is why you have a stylist. If you want to change your identity, you change your outfits and a lot of things. A couple other things you see with this stage metaphor, one is the idea of social scripts. We have scripts or rules of action for doing things, and we all know them. We don't know we know them, but they're sort of implicit. I know what to do when I get to a restaurant. I know what to do when I get to an airport. I know what to do when I jump in an Uber or whatever.
- 6.25** I went to a concert recently. It was like a Bob Dylan show, and we got in line, and everyone's in this line. I didn't know what was going on. It was weird. Didn't have a script for it. What they did was took everybody's cell phone and put them in a bag. That was weird. I was cool. I really liked it. It was like a time warp. This is really nice. Everyone's talking and being like it's the '80s. But that was weird. Everyone was like, "I don't know what's going to happen." It's a little uncomfortable because it wasn't done. But if it happens again, then it will become part of the script, and then we'll do it. So scripts are important.
- 6.26** Social roles are really important. The social role you have is like the role you're playing in a movie. So the example I gave, imagine you're a priest; that's your priest role. When you're playing your priest role, you put on the robes, you act a certain way, you just do certain things. When you're not playing a priest role, you can relax. Playing a professor role, you have to act a certain way, do a certain thing. When you're not playing that role, you don't have to do it. Most of our jobs or occupations have a social role with them, and that role is literally like a role in a movie.

- 6.27** This is what you do when you're a bellman. Like I said, that's my dream is to be a bellhop down at Anna Maria Island, just carry bags for people every day. "Great day today, guys. I think it's going to be sunny." It's every day. Same story. That's a social role you're taking, and you learn how that role works. When we develop a new social role, we learn the qualities of people in that role. We get mentors, we have role models, as we call them. We model ourselves off somebody.
- 6.28** I'm thinking, in my academic career, I modeled myself very much after my advisor, just my whole way of mentoring people. I'm like, that's how Constantine did it. That worked well for me, and I did it that way. That's role model. I found a role, modeled myself off somebody, and then adopted a role. Social roles are cool.
- 6.29** The audience is also a big part of this. It seems that an audience is something we develop over time. When we're young, we're performing typically for our parents or parent. If you have kids, you'll sit around at home and the kids are like, "I'm doing a show." The kid will run around, "Look at this. I'm doing this." Running around naked. You're like, "What?" These young kids are nuts, but they love putting on performances. OK, we're going to do dresses. We're going to do dress show. OK, we're doing a fashion show. And dad's the audience. Then as you get older, they get older, the audience becomes broader, it becomes more social.
- 6.30** Over time, what we develop is what George Herbert Mead, the old sociologist, called the generalized other. In our head, we have this generalized audience we're performing for. If I practice a talk in my head, I'm practicing for a general audience. If I think about how I'm going to come across in a meeting, I think about a general audience. We abstract all these people we perform to and we create this generalized model in our head. It doesn't mean we can't imagine how it would be in this group and imagine how it would be in this group. But generally, there's a general—
- 6.31** When I do podcasts and stuff, I usually ask people like, "Hey, who's your audience?" People will give you a 2-minute, 50-second, "20- or 30-year-old people interested in self-improvement and psychology." Boom, done. Mostly psychotherapists, but all that, boom, done. You get your audience, and that's going to change your performance. You're going to perform to the audience you have. But you build a general audience first. The audience can be active. So audiences play a big role in performance. That's why I'm very grateful to you guys. You're thinking, "Why are you so grateful?" I'm grateful because you're just looking at me. And if you stop looking or start looking down, I'm going to start to hate myself.
- 6.32** It's that sociometer. I'm like, "These people aren't looking." My self-esteem will start to drop. My energy will go down. I'll start to panic. And then I'll start making jokes because I'll be desperate, and it'll go downhill fast. Like, right now, I feel the collapse happening, and I'm going to run. It's really important to have—the audience is really important. Then you can get audiences with hecklers. If you go to comedians, they'll

have an antagonistic audience, and you'll have to develop a way of dealing with an antagonistic audience, or you can have, like you guys, a really positive audience.

- 6.33** In sporting events, there's a huge thing of the energy of the audience. In a football game, they'll be like this. So the players will be like, "Come on, guys. Scream because we need that energy." So the audience is part of it. This is another of my Grateful Dead comments from Bob Weir. I love it. He said, "The performance doesn't happen on the stage. The performance happens at the apex between the audience and the band." So there's the band, the audience, or the speaker and the audience, and this is the performance. It's something up here. There's a magic that happens. It's not about either of the individuals.
- 6.34** I think this performative aspect on the self suggests that a lot of the interesting stuff that happens to us isn't in our own head, and we don't grab it for somebody else. It's in that interaction with people. It's that sacred space in the dialogue or in the performance where real magical stuff happens. I love talking because weird things happen. I don't like writing at all because I don't have an audience. I just write and I just send it to the void. I just like to see faces. So the audience is cool. That's the idea of the self as the actor, as the performance. But what about the script or the story itself? What story are you acting?
- 6.35** That's the narrative. When we talk about something like narrative approaches to the self, or self-narratives, what we're talking about are stories we tell about our own life. What these stories do, well, they do a lot of things, but a big thing they do is they help us keep all the pieces of our life together in a way that's coherent and makes sense and maybe it's meaningful and maybe it's positive, just like any story. My kids are like, "Hey, how was it getting to Miami?" I could tell the story two ways. I'm like, "Well, I got in the car, and then this happened, this happened, and that happened." That's a pretty boring story.
- 6.36** So I tell this story. "Oh, my god, you wouldn't believe it. First thing that happened, I get to the airport and I'm at the wrong terminal. Oh, god, yeah, I'm at the south terminal, so I got to figure out the north terminal." Now, that's a story, right? So a story has some drama, had some action. I always say this to people. "Your dream in life is to have your life be a smooth sail." I just started and it was seamless and I was CEO. But when you listen to CEO do the talk, that's never the story you want to hear. Who wants to hear that story? "It's pretty easy. When you're real smart like me and your parents are rich, just follow the path and you just end up where the path gets."
- 6.37** Yeah. No. "If I'd failed, they literally would have just given me the job. It was nothing." No one wants to hear that. You want to hear the story? It's like, "Yeah, I went for it and I failed so bad. And then I fought my way back, and then I did this, and it was great. And then this happened, and I had to redo the whole thing. But then I figured this out, and I got my act together." Man, you're like, "Yes, that's a story. And you're like me because

we've both failed. And you're like me because we both have a chance of making it to the top, and you made it to the top, and I will."

6.38 A story with drama is a story you want, but you don't want to go through that life to get that story. It's no fun going through the drama, but that's the better story to tell. You don't want the easy story. Anyway, I'm thinking, my best Russian fishing story. We get stuck in Russia, our plane's broken, the ruble collapses. They're like, "We got to get you guys out to this dockhouse somewhere, or you're going to get kidnapped." We're hiding out for two days in these mineral baths, eating caribou meat. That was awesome. It was so horrifying. I remember I got back to Alaska and kissed the ground, literally, on the tarmac.

6.39 I'm like, what a great story. But not at the time. It wasn't so great. That's like life is weird. A lot of the good stuff becomes bad and the stuff that's too easy is not so good at the end. That's the narrative of the self. It gives us control, it gives us meaning. People have looked at this with diary-keeping. Someone asked about this earlier. There's this interest in sense-making. One way we make sense with stories is diary or journaling. We can literally, at the end of the day, write down what we did and make sense of it.

6.40 Jamie Pennebaker, who is a psychologist at UT Austin, very interested in these narrative approaches, one of the first people to do it, started looking at narratives and diary-taking in health. He had first-year freshman students come in. When you start university, everyone's all excited, "I'm going to university." All your boomer parents are like, "Oh, it's great. You get to drink beer and go to rock bands." And you're like, "It's not like that anymore, mom." And then you get to school and you're homesick and it's hard, because it's hard to make friends and it's hard to fit in and you don't know what to do. And it's just a challenge. It's a transition.

6.41 So what Pennebaker had people do was take, had half a group do journaling and the other half just write about something else, usual control design. He found that the kids who were doing diaries of the transition, especially if they were using language about causation and control. "Yeah, it was really tough because of this. I'm going to do this now. Yeah, this happened for this reason, and I'm going to change things up and do it this way now." People who had those kind of diaries that had some sense-making in it, they just got sick less. I mean, they went and looked at the campus sickness. They just seemed to adjust better. There seems to be some health.

6.42 Basically, you're reducing the stress, and by reducing the stress, you're reducing colds and other sicknesses. It seems that building a narrative intentionally that has meaning and puts you as a causal agent in your life, meaning, I have a sense of control over where I want to go or where I want to be, seems to be beneficial. It seems to have some health benefits. I said, thinking of yourself as a victim isn't probably going to do that. It's more about control. It's not so much of telling the story about poor me; that's

probably not going to get you out of your ride. But it's a little more story with control and agency in it.

- 6.43** Storytelling is an important, it's just part of everything. Now, what kind of stories do people tell? People can tell any story. They could tell a million different stories about their life because everybody's life is different. There's thousands of life courses we can take. But when researchers started looking at the structure of stories, they started noticing some commonalities. People have come at this from the literary tradition, the old-school literary people, and thought about stories. People have come at this from more psychological perspective, and right now, what a lot of work is doing is using—it's quantitative computer analysis.
- 6.44** What you're doing is, you're taking the language and the word. It's computational linguistics, and you're taking the language in your story and you're extracting psychological information from that language. You can feed a narrative through and you could, say, extract a person's personality from that narrative. Extract their motivations from that narrative. "Oh, here's my story." "That sounds like a strong power motive." ChatGPT is starting to be able to do that. I've seen some papers where people were like, yeah, this actually works pretty well. Anyway, it's very interesting.
- 6.45** They definitely do it with personality. But pulling these motives out of stories is something we're going to be able to do. My guess is, in the next 10 years, that this sort of narrative approach to psychology and all sorts of social sciences is going to go up and up because of the computers. You can scrape a thousand stories and pull out the themes, just like pulling out the Big Five traits or the moral foundations. Here are some of the stories you see. There's just some classic patterns.
- 6.46** One is a tragedy story, or a contamination narrative, sometimes it's called, which is essentially, "I had it and I lost it." There's a million versions of that story, but "I had it all going for me. Everything was working, but then I got selfish, then I got greedy, then I made this mistake, then I got into drugs, then something happened, whatever, and I fell." It's a story of tragedy. Not a happy story, but it's a tragic story. We like watching tragedies for some reason. The Greeks—I don't know much about this. I don't know much about a lot. My understanding from hanging out with classicists is when Greeks would put on tragedies, like if you watched Oedipus Rex, you're cutting your eye, "I slept with my mom, I'm going to blind myself."
- 6.47** That's a heartbreaker. People didn't clap at the end. They just sit there and just go like, "Whoa." That's like catharsis. You just watch this tragedy like, "Oh, my god. Really? You slept with your mom. You're blinded? Geez. Oh, dark." That's tragedy. But we watch that stuff. I don't know. I mean, there's theories like it makes us feel better, but I almost think it's just human, and maybe we just feel human. I don't like tragedy. I'm like a Hollywood, dude. I wanted an end to jump into the plane and shoot everybody. I'm just dumb. I was raised in the '80s, PsyOp. I'm sorry.

- 6.48 They raised us. Our model was like, any guy who's just an angry enough loner can do anything he wants, like Rambo, Jean-Claude Van Damme. You could fight. There's that movie where the Russians attacked us and a bunch of high school kids beat the Russians. What was it? The Wolverine movie. I love that. Red Dawn. That was it. We were raised just like, "Oh, yeah, six of you guys, football players. You could take on the Russian army. Probably a bear, too." A Russian bear at different times. Stopping, I was going on a little bit. OK, so that's a more negative story.
- 6.49 Another story, and this is a really popular story in the US. This is a good US story we call Horatio Alger story, or an "up from my bootstraps" story. This is a story where I started at the bottom and I worked my way to the top. I started at the bottom of the social hierarchy, and I pulled myself up from my bootstraps, meaning, I reached down, I grabbed my straps of my boots, and I pulled myself up to the top. Now, it's impossible. You can't pull yourself up by your bootstraps. But that's why it's such a great story, because it's a story about an individual starting with nothing and becoming great.
- 6.50 Americans love that story. The McDonald's guys, they just started with one little shop, and next thing you know, they owned all the McDonald's in the world. That's just such a great story. We love those stories. We love the story of the one person who just starts an empire. Then we hate them once they have an empire. But it's funny. They like the story when they build the empire. We don't like the story, like, "Rich kid gets richer." It's not so fun. That's not a fun story. No one wants to hear that. Bill Gates, rich dad, gets him rich job and he's rich. You're like, yeah.
- 6.51 But you like the hustle. You like the hustle stories. We like it. Those "up from my bootstraps" stories are really popular. They're hard. That's why I mean, it's—god, there's so many. And then you get more complicated stories that involve both those things, like a redemption story. Like, "I had it, and then I lost it, and then I brought myself back. I came back." So they used to have all these stories about bands in the '80s. I remember every band in the '80s, this was the story behind the music.
- 6.52 "We had a great run in the '80s. We were real popular. I opened up for Berlin and the Go-Go's. And then, it's that darn cocaine again. We lost it all. And the bassist decided to start a chicken farm in Petaluma, and we didn't know what to do. And then everyone got into disco. But then we were back. We had a revival tour with a bunch of nostalgia-seeking 45-year-olds willing to pay for our tickets, and we're back better than ever." That's a redemption story. Everyone loves a redemption story because you go, "That person was a great person, they failed and they came back, and maybe I can do that, too." So a redemption, a redemption arc is a really powerful arc that we like in stories.
- 6.53 There's some other versions I'll skip. One other I wanted to mention was the story of generativity, because this is my age. This is a story that happens, '40s to '60s. People transition from a story about me achieving or creating something to a story about me helping the next generation achieve or create something. It's like generativity is like moving from your own achievement to more mentoring, more bringing the next

generation along. It's a change in your narrative about yourself. Rather than seeing yourself as just an agent for yourself, you're an agent of something broader.

- 6.54** Again, this is very common in 50 years old, late midlife. I was talking to my brother recently about this because he's significantly younger than me. He's feeling old. I'm like, "Well, one of the nice things about getting old is to mentor people." "Yeah, I talk to the young guys." I'm like, "Yeah, that's part of what you do. You get older and you kind of help the next generation. You're losing your power, but you help the young guys, and that's the circle of life. It's great."
- 6.55** That generativity narrative is really important as you get old because if you stick with the narrative that "I'm a cool guy," you're not cool. I'm sorry. You can only be cool first, and then you get old and unattractive no matter what you do. Even in Miami, you eventually aren't that good-looking. It's good to switch narratives. There are all these different narratives, and of all of them, of all the self-narratives, the one that really emerges is the primary story of all stories, if there is one, is called the monomyth, or the hero's journey, or the hero's quest, or maybe *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*, which is Joseph Campbell's book, or maybe it's a Hero Of. I get that mixed up quite a bit.
- 6.56** It's essentially the hero's story that has been told over and over and over. This idea of the hero's journey was first put out by a psychoanalyst named Otto Rank, who none of you ever read, but he's probably worth reading. Then it got picked up by a literary scholar and mythologist with a, didn't even have a degree, just a super smart guy named Joseph Campbell, who spent a lot of time studying myth and then put these myths together into this integrated work called *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*.
- 6.57** What he tried to do in this book is, he said, look, Freudian development, when Freud talks about development, he talks about the Oedipal complex. It's about you face your father, your father's going castrate you, and so you identify with your father and find somebody like your mom. That's the journey. Jung's theory, the journey is about looking inward and finding your soul and then finding the center of yourself. Just goes, those are both the same thing. They're both just heroes' journeys. They're just different versions of a hero's journey. I wonder if there are other versions of this.
- 6.58** He goes around the world and just captures all these different versions of this hero's quest, which I will explain and go into in a little bit. He diagrams this. If you read Campbell's work, you see this lovely circular diagram of the hero's journey, and it's a descent and then a return. That's the narrative. Sometimes you can think about it sideways as a spiral. You descend, but you come up higher than you start. There's a little bit of an increase in the process. He has a way he talks about it. Everybody writing movies in Hollywood has Joseph Campbell's companion to how to write a movie with the hero's journey. Every movie you see has a hero's journey written into it. You see this a lot.

- 6.59** But finally, some psychologists have started looking at it. What I thought I would do here, given this is Psychology of the Self, is talk about the most recent academic models of the hero's journey and just break it into these seven components and give you some examples. That's what I'm going to do. Hero's journey starts with the protagonist. This is the hero-to-be. This is one of the points that people miss in life, so I will just make it. People think that you start out as a hero and then you have the hero's journey. The hero's journey is not the journey that heroes take. The hero's journey is the journey that turns normal people into heroes.
- 6.60** Hercules wasn't a hero until he did his heroic acts. He did the labors of Hercules, and then he became a hero. But before that, he was just a scrub. Luke Skywalker, kind of a little whiny SOB, right? You guys probably saw that Star Wars. I remember seeing, I went to see Star Wars. I remember that. I'll tell you this story. This is '70s LA, man, Chinese theater. I'm with my grandma. We're all in line to see Star Wars. A kid comes up in a skateboard and he says, "Hey, man, you want to buy some ludes?" The guy tried to sell me quayludes with my grandmother when I was maybe 13. That was LA in the '70s. I just wanted to share that moment.
- 6.61** That's what I always remember. It's like burned in my brain. Then I remember that little Luke Skywalker. I think, "What a whiny little son of a gun. He is just a little bumbly little baby." That's how the hero starts. He's just a little guy. You start with the protagonist. We have lots of these stories. It could be Luke Skywalker. It could be Katniss in the Hunger Games. She starts out, she's just this nice girl out hunting deer, just a normal person, just a poor girl, not a hero. Harry Potter, just living under the stairs, just a little of a loser, doesn't have a bad dad.
- 6.62** You start with the protagonist. The second phase is, there's a shift. What just came, called the call to adventure. This often involves a synchronicity or serendipity. Something happens. It might be, you see a white rabbit and you just start chasing that rabbit. That would be synchronicity or serendipity. Or it could be that Darth Vader comes and kills your family. You're like, "Now I got to do something." Or it could be an owl starts sending letters under your door. Or it could be that the evil SOBs from District One come and say, "We got to kill a couple of you guys," and you go, "OK, I'm going to do it."
- 6.63** Whatever. There's a shift. You go from the normal world into this other world, and then you're on a quest. So this is the quest. This is where it starts. This is a mission or goal. What is it? I don't know. You got to find the philosopher's stone. You got to become a wizard. You got to win the Hunger Games. I'm going to forget what other, Luke Skywalker, you got to take out the, you got to blow up the old Death Star and take out the empire. You got a quest, right? You have to have a quest to do it.
- 6.64** Then your quest is helped by allies. In these stories, you always meet allies. These allies will sometimes take the shape of Jungian shadow figures. So in the Hunger Games, she meets the drunk, the SoCal guy, whatever his name is. Haymitch, something Haymitch?

Haymitch. But I know the actor because I think he just smokes a lot of weed. But that's like, he's a drunk guy and that's like a shadow figure. He's a slippery dude, but he's actually helping her out. So somebody like that.

- 6.65** You get Obi-Wan in the Star Wars. You get other helpers, too. So typically what happens is, you find these helpers that are often maybe shadow figures. The examples, I should say, I'm giving examples of external journeys. These are journeys to go get something, but the journey can be internal as well. It can be finding yourself. The story of the Buddha was rewritten by Hermann Hesse in the novel *Siddhartha*. Is that a novel ring any bells for anybody? A few people, OK. He won a Nobel Prize. It's been around enough. But *Siddhartha* is the story of the Buddha, but it's written from a Jungian angle.
- 6.66** In the story, you have the *Siddhartha* starts. This is the story of the Buddha. Just nice kid, rich kid, growing up, everything's awesome. Then I get a shift. "Hey, these people are dying. There's sickness, there's suffering. This isn't good. I'm going to die." And dad's like, "Oh, this is not, bad news, we'll throw a bunch of flowers over everything, get rid of all the vagrants and stuff." But Buddha gets something stuck in his head. He's like, "This isn't working for me. There's got to be something more to life than just stuff because stuff is going to vanish. It's not going to be here forever." And then *Siddhartha* ends up with Ananda and literally called his shadow because he was running through a Jungian program.
- 6.67** So that's an internal quest. Jesus' quest is an internal quest. So it can be an internal quest or it can be an external quest. You get your allies. One of my favorite characters in *Game of Thrones* was this little girl who would kill everyone, a little Stark girl. Yes, yes. And her ally was this man with no face or something that was like a killer assassin, a shadow figure, literally no face. But he trained her up to be a killer, to become self-possessed. You have allies like that. You meet allies, and then you're faced with the challenges. These are the labors that you have to go through.
- 6.68** These are the challenges you faced. These challenges are what create the process of you becoming a hero. This is the alchemy of being a hero. Hercules had to do all sorts of stuff because they just kept saying, "Oh, yeah, now that you—go clean out all the stalls of this great horse." What is it? Stalls of Augeas or whatever. "OK, now you did that. Go kill this lion. OK, now go get this fawn. OK, now—" So I forget the others. But they just keep telling him to go do these challenges.
- 6.69** In the case of the Buddha, his challenge is to overcome suffering. He has to overcome the dark forces, the ways of Mara at the end, and become enlightened. In *Harry Potter*, he's got to go down and do his descent into the underworld and get the invisibility cloak or this philosopher's stone or whatever. Whatever that challenge is, there's going to be a series of tests, and there's often a "Jonah in the belly of the whale" scene. There's like, people hit rock bottom, the dark night of the soul. Like, it's Jonah in the whale's belly, and I don't even think it was a whale in the original text.

- 6.70** I started reading the Bible again, and everything I was taught was not really how they write it. So everything, I'm always a little confused. You're like, "Wait, that's not a whale. That's a totally, it's a Leviathan. What the heck?" But that's Jonah going in the whale. Moby Dick is a hero's journey. Moby Dick, everyone dies at the end, and Moby Dick is saved by a coffin which holds the body of his friend Queequeg. Queequeg is the shadow figure to Ishmael and Moby Dick. But that's what saves him at the end. You go through these challenges and you hit rock bottom. The famous scene in Star Wars was the trash compactor scene. They're all in the trash compactor, being compacted together, and they're thinking they're going to die.
- 6.71** Now, think about that from a psychoanalytic or Freudian. That's the trash compactor. You're in the depths of the unconscious, just the trash, the refuse, the junk, and you're fighting with that, and then you emerge out of that. There's a group of challenges people go through, and then there's the process of transformation in these challenges. You learn and grow and become strong and you become a hero by going through everything.
- 6.72** So Hercules successfully goes through his challenges. Little Luke Skywalker gets trained by Yoda or by Obi-Wan, and then by Yoda, and then his dad castrates him, but he still fights back. Yeah, that whole thing, like the dark father cutting his hand off. It's very Freudian. But then he recovers from that, gets a new hand just like Osiris. And then he comes back and he becomes a Jedi. He becomes a guy you respect after the whole process. There's this process of transformation that happens in the hero's journey.
- 6.73** Sometimes this can turn you into a god. The term we use for this is apotheosis or the transformation into a deity, a deos. Sometimes somebody like the Buddha or Christ becomes godlike after they go through this process of transformation, or they become Jedi-like in this process of transformation. The final step—so you sort of start, you have your allies, you call, your allies, your challenges, you're transformed, and then you come back to the world. You come back with a gift. Joseph Campbell called this gift a boon. The psychologists call this a legacy. I like boon better than legacy, but no one knows what boon means.
- 6.74** You come back with a gift for humanity. So what is that gift? Well, I stole fire and I brought fire to the people. My punishment is to be stuck on a rock and have vultures eat my liver, but I did it because I'm Prometheus, and that's what I do. Or I'm Harry Potter and I got the sorcerer's stone or philosopher's stone or whatever they call it. Or I'm Buddha and I was enlightened. If you read Buddha's stories, I'm not telling anybody this stuff. They're not going to get it. I'm just enlightened. Then the people come up to him and they're like, "What's going on?" He's like, "I'm enlightened." They're like, "We don't believe you. You're lying."
- 6.75** Buddha does Earth-touching mudras. He's sitting down, he just puts his hand on the ground. Earth is his witness. And everyone's like, "Dude, OK." And then Buddha said, "OK, now I'm going to start teaching." When Lao Tzu, the Chinese scholar, sage, was

enlightened, he's like, "Peace out. I'm going to the West." And he starts heading out of China and they stop them at the border and they say, "Before you leave, you got to write everything down." This is the story. I don't know if it's true. And that's where you get the Tao Te Ching, was something he was forced to write on the way out.

- 6.76** So very often people will go through a transformation and they're like, "Yeah, I did it. I don't want to bring anything back because I'm going to screw things up." Everyone's like, "Bring us something." OK, "here's the noble truths. Here's my message. Here's my message of the resurrection. Here's my, here I got rid of the bad leader of the Hunger Games." Whatever it is, you bring something back. That's the process. That's the hero's journey. That's the transformation. You bring back a legacy.
- 6.77** The hero's journey is, like I said, it's something you see in almost every movie. I don't watch really movies anymore, so I'm so bad at coming up with examples. The last one, one of my favorites that was funny, that was like a such a hero's journey that you wouldn't think of was this movie about these guys in Las Vegas. They get drunk and then they get drugged and they lose their car or something. I forget. Anyway, there's lots of these movies that are comedies, but you're like, oh, my gosh, this is straight-up archetypal. One, the guy gets a face tattoo and his tooth knocked out. It's like aboriginal adulthood. It's like a classic adulthood ceremony.
- 6.78** So the people are writing this stuff in the movies, and that's what gives it the kind of the heavy meaning for us. So this path is out there. What are the benefits of this? And so this is more the psychological question. We're not like, I don't know if there is such a thing as a hero's journey, but we experience it. What does it mean to experience it? And what the research shows is that experiencing your life like a hero's journey, which you have the option of doing—you literally can think of yourself as a hero on a journey, or you can think of yourself as a consumer. So, I'm a consumer or I'm a hero on a journey. Which is going to give you, which life you're going to get from either of those self-definitions.
- 6.79** If you think of yourself as a hero, life, which is chaotic and really hard to understand, all of a sudden has purpose. You get a purpose from life and you get meaning because you're doing something for something. You've got a quest, you've got a goal, you're doing something. It gives your life meaning. You also have allies because part of the hero's journey is, you end up pulling up allies. They might be mentors, they might be these shadow figures, they could be trickster figures that are always getting you into trouble, but then help you get out of trouble. But you're attracting belongingness. You're attracting social connection.
- 6.80** So this hero's journey is a connected journey. Even though it's an isolated journey, the heroes are always connected. They're always connected with people. You're building competence and strength by when you're searching for goals. So whenever you're facing the challenges on the hero's journey, the challenges are what turn you into a hero. They're what make you stronger. It's not like, I had to get the right mindset to do

it. It's the doing it that changes you. It's not the thinking about doing it. It's not the reflecting. It's just doing stuff. If you do stuff, you will change.

- 6.81** I think about this a lot because if you do—I got kids, so I think about it. I'm old. I've already had my shots, so I'm not so worried. But I have kids. I think about younger people. The way life works is, if you lead a creative life, if you're an entrepreneur, you're a creative writer, you're an artist, you do creative stuff, you're going to fail. You're not just going to fail once. What I mean is, you're going to fail substantially. A substantial part of your life is going to be failing. That's just the nature.
- 6.82** I go talk to my accountant, I'm like, "Dude, what percent?" "Yeah, we're batting about 20% over here with my entrepreneurs." I'm like, "That's better than academics. We're batting about 35% with our publications." So we fail about two out of three, and you guys are failing four out of five. That's the nature of life. You're going out there trying to date. I mean, oh my god, I'm never getting divorced. Oh my god. I would never, oh, my goodness. My point is, life is really hard and you're going to fail. And so what I like to remember—this is one of my favorite quotes from Teddy Roosevelt.
- 6.83** Teddy Roosevelt did stuff. Most presidents, I'm not really impressed with. Teddy Roosevelt has a river named after him because he's the one who explored it first, the first guy to go down there. Not because he's a president, they named it after him. He wrote more books than me, and he's smart, and he's crazy, and he has this famous quote or saying or aphorism, whatever it is, called the man in the arena, which probably a lot of you have heard, but I'm just going to say it here because I think this is really important for understanding the hero's journey and the challenges. This is Teddy Roosevelt.
- 6.84** "It is not the critic who counts, not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood, who strives, who strives valiantly"—I hate that word—"who strives toughly, who errs, who comes short again and again because there's no effort without error and shortcoming, but who does actually strive to do the deeds, who knows great enthusiasms, the great devotion, who spends himself in a worthy cause, who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who know neither victory nor defeat."
- 6.85** God, that tears me up every time I hear it. There's a female version I gave my girls. But that's the hero's journey. You're the man in the arena. You go out there and you do it, and guaranteed, you're getting your ass kicked. Guaranteed, that's going to happen. But do you want to be that guy? Or do you want to be those, do you want to be a cold and timid soul who knows neither victory nor defeat? That's the question. That's the hero's journey. Do you want to do that? Or do you want to just sit in the audience and tell everybody they're a loser and eat popcorn? I don't know. That's up to you.

- 6.86 I had a funny popcorn story, and I'm not going to share it. OK, I'm going to share it because I have a few minutes left, and I'm going to tell one more thing because I've got another Nietzsche quote. I was really into wrestling. Not into wrestling. I'd never been to wrestling. Like, wrestling where they dress up and they do that wrestling in big arenas and stuff. I had a former student, and he was into the wrestling world. He was like best friend with John Cena and knew all this stuff. He's like, and he reaches out to me. He's like, "Dude, we're trying to understand why some wrestlers are popular or not. What do you think?" I said, "I've never been to wrestling. I don't know; this is so lame. I don't know."
- 6.87 He goes, "Well, I'll get you some tickets. Go check it out." I'm like, "Oh, cool. That'd be fun." I go down to arena and I get some popcorn and I sit down on my seats to watch the wrestling. The kid next to me, he was a kid, he's probably 25, 30 goes, "Can I share your popcorn with you?" It was the strangest thing. I had no idea what to say because I was like, "This is so weird. I don't have a script for this." So I said, "Sure." I'm like, what's this kid? I don't know if you've watched wrestling, it's amazing. It's just so funny. Everything is a stereotype. Everybody cheats. Then there's the guy, "We're done." Then a guy will just smash him in the back with a chair, and it's all scripted. It was honestly fun to watch.
- 6.88 I'm like, this is kind of fun. I'm talking to my buddy. I go, "How is this stuff popular?" "Because you don't understand," he goes, "with real sports, they have what happens, and then they have to make the narrative to make it interesting." He goes, "But we get to start with the narrative. So we write the script ahead of time. So it's always interesting." Anyway, that was my popcorn. I don't know why. It doesn't have anything to do with anything. It was interesting. I recommend wrestling if you ever get the chance to see it. It was fun.
- 6.89 This idea of being a hero is great, and it's great to be the man in the arena and everything else. We have a challenge right now in this world, is that we're essentially living in a postmodern world, meaning, it's a world where it's very hard to find meaning. It's hard to know what meaning is because your meaning and your meaning and your meaning and your meaning might be totally different. Our worldviews may be totally different, and it gets very hard. So, this idea of the postmodern self really goes back to Friedrich Nietzsche in *The Gay Science*. I was going to read you. This is the the classic section in *The Gay Science* about the death of God. Again, it starts with the madman who I think is Diogenes. So this is Nietzsche.
- 6.90 "The madman jumped into their midst and pierced them with his eyes. 'Wither is God?' he cried. 'I will tell you. We have killed him, you and I. All of us are his murderers. But how did we do this? How could we drink up the sea? Who gave us the sponge to wipe away the entire horizon? What were we doing when we unchained this Earth from its sun? Wither is it moving now? Wither are we moving? Away from all suns? Are we not plunging continually? Backward, sideward, forward, in all directions? Is there still any

up or down? Are we not straying, as through an infinite nothing? Do we not feel the breath of empty space?"

- 6.91** I mean, that's pretty intense, right? So first he's saying, like, Nietzsche's out there like, well, it's Diogenes in the boat. He's like, "We killed God. We just killed God. We did this." And then he looks at everyone, and no one gets it. So he's like, "Here the madman fell silent and looked again at the listeners; and they, too, were silent and stared at him in astonishment. At last, he threw his lantern to the ground, and it broke into pieces and went out. 'I have come too early,' he said then. 'My time is not yet. This tremendous event is still on its way, still wandering; it has not yet reached the ears of men. This deed is still more distant from them than the most distant stars, and yet they have done it themselves.'"
- 6.92** This is Nietzsche writing, probably 150 years ago, 130 years ago, about the death of God and the fact that no one knows it's happened. This is the Enlightenment, this is Europe, this is modernity. He's looking around and he's like, "You guys wiped out God. You've swapped in science and this other nonsense, and you don't even know what you did. Now we live in a world where there's no meaning. There's no gravity. There's nothing to ground yourself to. There's no self source of support. You did it. All you knuckleheads got together and decided to kill God. Now we live in a world where God is dead, and I think everybody knows that."
- 6.93** Now, I mean that, I'm not saying, I don't want anyone to go, "My god's alive," and come kill me. I'm just saying the idea is that we live in a postmodern world where we don't agree on any of this stuff. So what do you do with yourself? What is a postmodern self? And so this is an idea that some researchers looked at. Ken Gergen at Swarthmore spent a lot of time thinking about in particular, and he wrote this book called *The Saturated Self* I liked a lot. And he said, well, here's my life. I'm an academic. I go to Europe all the time, meet a girl on a train to France. We start talking about a friend over in Singapore. We have this very—it's a modern cosmopolitan lifestyle and belief system that's all connected and essentially just mush.
- 6.94** We have lots of beliefs, we have lots of preferences, we have restaurants we like, we have policies, but we don't have any foundational beliefs that we share. We're just these global citizens doing stuff, and we do a lot of stuff and have a very elaborate and complicated self, but there's nothing foundational to it. There's just nothing there that's really meaningful other than it feels good and it's interesting and it's what we do. I got to say, I think that makes a little sense for people. It's very hard, if you said, "Hey, Keith, I really want meaning. Where can I find that?" I'm like, "I got 47 churches, I got 65 atheist groups, I got 42 TikTok gurus. I got 6 million of these weirdos. Take your pick. What are you going to be?" You're like, "I have no idea what to do."
- 6.95** We live in a postmodern world. There's nothing. I mean, we care about biology. We live in a materialist biological world. We don't care. What Nietzsche says is, he goes, "This is really exciting." Yeah, this is a very exciting time if you're a philosopher, if you're smart,

if you're independently wealthy, and you don't really care that much. It's a fun time to figure out who you want to be. But if you're just a normal person going, "Yeah, I just want to raise my kids, and I want some foundational set of beliefs that we can work from and allow us to grow and relate to our community in a way where we have shared values and understanding. At this point, I don't even care what the values are; for all, Satan is fine."

- 6.96** I shouldn't say that. I don't really want that. But you get my point. As long as we just agreed on what's real, that would be OK. But we're not going to get there. I wanted to end this class on the narrative is that this narrative self is really, really important. We live in a time without a narrative that you can have because we live in a materialist, postmodern, kind of evil and boring time. No one's just, no one's handing you a ticket. You got to make it up yourself. Young people are forced to either just wander or desert-wander, and just try to find, wait for something to come to me, to inspire me. They try different things to inspire them. Sometimes they get snared up in bad things.
- 6.97** Or they end up being very existential. It's like, "I can't really believe anything. All I can do is act and just create what I can create and keep going." This narrative idea is important, and I think it's especially important now to have a narrative, to keep yourself, your story, together. But it's also a time where it's really difficult to have a narrative that you can share with people. That's it. Thank you.
- 6.98** Is speaking as if you are a character in a story a good way to be objective upon self-reflection?
- 6.99** OK. That is a really interesting question. Is the strategy of thinking of yourself as a character in a story useful for self-reflection? I have never had that question asked about a human before, and I haven't thought about it. But oddly enough, people have tried that with large language models. They've tried to have them think of being characters and try to predict things as characters and had them try to do it more abstractly, and acting like characters seemed to help with large language models. My hunch is that the character thing could help, but when I hear people doing that, and I'm not sure if this is exactly what you're talking about, it's often in the performance realm.
- 6.100** Performing is hard because you get negative feedback, you're putting yourself out there, and you got to be arrogant. People will sometimes take on identities to that. The classic example, my daughter's told me, was Sasha Fierce. Is that the name? That's right. You're nodding. Beyoncé, yeah. Beyoncé puts on this role when she goes out on stage. It's just a whole different person, and my daughter's like, "Oh, you should just put on a whole another role and just play a part, and that would make your job easier." I thought about it. I thought that would be cool. I think there's something to what you're saying that's interesting. I've just never seen it studied, except in the large language models where it seems to work.

- 6.101** In the age of AI, do you ever worry that even the hero's journey will be taken away from us as humanity because of the advancement of technology and AI taking over even all these challenges that we face?
- 6.102** Yes. So, really, the question is, if we can build an intelligence that will be such a crutch or an assistant to us, that it takes away some of our challenges, will it make us less human? My hunch, and maybe I'm just an old guy and I'm angry and this is just a bias, and definitely it could be the case, my sense is when you give people tools that make things too easy, it makes people weaker. My hunch is, it's going to make people a little weaker, and it's going to make the world more into a game.
- 6.103** I grew up, they didn't play video games. You had to play games. When you play a video game, video games don't seem terrible socially, when I look at the research. You're playing with people, it's social, there's a goal, but you're not being punched in the face, for real. It's fake. I think as we get more virtual in our lives, we're going to be less human in a certain way. But again, it's just my bias, and maybe I'm just an old guy and I'm wrong. But I certainly feel weak compared to people who live much closer to the land. I feel weak. I hang out with guys that live off the land. I'm like, these guys, if they can live, and I'm a loser a little bit. So yeah, I do worry a little bit.
- 6.104** With regards to the narrative of the self, what would you say is noteworthy of the contrast between collective societies such as China and Western societies like the United States?
- 6.105** Gosh, that's a great one. What you see is, you'll see hero myths everywhere. You'll see that in all places in the world. When you look at self-enhancement in general, what you'll see is, in more collectivist cultures, you'll see that self-enhancement is a little more communal. People might say, "I'm really nice. I'm a great team player." In the US, I'm more likely to say, "I'm hot." I think when you start making that collective, you're going to see a little more difference in the communality of it.
- 6.106** The story of Buddha is a powerful story in Asia because he leaves his family and leaves his father. That doesn't resonate in the US. The story that, yeah, a kid turned 18, said, "Dad, I'm out of here to seek my fortune," it's like, yeah, that's what you do. Even in a case like that narrative, the emphasis on the relational part is stronger than it would be in a more individualistic culture. I think there'd be some differences that way. But in general, I think the hero's myth is the hero's myth. As China is urbanizing, it's becoming much more individualistic. It's always been kind of individualistic. Things change, too.

Lecture 7: Self in Society

At a glance — The self in society.

- 7.1 All right. Welcome back. Today, I wanted to talk about the relational nature of the self. We've talked about the self, and we've talked about how it's structured, how it operates, how it feels good. What I wanted to focus on today is how the self connects with other people, how we're connected. I'm going to talk about dyadic relationships or couples, and I'm going to talk about small groups. But I first want to talk about, just theoretically, just a lot of people have approached the self as a social construct. William James, who I've mentioned a lot in this course, talked about the social self.
- 7.2 He said, "Properly speaking, a man has as many social selves as there are individuals who recognize him and carry an image of him in their mind." Classic quote is, basically, James is saying, "We have a different self with every important relationship in our life." I have a self when I go visit my mom for her birthday. I have a self when I talk to my mother-in-law. I have a self when I talk to my children. I have a dog self. I just made up the term dog self, but I think that could be a real term. Somebody could write a dissertation on that because I'm very lovely when I'm with my dogs.
- 7.3 We have these different selves that get reflected in different relationships. Some researchers have gone farther. Like the sociologist Baldwin talked about, maybe we shouldn't talk about the self per se. Maybe we should talk about something like a "socius", like an actual dyadic relationship that's foundational. Socius is a word that comes from companionship in Latin. Sorry, it's been a long time since I studied Latin. But it's the idea that maybe we could think of ourselves not as an independent being all the time, but maybe something connected. So that's maybe a way to think about it.
- 7.4 There was a whole element in psychiatry back in the day called interpersonal psychiatry with Harry Stack Sullivan, which you might run into if you're in the business. But what you'll see now in a lot of the clinical fields is they're talking about relational disorders. So they're saying, let's think about psychological disorders as relational disorders, really some of them. In that way, we're thinking about the self as a relational idea. Your self is formed always in relationships with people.
- 7.5 Solomon talked a lot about early friendships in relationship, what you call chumships. You form, not just your parenting—I'll talk about attachment in a second, which is parenting—but early friendships, chumships, are really important for forming ourselves. In the clinical world, there's a whole other way of thinking about the relationships as integrated with the self, which is called object relations theory. This is one of those terms. Object relations is one of the worst terms I've ever heard in psychology. There are a lot of bad terms, but object relations, what does that mean?
- 7.6 Well, an object is a psychic representation of another person. I have an image of my mom that is an object. Why don't you call it an image of your mom? I don't know. Ask

the object relations theorist. I think it was Freud's idea. The idea in a lot of this early psychoanalytic work is thinking about the self is containing these psychological structures which represent our mother, our father, something else. They're represented as objects in our mind. What's cool about it is sometimes these can be split objects. I can have a representation of my mom that's good and a representation of my mom that's bad, or a representation of my good father and bad father.

- 7.7 With kids, imagine, when my children are young, they'd see me. Sometimes I'm really nice and they go, "That's good dad." Then sometimes I'm pissed off and I'm on the war path, like I shouldn't have been, but I'm sorry to everybody. I just did my best. They go, "That guy's an ogre," and they form an image. They're like, "That dad is the bad dad." Kids can form these split object representations. You find all these ideas in clinical psychology if you go in that direction. Just the way our self is structured at the most basic level has to do with these relationships and how we hold these relationships in our head. That's the idea here.
- 7.8 One of my favorite ideas, I'm just throwing this out in the object relations literature, is this idea of the basic fault, like the basic split or basic hole in the self. So what object relations people would notice is like, hey, people are built to have relationships, but we're always disconnected. We're always a little bit isolated. So there's this sense we all have of a core of loneliness or a core of disconnection. Sometimes it's bigger, sometimes it's smaller. But because we're meant to be social, isolation sticks with us in a way. So I like that term, the basic fault. Anyway, Michael Balint, so old British object relations theory. What the heck? It's my class. I can talk about crazy stuff.
- 7.9 There's lots of ideas that the self is somehow fundamentally relational. The most powerful theory on this, I'll talk about a few ways we connect. Probably the most powerful theory is attachment theory. I talked about it a little bit when I talked about Harry Harlow's monkeys and the monkey studies. That's early attachment work. But what attachment theorists did was they, well, I'll just give you the story. I'll make it fast. You got John Bowlby. He's an object relations theorist, like I talked about, a psychoanalyst. He's studying people. He's in Britain during the Battle of Britain. He's dealing with a bunch of orphans. So lots of parents are dying and lots of kids are orphaned.
- 7.10 He's watching these kids in an orphanage and he sees these kids are suffering. So there's all these kids without parents and they're suffering. That's weird. I thought suffering came from bad relationships with your parents, but these kids don't have bad relationships with their parents and they're suffering. Maybe there's something else going on. And Bowlby was, in addition to being a psychoanalyst, he was also an expert in evolutionary psychology, and he was a biographer of Charles Darwin. So he knew a lot about evolution, and he thought about the world as an evolutionary space.
- 7.11 So he said, well, maybe these kids are suffering because, just like any mammal, they're not attaching. They don't have something to attach to, a parent, a caregiver, a nurturing

figure in their life. Because they don't have that, they're developing some sort of poor coping mechanisms in childhood. This came up with this idea of attachment theory. To break it down, what Bowlby started noticing with people is that our personality develops out of our early attachment relationships.

- 7.12** There's two fundamental lessons we learn. We learn, are we a good person or a bad person? If we're loved, we think we're good. If we're not loved, we think we're bad. Then we learn if we can trust people or if we want to be close to people, or if we shouldn't trust people and want to be away from people. We learn these two messages. It's like, am I good or am I not good? And do I trust people or do I not trust people? Those two basic messages, and this is what we're talking six months, we're just learning these very basic messages about how the world works. As you get older, these turn into styles or ways of attaching to the world, ways of attaching in other relationships.
- 7.13** The three big styles that Bowlby talked about, and I'm skipping one of them. The big three are a more anxious style. Imagine you got a caregiver who's not really there, they're drinking, it's 4:20 every day, and sometimes they're there, and sometimes they're not there. And you become really clingy about relationships. You're like, whenever my parents are there and they're good, I've got to hold on to them. I don't want them to go away. So you become anxious. You become attached. You're hard to comfort. That's just an attached, anxious, ambivalent child.
- 7.14** On the opposite side, you imagine you have a parent who just doesn't pay attention to you at all. They're just like, "Yeah, go do your stuff," kick you out in the morning. You're like, "Dude, I'm one. What am I doing?" "Just go crawl." Very quickly, what you learn is, "I can't trust my parent. I just can't trust him. I have to develop my own toughness, my own way of living. I can't sit there and cry because if I cry, somebody's going to kill me, so I just got to suck it up." This is what we call maybe avoidant attachment style. Sort of different flavors of this, but avoidant attachment, it's very hard for me to attach in relationships in a healthy way.
- 7.15** I might attach in an exploitative way. I might become more psychopathic in my attachment and more manipulative because that makes me feel safe, or I might not want to attach to people at all. I want to become alienated from people. With that more avoidant attachment style, you either become a manipulator or you become somebody who doesn't connect with people very well. Then the final style is what happens when you have a parent who's there and offers support when you need it. This is what they call secure attachment. You end up feeling like, "Yeah, I can trust people. I like who I am. I feel pretty good." What's neat about secure attachment is when you feel that you have that secure attachment there, it turns on your exploration system.
- 7.16** So with young kids, what you'll see is, if they're at the park with their dad and they have a good relationship with their dad, they can go run and play with all the other kids. And

when they fall, they look back to make sure dad's still there, and then they feel safe and they go play again. If kids have that kind of security, it becomes a secure base to be able to explore the world effectively. Without that, that exploration gets harder. So that's a very quick explanation of attachment. But I think this is probably the most common theory, theoretical understanding, of how the self emerges from early relationships and the more positive and more negative sides of that.

7.17 Then you have this interesting case where, imagine you have two individuals that are, let's say, adults, two adult selves, and you're trying to connect with another self. How do you take this self and connect it with that self? That's an interesting question. People have thought there's lots of different ways of thinking about this. I think one of the most powerful models of this is a model of intimacy and reciprocal self-disclosure. So think about it this way. You have a self and you have your public self, the front stage. This is the stuff I show everybody. This is the shallow stuff everyone sees, and the other person has the same thing.

7.18 But we're like a Tootsie Pop. Inside, I don't know, people don't eat Tootsie Pops anymore, but inside there's the hard candy surface, and then inside it's a little bit, there's stuff that people don't know quite as much that's a little more emotional. And then you go down to the center of the Tootsie Pop, and I got some big fears and concerns, and I hope no one notices this about me, and some other stuff that most people don't see.

7.19 If you think about our selves as shallow on the outside and going to something that's more of an emotional core, it's just a metaphor for the self, the way you connect with people is you imagine the two Tootsie Pops coming together and they hit each other's hard shells, well, how do you get to the warm, gooey center, the warm Tootsie center of the self? That's the process of reciprocal self-disclosure. OK? Sorry. This metaphor is so horrible, and I'm just going to run with it. You got the two Tootsie Pops, and you want to get to the warm, gooey, chocolatey center of each other. So how do you do it?

7.20 Reciprocal self-disclosure is the process of systematically revealing aspects of each other that start shallow and become deeper. And this is one way that we form emotionally intimate relationships. How do you do this? Well, you can do this in a lab. We can bring two people, strangers, into a lab and say, "Here's a list of questions to ask each other. Let's go for it." There's different versions of this. One version we did way back in the day, it's called the relationship closeness induction task. Art Aron has some really cool ones that people end up getting married at the end.

7.21 But ours is very simple. It's like, "Here's a list of words. Start asking and answering questions of each other." You start off with shallow things like, "What's your first name? What's your hometown? Where are you from?" Those kind of things, things that you just talk to anybody. What you do is like, "Hey, where are you from?" "Oh, I'm from Miami. Where are you from?" "I'm from Miami Lake." We learned a little bit about each other. OK. Then you go a little deeper in the questions. You're things like, "What are

your hobbies? What's a strange thing that happened to you at school?" This is with undergrads. "What do you miss about your home?"

- 7.22** Then people tell you a little more. "I'm really into catching bats." Not a lot of people know about this, but bat-catching is a classic hobby. I love to catch bats. You're like, "Dude, I'm into catching iguanas." Man, we're like simpatico. And so you start to line up. And so you get a little deeper. And then about 10 minutes in or eight minutes in, you're asking stuff like, "If you had one wish granted, what would it be? What's one of your biggest fears in life? What's one thing about yourself most people would consider surprising?"
- 7.23** So what you do within that 5, 10 minutes is, you start off talking about where you're from, and pretty soon you're like, "I'm really scared of deep water. And most people wouldn't know, but I actually won the hopscotch championship in 1984 in Fresno, California." I was literally the hopscotch king of Fresno, and none of you knew that. And I just made that up completely. I don't even know if there's such a thing. So what happens in this process of reciprocal self-disclosures, you're basically saying, "Share a little bit about me, share a little bit about you," and you get deeper and deeper and deeper, and pretty soon you're sharing some pretty heavy stuff.
- 7.24** And this can happen very, very quickly if it's structured. But most of us in relationships, you're not really doing that. Most of the time, you're just shallow banter and things. But if you do want to get close, that emotional intimacy by revealing aspects of yourself is a very good way of doing it. It's interesting thinking about this in a psychotherapy setting because it's non-reciprocal self-disclosure. "Tell me about yourself." But then the psychoanalyst or the therapist isn't like, "Well, let me tell you about my biggest fears." It's usually a one-way street and something like therapy more, which is neat. But in a relationship, it's more reciprocal.
- 7.25** So one way we can bring ourselves together is this reciprocal self-disclosure. Another method people have talked about is not so much reciprocal self-disclosure, but self-expansion. So this is another crazy Art Aron idea that comes out of, this actually comes out of the Vedic literature, out of the Upanishads, believe it or not. But it's this idea that, in a relationship, I'm going to expand to incorporate aspects or qualities of my partner. My partner is going to expand and incorporate aspects of me. We're both doing this in the interest of growing ourselves.
- 7.26** My interest as a human is, I want to grow, I want to expand who I am. I start a relationship with somebody, and they do something different than me, and I start to learn about what they do and about what they're like, and I learn about their family, and I learn about their culture, and I become an expanded person in that process. I start growing because I'm incorporating aspects of that person. They're incorporating aspects of me, and they're growing at the same time. When we're both growing really fast, what we feel is passion. This is where love comes from, according to some of the

self models. There's other models, too. But the idea is this rate of growth makes us feel passion.

7.27 If I start a relationship with somebody who's very different than me, I'm going to have a potential for a great deal of growth because the person is very different, so I can grow a lot. It's going to be harder to keep a relationship because we're going to be so different, but I'm going to have a lot of growth and it's going to be very passionate. If I start a relationship with somebody very similar to me, I'm not growing that much. I'm like, "Oh, you're from Laguna? I'm from Laguna. Oh, I live down the street from you. Our aunts are friends." OK. It's very comfortable, though, right? You don't get that passion, but you get a sense of comfort, you get a sense of warmth. It's more companionate. It's more of a companionate sense of love that you get in a slower growth relationship.

7.28 So that self-expansion idea is great. We love it in movies, and obviously in movies, they take it to the extreme, where it's like you're marrying a vampire, right? Because they're like, well, how do we write this script? Maybe it's a woman from Norway. No, we need something farther away. How about a vampiress from Romania? Perfect. So they try to make this expansion as wild as they can because that makes for drama and passion. But here's what happens when you expand in a relationship. It stops. So you start dating the vampire, and pretty soon you're freaking over it. You're like, "I am so over this vampire stuff. I just want to go to the beach, and you can't go with me."

7.29 So, expansion. So it's really interesting in relationships, this idea of growth is, you grow and expand and you can bring the person together with somebody, but eventually you stop because you just know the person. And then this is the model. What you do is you expand together as a couple. Then as a couple, you go, "Yeah, passion is going away. We know each other pretty well. Let's go do something new together. Let's grow together. Let's go on a vacation. Let's go read something new. Let's go try a new restaurant."

7.30 Whatever it is, let's get out of our comfort zone a little bit and grow. That would continue leading to passion and connection. Again, disclosure is more like merging together, and expansion is like merging and growing at the same time. It's a little different model, but it's a good way of connecting. Self-disclosure is great, works great. Self-expansion, I think, works reasonably well. I think there's always challenges in it because self-expansion can be exciting but destabilizing.

7.31 A third model for connecting selves and relationships is called I-sharing. I find this model a little more speculative and a little more theoretically interesting. The idea of I-sharing is that, rather than sharing the content of our self-concept, rather than us saying, "Hey, tell me about where you're from. Oh, here's where I'm from." Or, "Hey, my wife's this, and I'm this, and we're both growing." Instead of it being about content, I-sharing is about sharing the experience of consciousness. It's about sharing the I rather than the me. It's about sort of, like, we're feeling the same thing at the same time.

- 7.32 How do you measure that? It's a hard one to measure. You just ask people, "Did you experience this?" I say this work, this idea came from Liz Pinel, who's up at Vermont. I always try to give people credit, and I'm pretty sure she's still at Vermont. Very nice. This idea, so here's my example of I-sharing, because when I heard about this, I felt this idea was fascinating. I was trying to think of an example. I remember my uncle was living in New Zealand. This is a long time ago, of course. I went down, we were going fishing. So I flew down to Queenstown to meet him.
- 7.33 And if you ever have flown to New Zealand, you fly from the East coast to LA. Where do you go? Then you go to Auckland, then you go to Christchurch, and then you fly into Queenstown. Maybe now there's a direct flight, who knows? But that's what it would be. So it was like 24 hours in the air because I don't sleep on a plane. I've been up for 24 hours. Bill picks me up. I won't say his name, though. And he's driving his Land Cruiser. So it's driving on the other side of the road. So it's right-hand drive, driving an old Land Cruiser with a stick shift.
- 7.34 So if you ever have driven on the wrong side of the road with a stick shift, it's hard because everything's backwards. So we're driving down this lake, and if Bill goes over two feet, we're dropping right in the lake; we're going to die. I'm sorry. I don't know why I'm laughing so much. I look over and Bill's driving with his knee. He's driving the stick-shift Land Cruiser around the lake with his knee, and he's rolling a cigarette with his two hands. He looks at me and he goes, "Help me out if I get in trouble." I go, "What do you want me to do? Tell you to go for the light?"
- 7.35 I mean, and so that's it. It makes no sense at all. We both started laughing harder than we've ever laughed in our lives. Basically, what I'm saying is, if you screw up, we're dead. You drop this, we're dead. All I can tell you at that point is, go for the light. That's the last message I'm going to get to you. We laughed. I mean, we just laughed and laughed and laughed. I try to tell that story. It doesn't make sense. It's not funny. You had to have been there. I did all the setup, and you're like, guys, this is insane. But it was one of those experiences that we both shared in a way that was hard to explain.
- 7.36 So that, to me, is like I-sharing. It's like you capture a moment with somebody. When you're young, this happens more when life's a little freer, I think. But that can be a really important connection, but there's no content to it. I told you a story, but the story wasn't the point. The point was just, we were in, that we shared an experience together that was powerful and funny. That's I-sharing. I think that's a really neat way of merging the self. It's not studied too well for the obvious reasons that it's hard to study; and also ethically, I don't know if I could bring people in the lab and try to induce this. I mean, you can try to induce love in a lab. Maybe you could, but anyway.
- 7.37 I love that idea, too. You can merge not just at the level of the content, but at the level of the consciousness of the I as well. Then there's some other really important roles for the self in dyads as well. One of the biggest things we do is not so much use our self to capture an aspect of the person, but we use our self to regulate our bad side so that we

can have a relationship. I'll explain this. Relationships, having a long-term relationship, like a romantic relationship with somebody, raising a child, living with a parent, all sorts of relationships, they take work. They take a lot of energy, and they take a lot of self-control.

- 7.38** Why does it take self-control? Well, here's what happens in relationships. Everything's good, and then somebody will do something that's potentially destructive to the relationship. Come home tired, say something mean. "Oh, yeah, I got home. I expected you to have something in the fridge for me." Dude, don't do that. But people say stuff like that, right? Because they're tired and they're stressed out. And they're like, yeah, if I can't get pissed off at my husband, who can I get mad at? You're like, well, maybe somebody other than your husband. But that's just how we are.
- 7.39** And the other thing, the way we run our life is that we use all our energy for everybody else. We wake up and then we get out of the house and we fight and then we get out of the house and then we're nice all day working. Then we go back and we're so tired. It's like, I just want to punch my wife, but I'm too tired. She's trying to punch me, and we're so tired. We run a life so we're always exhausted, which makes relationships hard. What you need to do when your partner does something destructive is, you need to invoke your self-control and stop it by doing something that's pro-relational or more accommodative.
- 7.40** Sometimes they call this the process of accommodation in relationships. When your partner does something destructive, what you need to do is say, "Sorry you feel that way," or, "Yeah, I should have filled up the fridge. I'm really sorry, I didn't." Oh, god, imagine if I said that. Imagine my wife's like, "Why is the fridge not filled?" I'm like, "I'm really sorry, I should have done that." She'll be like, "I don't know what to do. I can't be enraged anymore. You stopped my power. I'm such a jerk." It's very easy to do to me. You just be nice. I'm like, "Oh, my god, I hate myself." I just melt like a witch.
- 7.41** A lot of times using self-control and just being nice or being calm or not being aggressive or not being responsive in those situations can be really helpful to keep a relationship going and stop it from breaking apart. But like I said, it's hard for us to do because we often are just tired. Often, our spouse says something to us or a friend says something to us, and they're just wrong, and we really want them to know they're wrong. But sometimes it's better to let them know they're wrong the next day. The next day, they go, "Hey, man, I'm really sorry I said that. I was being a jerk." I'm like, "Dude, it's OK. I was a jerk once myself, like this morning."
- 7.42** Using self-control is really important just to keep us from doing mean things in relationships, to keep us going. I figured as long as we're talking about some of the more negative side, self-control is really good for keeping things positive. The other thing you see in relationships, and I see a lot of this now, so I thought it'd be useful to talk about, is people use their selves to manipulate and destroy other people, by

destabilizing them. So healthy relationship, mutual self-disclosure and respect. Healthy relationship, mutual respect and self-expansion. That's seems pretty healthy.

- 7.43** Healthy relationship, we work hard to be nice. We work hard to have good discussions. We work hard not to fight. We work hard to have more positive energy than the negative. Healthy relationship. Not-healthy relationship, what I do is I try to destabilize my partner's sense of reality so that he or she doesn't know what is up or down, and then I can control him or her in the way I want and get whatever I want out of the relationship. Not so healthy. That's more of a predatory or more psychopathic or narcissistic relationship.
- 7.44** There's a lot of terms for this. The most common term I hear now is gaslighting. People talk about gaslighting in relationships. That term, for some reason, caught on. For those of you who don't know, the term gaslighting comes from an old play that they turned into a couple of movies. But essentially, what happened is a ne'er-do-well husband was trying to make his wife think that she was going crazy. So he'd go in the house and he'd turn the gas lights down. And she'd be like, "Somebody turned the gas lights down." He'd be like, "What? No way. You're crazy."
- 7.45** Or he'd go up in the attic and rattle some chains. And she's like, "Do you hear that noise in the attic?" "What? No way. There's no noise. You're crazy." And what that does is you break somebody's connection with reality. You just make them think that reality isn't real. You destabilize their sense of reality. And once you've disconnected somebody from reality, you can just take them out. I don't mean to be so direct about that. I call this a billfish strategy, like a marlin, like a swordfish or a spikefish or a sailfish or marlin. I think that's all of them. Probably missed a billfish in there.
- 7.46** But the way—the reason fish have those bills on them is not because they go spear. They don't fly around and just swim in the water and go harpoon a fish. What they do is they swim into a school of fish and just start thrashing the bill around. And that destabilizes all the fish in the school. And then they're like, boom, "I'm just going to eat you now that you're destabilized." Does that make sense? You cut off somebody's sense of stability. Gaslighting is just doing that. You're cutting off somebody's connection with reality, which is much easier to do than you think, and then they get really destabilized, and then you can control them. So this is a more negative way.
- 7.47** Believe it or not, I saw a Saturday Night Live skit about this recently that was funny. I quit watching Saturday Night Live 20 years ago, and I saw a skit on gaslighting that was funny. So if you ever see one, it was actually funny. I don't know. It was just a few days ago. They didn't call it gaslighting, but that's what it was about. That's a more negative and more pathological relationship style. It's a more predatory style. But I'm just making you aware because the self can be good or bad in these things.
- 7.48** That sense of, I'll just say this again because I think it's important right now, is keeping a sense of connection with reality is really important in a relationship. How do you do

that? You have a group of friends that you trust, that you can talk to. You have a parent that you trust, you can talk to. You have a therapist, coach, counselor, religious leader, whatever person you trust, you can talk to. You spend time in nature where you feel you can trust things. You have animals that have good vibes you can trust. You find some source of stability that you can trust, and then your partner will have less control over you.

7.49 Whenever you feel somebody trying to socially isolate you, that's when you start getting nervous. This is what cult leaders do. "Hey, you want to be in my cult? Oh, yeah, we got a little place out in the mountains. We just come out here and, yeah, no visitors." They don't like visitors at cults. Or if your friend's in a cult and you want to visit, they always have another person come with you. So you just got to visit person. So if you're in a relationship and you're like, "Dude, this has got a little cult vibe," I get nervous. OK. That wasn't advice. It was just something to consider. OK, so that's more a dyadic connection with people.

7.50 There's also ways we connect with people at more of a group level, and this is our self as a group. The way we are designed as individual selves is, it's very very, very, very easy for us to identify with a group. It's pretty much like we're built to have some group identification. How easy can you do it? Well, the easiest way you can put people into groups is what psychologists call mere categorization. Meaning, by merely categorizing you as a member of a group, you're going to start feeling like you're part of that group. How do you do that?

7.51 Well, this is old work by like Tajfel and Turner and others. One of the early ways they did this is they put a board up with a bunch of dots on it and they said, "How many dots are there?" People would make a number and they'd say, "Oh, you're an overestimator and you're an underestimator." OK, that's your group, that's your group. That forms groups. I remember working in labs where they'd show people art. They'd show them pictures from Klee and Kandinsky. I don't know if you know Paul Klee and Wassily— I don't even know Kandinsky's first name. I know a little bit about modern art, and Paul Klee happened to be the favorite artist of a lot of Jungians, but I still couldn't tell Klee and Kandinsky apart. Nobody in the studies can.

7.52 But what they do is they go, "Oh, yeah, here's some modern art. You like Klee, you like Kandinsky, you're in a group." So very simple categorization works for groups. When you're in a group, what you feel is a sense of groupness. So your self feels connected to a group. We might call this belongingness or groupness or we-ness. The technical term for this is entitativity. I love that word, entitativity. What does that mean? It means I feel like I'm part of an entity. When I was talking about a Marine Corps, a body, this is like I'm part of an entity. So you get a sense of groupness or entitativity in a group.

7.53 Once you're in a group, it's really easy to expand that sense of group connection. You do it in a few different ways. One thing you can do is you can start increasing what they call the interdependence or the interaction of the group. You can say, OK, now there's a

leader, and now you're the second in command, and you're in charge of snacks, and you're doing this. All of a sudden, you've got a functional group. They're working together. That makes your identity a little stronger.

- 7.54** Then what you can do if you really want to amp it up is you get an out-group. If you want your group identity to be strong, you go, "Hey, guess what? You guys are now an in-group, and those guys are an out-group, and you're the guys who like Klee, and they're the people that like Kandinsky." Or you're the overestimators who are awesome and know the underestimators are lame. What happens is, you set two groups up to compete, and all of a sudden, it's on. People are very, very comfortable being identified and being part of competitive groups. Again, it's just how we're built.
- 7.55** You have to do a little work to do this. You can't just be like, I couldn't just say, "You guys are in a group, go kill those guys." It'd take me a minute or two. I shouldn't say that. It'd be like five. But oh, no. We laugh. A lot of people make, and this is their job, is getting people to hate each other at scale. Groups can really get to, get identity without group competition. Here's the other real piece of the groups as they involve the self. Groups are about identity, but what groups do importantly is they give us self-esteem. We get esteem from our membership in groups. This is the basis of what's called social identity theory, or social identity theory of groups.
- 7.56** So how does that work? Well, I'm a fan of the Georgia Bulldogs. When the Georgia Bulldogs win a game, I go, "Man, we won. That's awesome." I feel great about winning that game. Somebody goes, "Dude, you seem a little short to be out there on the field, my friend." Say, well, we're all part of the same thing. We're all Bulldogs. Some of them are out there playing. Some of us bought a hat, but we're all there. That's group identity. I get esteem when my team wins, and I don't get esteem when they lose. So what esteem comes from is group success. And when you're part of a group that's successful and you get esteem from that, you tend to identify more and more with that group because it's filling the psychological need.
- 7.57** When your group stops giving you esteem, you go, "I feel like a loser identifying with this group," you'll leave that group if you can and try to identify with another group. People will strategically identify groups to get self-esteem needs met. There's lots of fun research on this. Cialdini, who's one of the great, Robert Cialdini, is great persuasion, wrote a book, Persuasion, great researchers on this. He did a study looking at people wearing team sweatshirts after college victories and losses. He just had people at different campuses. I think he was at Arizona State, one of them, and they did some others.
- 7.58** And he measured how many kids at the university would wear college gear, college paraphernalia, after winning a football game or losing a football game. People win a football game, they're wearing the gear. You lose a football game, you're not wearing the gear as much. When Georgia won the national championship, people were lined up at midnight to buy gear, championship gear, because they wanted that self-esteem so

bad. I cannot wait for that hit of self-esteem, putting on this championship hat, walking around.

- 7.59** I mean, it's so funny, right? Because basically your entire economy is giving fake self-esteem to people who don't play football by making them associated with a football team. God bless, it works. You got to get self-esteem from something. This term, which we have a name for this in social psych, we call it basking in reflected glory, or sometimes BIRGing, or BIRGing. I've heard both, and I never asked Cialdini, which is right. But BIRGing or BIRGing. We bask in reflected glory when we have the opportunity to do it. It's a way our self gets esteem from a game.
- 7.60** The other thing you see in sports is you see selective perception of games. So one of the earliest studies in psychology—this is almost 100 years old—was called They Saw a Game. And they had the fans of watching a football game. And maybe it was like Dartmouth and Tufts or something, I can't remember the two teams. It was a long time ago. Now it would have been like Michigan and Texas or something. And then they said, "Hey, how were the calls? How were the refs?" Here's what happens, as you can imagine.
- 7.61** When it's my team, I go, "Yeah, they made a bunch of bad calls against us. Those guys were cheating." You go ask the other team, "Yeah, they made a bunch of bad calls against us. Those guys were cheating." So whenever you watch a game, it's essentially the self-serving bias, making excuses for failure, but applied to your group in order to keep your self-esteem. So whenever I have to watch Georgia lose to Alabama, which is part of my life's journey and mission in this one journey of this life course, I'm learning humility. I go and watch Georgia and they lose to Alabama, and the ref's always like, "Oh, here's three points for Alabama just for fun." I'm always crying. I'm like, "This isn't fair."
- 7.62** I try to remind myself it probably is fair, but I don't think it is really, because deep down, I do think Alabama is in league with the devil. But that's what I mean. That's what I mean about self becoming identified with a group and using that group identity as a way of regulating self-esteem. You can imagine you can go through your whole life getting self-esteem by group association and never do a darn thing in your life. "Who are you?" "I'm a Rams fan. That's where I get my self-esteem." "OK. Anything else you got?" "Love those Rams." OK. But you got to do something, right? It's like better than nothing. And being a fan is a lot of work and you got to show up.
- 7.63** And also, I should say, I'm being negative and I should be positive. There's a lot of evidence, work on football fans, and they tend to be pretty happy. They tend to be pretty extroverted. Football fandom tends to be pretty social because it's often like, "Let's get together and watch a game and eat bad food or tailgate." In terms of fandoms, I don't think it's the worst. I enjoy the tailgating, and it seems very social to me and fun. I don't mean to be all negative about it. It's just, this is a way we get self-esteem from group identity. It's very common.

- 7.64 And I guess you can see how easy it would be if somebody wanted to turn the world into chaos. You'd just put people in the groups and give them esteem and say, "Those groups don't want you to have esteem, and go get them," and then everyone fights. Another thing about the self in groups that people don't think about as much that has to do with group competition is that groups make people different in an interesting way. Essentially, groups made out of nice, conscientious, agreeable, compassionate people can be made incredibly nasty and violent in competition. And groups made out of nasty, psychopathic, impulsive individuals don't make very good violent groups. That doesn't make sense.
- 7.65 What that means is that niceness as an individual, when you put it into the world of groups, can become meanness. And this process, and I'll explain this a little bit, this is called discontinuity. OK, discontinuity. Why discontinuity? There's not a continuity between individual behavior and group behavior. I'll give you a couple examples of this. If I had to make a deal—right now there's so many wars, I don't even know what example to use. But if you said, "Hey, Keith, we're going to go start a war with the Marshall Islands because we don't have enough wars right now, and those Marshall Islands look nice. Go down there and talk to somebody."
- 7.66 Well, they could fly me to the Marshall Islands. I could talk to anybody and make a deal with them. Talk to anybody. "Hey, how's it going? I'm Keith." "Good to meet you. I'm John." Start talking. "Oh, it's a beautiful out here. I love this place. Hey, let's work this out." "OK, I trust you." Go have a drink together. We'd be fine. Individuals are able to trust each other. But then I go back to my group and I'm like, "Hey, I made a deal with John down there, and they said we're going to work things out." My group's like, "I don't know about John. He might have said that, but I don't trust those guys. Those Marshall guys are bad. Oh, come on. They're going to just take us out. We got to protect ourselves. Why don't we hit him first and hit him hard?"
- 7.67 "Why? John's a nice dude." "Yeah, John is, but those Marshall guys, they're bad. Bad news, man." And so when you start getting that group mindset, it becomes much more about protection. It becomes much more "we got to work together as a group," and very hard for groups to trust each other. They just don't do it very well. What am I talking about individuals? Well, I'll give you two examples. Imagine a very high-trust, cohesive society where you could go right now and shake somebody's hand and have a very trusting relationship and they're not going to steal your wallet. Some place like Tokyo, Japan.
- 7.68 We could all go there right now. It's very high-trust. You could drop your wallet. Somebody's going to find it for you. People are going to be very nice to you. During World War II, we were fighting the Japanese, and the same high-trust people were at war with us, and we thought they were pretty evil, and they thought the same thing. This is another New Zealand story because I was thinking about my uncle. One of my uncle's buddies in New Zealand was a fishing guide. He had a client who was a

Kamikaze, like a former Kamikaze. Now, not many Kamikazis lived through the war because they died. That was the nature of it.

- 7.69** He was talking to the guy. He said, "Well, tell me about it." He said, "Well, because I love the Emperor, I love Japan, they told us to go kill the Americans. I knew if they captured me, the Americans were going to torture and kill me. So I flew my flight, my plane in, to take out the destroyer. I got shot down and crashed before I got there. And I got rescued by the Americans. They patched me up in the ship and sent me back to Japan after the war." But in his mind, this is, in American mind, this is a Kamikaze pilot. In his mind, he is a good person doing everything he can to serve his country and his Emperor, to stop evil Americans. In an American mind, he's an evil guy. After the war, friends.
- 7.70** Does that make sense? So these really nice people in the time of war are the ones that become really aggressive because of the nature of the group, because they love the group and they want to protect the group because they're good people. Give you another story from World War II. This is a fake story, but it's popular. It's called The Dirty Dozen. It was a book, and it was made into a movie, starring Telly Savalas, who is one of my favorites, and Charles Bronson. These are classic '70s tough guys that most of you don't know about.
- 7.71** The book, The Dirty Dozen, was a story of, let's get a bunch of psychopaths to do a military mission together. Instead of getting a lot of cooperative people that love our country, let's get a bunch of people on death row, and we'll have them work together in a cooperative way to kill the Nazis. So this is the Dirty Dozen. They get a dozen people on death row. They say, "You guys here, we'll give you a chance. It's a suicide mission, but you might make it." If you want to look at measures of the Dark Triad traits, of narcissism, Machiavellianism, and psychopathy, one of the measures is called the Dirty Dozen. It's based on this movie, and now you know the whole story.
- 7.72** What happens when you take a group of psychopaths and form them into a unit? They collapse. They go fight the Nazis. They start stealing from each other. They're shooting the wrong thing. Half of them want to steal the gold. They kill some Nazis. I think one guy makes it. It doesn't really work. What I mean is, bad people make for terrible groups. Bad people don't make for bad groups. Good people make for bad groups, and bad people make for dysfunctional groups. Isn't that weird? What I mean is, the self changes on the scale of the relationship status. It's a weird phenomenon that people often don't think about.
- 7.73** How did groups learn to get along? How do you learn to trust in groups? Well, you can't really negotiate too well because there's so little trust. Often what groups end up doing is what's called tit-for-tat strategies. This is an old strategy that comes out of political science. I think it's Robert Axelrod, Bob Axelrod's work. What a tit-for-tat strategy is, if you do something mean to me, I'm just going to do it back to you. If you're nice to me, I'll be nice to you. If you're mean to me, I'm mean to you.

- 7.74 Then what you see is what's called proportional response. We're going to attack you. Now we're going to attack you, but we're going to attack you about the same. We're going to hope this stops it. Then they go, no, we're going to attack you again. OK, now we've got to do it again. Sometimes it gets out of hand and you end up with the Hatfields and the McCoys, killing each other for centuries or for generations. Sometimes people can stop with tit-for-tat. But that's the strategy people are using with groups. They're not trying to just shake hands like a couple. There's no shaking hands. It's all trust and verifying tit-for-tat.
- 7.75 I hope that wasn't too heavy, but I find that really an interesting way to think about how the self is changed in the process of groups and ways people don't typically think about. Finally, I wanted to talk a little bit about the self as a cultural construct, not just as part of a diet or a couple or part of a small group, but part of a culture. There's an enormous amount of—there's a whole field of cultural psychology. An enormous amount of this work is trying to understand how the self links with culture. There's a lot of ways to understand culture, a lot of ways to understand the self. I'm going to give you just a couple of examples of this, to give you a flavor.
- 7.76 I worry with this work, when you start doing cross-culture work in it with all these stereotypes, and stereotypes are always dumb when you travel, but it is what it is. When people first started looking at this, there's a lot of work in the business world. When they first started looking in psychology, the interest was comparing the west coast of the US with Japan. The reason for this was because you had a couple of friends who were academics, and one was at Stanford, and one was in Michigan, but he was from Japan, and it's Markus and Kitayama. They're like, "Hey, this is really interesting. Let's start comparing these two groups."
- 7.77 What they were doing at that point was comparing a very individualistic culture, which is California in the '80s or '90s, when it was—California is not as much now, but it was a very individualistic place. Japan, at that same period, was a very collectivistic place. You have two different kind of cultures, a more collectivistic culture and a more individualistic culture. What you assume, theoretically, is that the self-concept, the average self-concept in that culture, will align with the structure of the culture.
- 7.78 What the assumption was, well, my guess is, people in Japan are going to be a little more interdependent in how they see themselves. They're going to see themselves as more connected with their group. They're going to see their identities as more connected with social roles. They're not going to want to be better than people quite a bit. There's going to be less competition. Their competition will be muted a little bit. But an independent self that we'll see more in the United States, it's going to be more individualistic, more self-focused, higher self-esteem, and more competitive. That was the model of this.
- 7.79 When you look at that, if you look at the data, it does kind of come out that way. When you look at the Japanese self-concept, it seems to be more communal. When you find

self-enhancement in Japan, it tends to be more on these communal traits. "I'm a good worker, I'm a good citizen." Americans aren't like, "I'm a great American citizen." They're like, "I kick ass." So they're a little more enhancement on communal. You find a little lower self-esteem in Japan. They did this interesting, I remember going to one of Hazel Markus' talks where she was showing baseball in Japan versus the US. And in Japan, you want to win a little bit. In the US, we want to win by more. So there are these interesting cultural differences that you see.

7.80 Then people have tried to tie those to different environmental factors. One is economic production. A group of psychologists and sociologists, maybe anthropologists, and looked in China, and they said, "Well, let's start comparing cultures that are more rice-focused than wheat-focused." Northern China is more of a wheat-based culture, and southern China is more of a rice-based culture. What people expect is, in a rice-based culture, you'll find more interdependence. Why is that? Well, the way you harvest rice is the water has to be flooded through multiple paddies, and everyone has to cooperate.

7.81 So the water comes to my paddy, I use it, then I got to send it to my buddy's paddy, and we have a big chain of paddies. Dry wheat farming, we're all just waiting for the rain. So I don't have to cooperate with you because the rain is going to hit us all. So there's less need for cooperation. So when they looked within China, they found the same pattern. You find more individualism in the north with wheat culture and more collectivism in the south with rice culture, which I thought was interesting.

7.82 Huajian Cai, who's somewhere in the south now, but he's a Chinese researcher. He looked at narcissism in north and south China. He's like, yeah, the narcissism is higher up north, which is interesting, potentially because of the rice farming. Then somebody just replicated this. They just replicated this in almost a causal way, that putting people in these more interdependent environmental conditions leads to more interdependent selves. I think that environment part is really interesting.

7.83 Bringing it to the US, to just give you another example of this, they're in the southern US, and I don't know if I count Miami as the south. I think Miami might count as something different. But researchers were interested in what they call the culture of honor. The theory was that the southern US was settled more by people who were herders, that did animal husbandry, people who had flocks of sheep from northern Britain or Scotland, sort of my people. Then the north of the US was settled more by southern people from the south of Britain that did more farming.

7.84 The northern US is more farming-based migration pattern, and the southern US is more husbandry-based or a large animal-based migration. What is demanded by those different occupations? Well, if I'm a guy and I've got a flock of sheep, each one of those sheep is worth a lot of money, and I could get a rustler come and steal my sheep. The only thing I can do, if I want to survive, is I need a reputation that if anyone messes with

Keith's sheep, they're dead. I mean, that's it. I got to have, and that's called a reputation for honor. Yeah, you mess with my sheep, you're dead.

- 7.85** Then what happens is, nobody messes with my sheep. Everyone has that reputation for honor. We have a culture that involves honor, which is, if you insult me, if you take something from me, if you slight me, I will reestablish my authority over you, or I will reestablish my honor by defending it. I can defend my honor by punching you. We can have a duel. So dueling was very popular in the south, and that was just a way of maintaining honor. In the north, in a wheat culture, in a farming culture, no one's coming and stealing your wheat. It's not like, "Oh, God, I woke up this morning, honey, and somebody came and they just harvested all our wheat and made bread and ran off."
- 7.86** They don't do that. It's not worth anything. It's too hard. People don't steal wheat. They might steal some fruit off a tree, but they're not stealing your wheat. What you learn to do is cooperate more. "Hey, let's help each other build barns. Let's help each other harvest together. Let's work together." It's just more cooperative, and there isn't as much of an honor culture. The research on this was fun. They brought students in a lab and they'd figured out where they were from, and they'd have them walk down a hall, and then somebody would bump into them and go, "Asshole," and then walk around the corner and lock themselves in a room, and they'd see if the person would chase them down and try to beat them.
- 7.87** People don't beat each other anymore. It was a long time ago. They found that what happened, the southerners, somebody hit them and say, they get more aroused, they get more pissed off, they'd be more likely to confront the person. My wife from Brooklyn, somebody's like, "Asshole," you're just like, "Whatever." I mean, it doesn't affect you at all. I think that southern culture of honor is a pretty interesting idea. They replicated it in Brazil, too. They've got an honor culture in other places, so these cultures—but again, the idea is that these economic forces way back in the day shaped modern culture.
- 7.88** If you're in Georgia now, people are very polite. I'm always polite. Yes, sir. Yes, sir, all the time. Why am I doing that? Because it's an honor culture. The reason you're polite to everybody is because if you're not polite, you're just worried somebody's going to shoot you, because half the people have guns. They're not really going to, but half the people are armed. Everyone's just real nice to each other. As long as everyone's nice, it's great. And so what's weird is, you get a violent honor culture, and the surface is a very polite, nice culture because you just be nice to everybody. I've been there 25 years. I'm just very nice.
- 7.89** My other thing I learned in the south is you always want a relationship with people first. So when the northerners come in, they're like, "I'm just going to go demand this." I'm like, "You could do that, or you could pick up the phone and call somebody and say, 'Hey, how are you doing? How's your day going? How's the weather? Hey, by the way, I

got a question for you,' and I bet that would work better." OK. I was talking about cultural differences within cultures or between cultures.

- 7.90** A final way to think about cultural differences and the self is generational change. As the United States or Europe or China or whatever changes, our cultures are changing dramatically, and everybody raised every year is essentially raised in a different culture. When I was born in the mid' 60s, I grew up in one culture. My kids that were born 20 years ago grew up in a totally different culture. It was both called America, but it's just a totally different culture. This is true everywhere in the world.
- 7.91** What you see is generational change in the direction of cultural change. In the US, the primary change that we've seen is in the direction of individualism. We've gotten more and more individualistic over time, but it's been complicated. I don't want to go into this because this is a whole talk, but narcissism seemed like it went up and down after the Great Recession, and now we're more vulnerable and more depressed. But we're a very individualistic culture, and you can see that change in all sorts of things.
- 7.92** You can look at how many people live alone. It's going up. You can look at how people name their kids. We give our children more unique names. We don't name them all William and Mary like we used to. We give them different names to have them stand out. When people grow up, we tell them, "What are you going to do? What are you going to do?" That's for everyone. What are you going to do? No one assumes, oh, you're just going to work for your parents. Because what are you going to do? Got to be an individual. We have a very individualistic culture.
- 7.93** Probably the real downside of that right now is loneliness. There's a Surgeon General report on the epidemic of loneliness. I've done some research on this with Jean Twenge and looked at it, and it's bad. People feel very lonely, very atomized, very isolated. That's the not-so-fun side of individualism. But you see that in China as well. China is becoming a more individualistic society. What's going on? Well, you have a one-child policy, so you don't have big families, and that screws up Confucianism a little bit. Then you have urbanization, so you have people move to cities, and people, when they move to cities, become more individualistic.
- 7.94** They stop having kids. They focus on the careers. They focus on meeting people. They focus on themselves and small families. So you end up with isolated individuals living in cities, which is very individualistic. And then people stop reproducing. I guess then we die off. I shouldn't say that. I'm sorry. If you look at the data, South Korea is where we're seeing the biggest problem right now. And if you talk to any of your Korean friends, there's a huge interest in moving to Seoul, the capital. So lots of people move to Seoul. It's very hard to buy apartments. Housing is really expensive right now. Family formation is really hard.
- 7.95** So you have a lot of individualism. People are just on their own, doing their own thing. But it's not the fun individualism. It's not like self-expressive, "look at me, I'm awesome,

check out my selfie in Dubai" individualism. It's more like atomization, loneliness, anomie, sense of disconnection. It's not a real great individualism. I think that's happening in a lot of cultures right now. I should say this because I want to say something positive at the end. There's always countercultures. The general trend of culture around the world is becoming more individualistic and more isolated and more atomized.

- 7.96** Just go look at what they're building around the world, multi-unit. Like I just drive around here, multi giant apartment buildings, just giant apartment blocks for individuals to live in. It's kind of dystopic. But there are countercultures. People know this doesn't feel good. People are trying to learn the ways to connect each other. They're trying to bring back families. They're trying to bring back other ways to connect. So all these trends are going to lead to countertrends, and we try to—I'm trying to end with something positive.
- 7.97** So in conclusion, the self is a very social construct. We are built with pieces of other people in us, pieces of our mom, pieces of our dad. Those are objects that are in us. We come out of relationships. That earliest relationship sets us on our path. We identify with close people by connecting with them. We connect with their qualities, we learn about them, we grow through the process of connecting with other people, and we identify with groups, and we get esteem and meaning from identifying with groups, and it allows us to relate with other people in some positive ways, but it also can lead to some challenges and conflict.
- 7.98** Generally, our self is linked to our broader culture and economic systems as well. I think we're trending in the direction of isolation and individualism still, and not the optimal trend. I think sometimes considering countertrends of connection and meaning and purpose might be useful. That's it. Thank you.
- 7.99** You alluded to skyscrapers being a little dystopic. How does cities versus rural life influence the self?
- 7.100** When people live in a small town, they know each other and they have a reputation. Everything you do, everyone knows. And so, it's in your interest to be somebody that people can trust and somebody who's trustworthy and hardworking and is a decent person because everyone knows. If you're a bad person, they're going to isolate you. When you go to a city, no one knows who you are, so you can put on any act you want. The act that's going to work well in the city is going to be one that's extroverted and self-promotional.
- 7.101** So if I move to Miami and I'm like, "Dude, I don't know one person here, I got to fit in," I'm going to put a big smile on my face because I'm a boomer inside, even though I'm not technically. Put a smile on my face, start shaking people's hands, start meeting people, start getting invited. So I'm going to be reinforced for self-promotion and for extroversion. When I'm in my small town, I'm going to start doing my thing. I'm going to

follow the path. I'm going to go get married because I'm married to a girl from high school. And in the big town, I'm going to start dating people.

7.102 But everybody's been shallow and self-promotional, too. So it's going to be very hard for me to find the girl next door in a big town. So it's going to take me longer to settle down. So my self is going to be more aggressive, more extroverted, more individualized, a little more competitive, and a little more self-seeking, ambitious, in a big city, I think. And then what's going to happen is, you're going to hit a point when you're in your mid-30s or 40s, where you're like, "Do I want to do this forever? Or do I want to settle down?"

7.103 And then you're either going to find one random person and go, "Let's just move to Westchester County and get a dog and hope we make this work and get the heck out of here." Or let's move to, I don't know where you move in Miami. Just get out to somewhere inland and try to make this work. Or you go, "I'm just buying into this kind of life. I'm just an individual self-promoter." And that's awesome until you're 75 or 80. And then you're old and no one cares about you, and everything you thought was cool, no one thinks it's cool anymore. And no one remembers what you remember. And then you're isolated and alone and atomized and feeding pigeons. And it's pretty sad.

Lecture 8: Paths to Self-Growth

At a glance — Paths to self-growth.

- 8.1** This is our last session, and I thought, well, we haven't talked about enough heavy stuff yet. What I wanted to focus on was growth and transcendence. I thought, well, these are kind of the more interesting topics of the self, these concepts of how do we grow as a person? How do we grow to be what we want to be? It's a challenge. There's questions of, like, who do I want to be when I grow? How am I going to get there? These are all the self-regulation questions we've asked. How am I going to change as I grow? That's what's cool about being a self. As you grow, your actual experience of being a self is changing in the process. It's this very complicated process of growth.
- 8.2** Then you get this question like, how do I grow beyond myself? How can I be the best self that I could possibly be? How can I be even better than myself? How can I transcend myself? How can I rise above the duality and suffering of the world? These are questions people have asked throughout history. We talk about terms like self-actualization, be who all you can be. Self-transcendence, transcend the person you are. Individuate, this is Jung's term, become a full individual or become the absolute, become the fullest manifestation of your essence in this world. We can talk about just maturation, becoming a mature adult, growing from a child into an adult.
- 8.3** All these different ways of talking about growth are happening, and I want to talk about them. But what's interesting, when you talk about the highest levels of growth, and this is what we'll run into in this hour, is you can talk about something like self-actualization, which is being the best version of you. Then you can talk about something like self-transcendence, which is being beyond you in some interesting way that's hard to describe. That might be a peak experience or mystical experience or something like that. We talk about both those things.
- 8.4** Maturation, becoming a mature adult, is the basic path of growth. It's the basic path of the development of the self. It's obviously a biological process. We mature biologically. You go through adolescence, you get the hormones, you go into adulthood, you change. There's all those processes. With any creature, we talk about juveniles and adults, so it's not like it's just a human thing. But human adulthood and human maturity is very cultural. It's very much a social phenomenon. We define it culturally.
- 8.5** The traditional markers of being a mature adult in a society are essentially supporting yourself in the community. It's like, you're bringing more than you're taking. I remember I talked to Roy Baumeister, did this big book on masculinity, and I was like, "Dude, what does it mean to be a man?" He's like, "Well, I talked to all the anthropologists and read all the literature and it boils down to, you bring more to the system than you take." Well, that sounds pretty easy, but makes sense. You're

contributing. So the idea of an adult is you're contributing, and as a child, you're taking, because that's just the nature of things.

- 8.6** What does it mean to contribute? Well, in our society, and this is common in a lot of societies, we have markers of adulthood. What does it mean to be an adult? Well, you get a job, you do something to make money, you're economically independent, you live by yourself independently, you move out of your home with your parents and you move by yourself or with somebody else or in another arrangement, so you're living independently. Perhaps you get married and start to form your own family, and perhaps you have children.
- 8.7** The classic adult marker is independently supporting myself, married, living with myself with kids. That's the general marker or markers. Again, this is society. It's not like, "Hey, you didn't have kids. You're not an adult." You're like, "Dude, I'm a priest. What was I supposed to do?" "No, you're a child." It's not like that. It's not that everyone has to follow the path. It's just that's the general path we see in society. That path of maturation goes along with psychological change. When you see people mature into cultural maturity, what you see is greater conscientiousness. People become more dutiful, disciplined, work-focused.
- 8.8** It's obvious. You have a kid, you got to wake up in the morning. You have a dog, you have to wake up in the morning. By yourself, you don't really have to wake up in the morning. People tend to have higher emotional stability. You can't be quite as neurotic when you're an adult. You can't cry at work all the time. There's things you learn. I remember my wife was a consultant back in the day, and those jobs are tense. I remember one of the things she said is, she goes, "Yeah, no crying in consulting." Because everybody starts off as a consultant. They have one day, they just lose it, and then they get the talk. "No crying in consulting. You just got to suck it up."
- 8.9** So higher emotional stability, higher extroversion because you have to go meet people, you have to engage with the world, you have to be confident, and then a little bit of higher agreeableness because you got to get along with people. So generally, to become an adult citizen, a productive member of society, there's a push to be a little more conscientious, a little more confident, a little nicer, a little more agreeable, and harder-working, extroverted. That's a process that we see.
- 8.10** But today, because of the way our culture is designed, if we grew up in the 1950s, we'd all feel the pressure to be married. Everybody in here would probably have 16 kids. I just made that up completely. But if it were 1910, we'd all be like my great-grandfather had 13 kids; that's just how it was. Everyone would be going through this process because that's just how our society is set up. Right now, we live in a very individualistic society, meaning, you can choose if you want to be an adult or not. You don't have to really do it.

- 8.11** I noticed this when I heard people start talking about "adulthood" as a verb. When I was in, I remember I was in a yoga class, and somebody said, "Oh, I have to adult today. I have to do my laundry." OK, I thought that's interesting. I'm going to be a child most of the time, but occasionally, I got to be an adult. I thought about it, I thought, well, that kind of makes sense because being an adult kind of sucks, because it's hard and you got to show up and you got to get stuff for your kids and you have to wake up before them and make breakfast, and who wants to get up early and make breakfast? Certainly not me. When I'm alone at a hotel, it's much easier for me.
- 8.12** There's a choice of being an adult. It's also, we're in a time where it's very hard for people to establish independent adult lives because of a lot of social and economic reasons. It's hard to date. I don't understand how they do it with these cell phones, but I've looked at some of the research and it seems like a really awful way to do it. If I had to design a system that would lead to chaos, this is what I would design. It's terrible because, literally, you're giving people choices of judging people to date based on a photo. Come on. I mean, I would rather have a matchmaker. I'd literally have just a random matchmaker do it rather than a phone.
- 8.13** Then you're like, OK, finally, I found somebody. Then they're like, "But there's a billion other people out there, so I don't really want to commit." Finally, after you have 8 million bad dates, you go, "I'm going to just give up and commit." Then you go, "Let's buy a house." Then you go, "Oops, I guess that's not going to happen because interest rates are 800% and I live in a hurricane zone, and there's no houses for sale despite that." The houses are both unaffordable and unavailable, which is economically impossible, but it managed to happen.
- 8.14** Then you're not, and then you're in a society and you have kids. You're like, "What am I doing with the kids? There's no kids around." You take your kids to Disney, right? You're like, "I'm taking my kids to Disney," and you look around, it's all adults. It's all like Disney adults. What am I doing here? It's a bunch of grownups here dressed as wolves or something. It's crazy. There's not really a childhood culture. This idea of adulthood is something that's become a bit optional in society. The challenge is, you end up with people that just don't develop because they don't have the pressure to develop.
- 8.15** A lot of us, I mean, if I were left up to my, I'd be dead if I were left up to my own choices in life. I never would have made it to 1992. So, you give people choice, and often they make bad choices. This happened in the '70s. A lot of what we're seeing now is a reflection of the '70s, the narcissism, and then the collapse after that. In the '70s, they talked about Peter Pan syndrome. They had guys like Warren Beatty who was like, Peter Pan. These were guys that would, like, date 20-year-olds their whole life and never grow up. Carl Jung called this the puer or the puer aeternus, puer aeternus, which would be the eternal boy or the eternal youth. But it's this archetype of somebody who never grows up.

- 8.16** So that's something we're seeing in culture. In a weird way, we have a society that traps you. Even before you just become an adult, you get trapped and you become a Disney kid for your whole life or something. It's a very hard cultural time just to do basic maturity. Let's say, though, you get through it and you're like, "Yeah, I got to where I want to be. I matured, I'm independent, I'm navigating, I have a sense of agency, I have some control of my life, I'm contributing, I have a job." Maybe it feels occasionally like what I do matters. I know most of our jobs don't feel that.
- 8.17** My fantasy about being a bellman is partly because I remember when I was a bellman, I would actually do good. I'd pick up a bag and put it in a car. I'm helping the world. A lot of jobs, you don't feel like you're doing that much good. You work a big corporation. You're like, dude, I'm just moving digits for evil. I don't even understand it. But you get to that place and you go, OK, I want to grow beyond this. I don't want to just be an adult. I want to be something more. How do I do that? How do I become something?
- 8.18** I guarantee you, this audience—I shouldn't guarantee anything—but I bet most of you guys are like this. You're like, "I'm trying to learn more. I'm trying to become something more. I'm trying to improve myself, better myself, explore." How do you do that? Society offers a couple of different routes for that right now. One thing that you see that's very common, I call optimizing or the optimization, I call it that. That's what people call it, self-optimization, life optimization. I see this coming out of the tech world.
- 8.19** This is people going, "You know what I'm going to do? I'm operating a certain way. What I'm going to do is, I'm going to treat myself like an engineering project, and I'm going to set up the context of my life so that I get the most performance out of myself as possible." I'm going to treat myself like a factory floor. I'm going to treat myself like a machine, and I'm going to get the most out of myself as possible. How am I going to do that?
- 8.20** Well, I'm going to get my diet dialed in, so my energy's, my mitochondrial energy's maximized. I'm going to sleep for 8.5 hours on a certain bed to maximize my sleep. Then I'm going to wake up in the morning and meditate for 20 minutes while looking at the sun through one eye because that's going to wake my pituitary gland. Then I'm going to drink matcha tea and one shot of espresso and two celery roots, because that's what's going to get—you know what I mean? You know what I'm talking about, right? This is optimization. This is treating yourself like a machine.
- 8.21** It's like just having a car and going, "I'm getting my, I'm race-tuning this baby." You're doing it to yourself and you're optimizing. So optimizing, again, this is really popular. I see people do this all the time. Optimization is really good when you know exactly what goal you want. If you're in a path towards a goal and you go, "I just want to get there faster. I want to get there more. I want to get there better. I want to publish more research. I want to do better," whatever it is, optimization strategies are really good.

- 8.22** But optimization only pretty much gets you where you want to go, and it puts blinders on to everything else. The cost of optimization is you lose optionality or you lose other things. This brings up one of the big questions that's throughout all of this study of the self back in time, which is, is it better to have a vision in your mind and go for it fully, or is it better to trust the universe and go on an adventure and hope you end up where you're supposed to be, even though you couldn't imagine it when you started?
- 8.23** The other way of approaching this, rather than optimizing, I call more alchemizing; it's more like an alchemy approach, more of a chemistry approach, is that rather than pursuing goals directly, you pursue goals directly, but you don't take your blinders off. So you see opportunities, you jump at those opportunities, you take risks, you take chances. Different things happen. Some things go nowhere, some things go somewhere. Life becomes a bit of an adventure, and you don't know where it's going to end up when you do that. Sometimes you go through these processes and you have a life like this, and you have a period of time where nothing seems to happen.
- 8.24** So Carl Jung had this period of time called this fallow period, where he just sat in Switzerland in his house and had visions. It didn't produce any. It's like the least optimal time of his career. But that's where all these great ideas, like The Red Book and everything after, came from. So if you take a different approach to life, it's not going to be optimal. It's going to be a little bit more like this. But sometimes you'll get to a place that'll be really interesting. Sometimes you'll just end up trapped in a bad hotel in Baja and not know how you got there and pray you just can be back home.
- 8.25** Things can happen either way. Both of those routes are available to people. When people are trying to grow, you can either try to just really dial it in and optimize, or you can open up the aperture and try to have an adventure. Both are going to work. They're just going to work a little differently. What's the endpoint of this growth? As I said at the beginning, people talk about two different endpoints for life. The first of these endpoints people talk about is self-actualization. This is a term that goes back to Abraham Maslow, the great motivational researcher, hugely popular idea in California. All the developments, the optimization we hear now comes out of Maslow, basically.
- 8.26** What is self-actualization? Well, what Maslow said was, "What one can be, one must be!" Exclamation point. "What one can be, one must be." Point a finger at you. That's self-actualization. It's, you have the potential to be that, you need to reach that potential. You got to reach your full potential. That's a really hard thing to do. I didn't make it. Most people don't make it. That's self-actualization. Well, then Maslow got into self-actualization and was into it his whole life, and I'll talk about a little more. But then he noticed that maybe there's more to life than just being all you can be.
- 8.27** Maybe you can go beyond that. Maybe you can have moments of connection, moments of wholeness, moments of greater vision, which he might call self-transcendence, and he might say might happen in moments like peak experiences. So

he said, not only do you actualize yourself, but sometimes at the process of fullness of the self that you transcend the self, that there's a sense of overcoming the self.

- 8.28** The metaphor I like to use for this is an alchemical metaphor from winemaking. Imagine you make wine, and there's really two steps. The first step is, you grow a really good grape. And a grape is, growing a grape is a beautiful process, and a fully mature grape, like self-actualized, the best grape you can be, that's a real goal, a real accomplishment, growing a great grape. If all you did was grow grapes in your life, that would be a great life. But what people do then is say, "God, I grew this great grape. This is fantastic. What I'm going to do is I'm going to smash it into pieces and make it sit and ferment in a barrel for a long time. Maybe add some yeast."
- 8.29** They take that beautiful grape they built and they said, "Well, we're going to go beyond this grape. We're going to smash it in a barrel, ferment that bad boy for a while. Then through this magic process of chemistry or alchemy, what we're going to get out of that is a spirit. We're getting wine. We're transforming the fruit into the spirit." That's the metaphor of self-transcendence. It's going beyond this really good self, which is this beautiful grape, and then becoming something that's spiritual, something that transcends what the grape is, becoming an essence.
- 8.30** Again, it's a metaphor. I think of the actualization like becoming a grape, and transcendence is like becoming wine. It's going beyond that, becoming spirit, something different. Very hard to measure this stuff in a lab. How can we think about self-actualization and self-transcendence in different ways? I thought, well, let's think about it in the short term and medium term and long term, and talk it through that way.
- 8.31** In the short term, probably the best work on self-actualization and self-transcendence is the work on flow or optimal experience that comes out of the motivational field. This goes back to the work of a psychologist, Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, who apparently went by Mike, and I never met him. I tried so many times, three times. It just never worked out. A genius guy. He got very interested in why people climb mountains and why people do art. He would hang out with artists in the '70s, and artists would draw paintings, and then they just put the painting down, they'd draw another painting.
- 8.32** He's like, well, I thought you'd draw the painting so you get a painting. But the artists weren't interested in having a painting. They were interested in the process of painting. Then he started hanging out with climbers, and he was a climber, and climbing was really big in the '70s. This is where Patagonia comes from, and North Face. This was a huge cultural thing. He talked to climbers, and what you notice with climbers is none of them were really climbing to get to the top of the mountain. That was a goal, but the real reason they were doing it was the joy of the climb. It was the intensity of the climb.
- 8.33** But it wasn't like a climb was being on a parade float in a parade in New Orleans at Mardi Gras, drinking bourbon, waving. It wasn't that kind of fun. It was a different kind

of fun. It was what he called optimal experience. When you're climbing, you're so focused on what you're doing because if you slip, you die, or maybe if you have a rope, but it's sketchy anyway. You're so focused on what you're doing and you're getting immediate feedback for everything you do. Every hand position, there's immediate feedback.

- 8.34** What happens with that is you get so focused that you lose self-awareness because you're just in the process. As one climber said, "I just feel like I'm flowing in the flow," because it was the '70s, and that's how people talked. "Dude, I was just flowing in the flow." That's why they call it flow. There's an example of, like, and I'm there and all of a sudden I just see this insect and I feel one with the insect on the rock because I've gotten so focused on myself. I'm so engaged in what I'm doing that I've lost self-awareness and I'm transcending at the same time. Does that make sense? It's a little weird.
- 8.35** So these flow experiences are neat because they can offer very short-term self-transcendence during that flow state. When people play sports, they call it being in the zone. They're like, "Yeah, I just keep shooting shots and I hit every shot and it just feels like magic." So people become self-transcendent in those experiences. They also perform very well. And then after flow states, when people come out of it, they feel self-actualized. Their self disappears when they're in the experience, but afterwards, it's like, "Man, I feel like I am who I am. I really nailed that. I really did that." So this deep engaging in things we love, especially things that give us immediate feedback.
- 8.36** I always liked snowboarding, mountain climbing, chess. Like I said, he did surgeons, Japanese motorcycle gangs he studied, boaters in Fiji. I mean, very interesting career, boaters in Fiji. Lots and lots of things can give us potentially a flow state. As long as we get—video games are designed to give people flow, that's why they're addictive or enjoyable. A flow state is an external way of generating both self-transcendence but also self-actualization. Again, the flow state, the self-transcendence in the flow state is very short. It's typically very short.
- 8.37** If you imagine you're, I mean, I've had this happen a lot. You're surfing, you're like, "Dude, I'm flowing." Then you're like, "I'm out of it." As soon as you say, "Dude, I'm in flow," you're out of flow. That makes sense? You can't be in flow going, "I'm in flow," because you lose yourself. That's the price. As soon as you're in flow and you realize it, you get knocked out of flow. These are smaller states, like a lot of self-transcendence. That's the external route.
- 8.38** There's an internal route as well, which is a route of meditation practice. People that use very significant meditation where they're focusing on something like their breath or a mantra or something else that they're getting feedback, because they're getting feedback from what they're focusing on—I'm breathing. OK, I lost that. I'm breathing. I lost that—there are meditative states of self-transcendence. I've never experienced one. I usually meditate and just stress out and then go, "God, this isn't working." I do it

the next day. But people who actually seem to be able to meditate, they can develop that focus, do have experiences of self-transcendence in meditation.

8.39 Sometimes you call it samadhi, self-transcendence, a sense of loss of self often accompanied with joy. Again, this is just what I've read about. A sense of joy, a sense of divine essence. People come back from that being stronger in their sense of self as well. It's not that you lose yourself and don't come back. You transcend yourself and then you come back a little stronger. There's this interesting link between self-transcendence and self-actualization. Self-transcendence is different than just bailing on yourself and just becoming a maniac. It's like leaving yourself a little bit.

8.40 In the short term, you have things like flow or meditative experiences. In the medium term, there's lots of examples of processes of self-actualization and self-transcendence. I wanted to just talk about a couple of them. So post-traumatic growth. The idea here is that negative and positive emotion, systems, growth, experiences, are separate. What does that mean? Well, I can have a very negative experience, a traumatic experience; that can lead to lots of negative stuff. Depression, rumination about the negative experience, intrusive thoughts about the trauma. All these negative things can happen.

8.41 But that trauma didn't kill my positive growth side because that's a different system. It's just like approach and avoidance are different systems. Sometimes what happens are people experience trauma, and that activates a desire to grow, which is a little bit counterintuitive. But the trauma itself is the motivation to grow. Without that trauma, you might not have. The early research on this was looking at things like cancer patients. People have cancer. Oh, my God. Really bad trauma. A lot of negative stuff. But people will also sometimes go, "My goodness, this is a wake-up call. This is time for me to go out there and do what I meant to do, to express myself, to grow."

8.42 Again, you have the negativity, but it can also generate positive change towards self-actualization because of the negativity. The example of Socrates, when he was being put to death, his daemon was like, "Yep, you got to go learn the lyre." Maybe that's post-traumatic growth. I just made that up as an example right now, but that's an example. Even you're in this bad position, go do something. My favorite classic example of post-traumatic growth is the book *The Razor's Edge* by Somerset Maugham, which most of you are probably not familiar with. They made it into a, won the best picture award in the '30s when they made it into a movie. Then Bill Murray made it into a movie in the '80s, I think, which I liked, but no one else did. It was one of Bill Murray's serious roles.

8.43 But *The Razor's Edge*, that title comes from one of the Upanishads, which has a line something like, "The path to enlightenment is as narrow and dangerous to walk on as a razor's edge." *The Razor's Edge* is about the path to enlightenment. That's what that phrase refers to. The story of *The Razor's Edge* is Bill Murray—I'm going to say Bill Murray, whoever the character is, protagonist—is in World War I, ends up with shell shock or PTSD from seeing his friends die. Like a lot of wealthy kids, he was one of the

people over there, and he went back to his house and just started drinking himself to death like a lot of people do with PTSD.

- 8.44** Then he decided to, "Maybe this isn't everything in life. Maybe there's something more, and I shouldn't just drink myself to death." So he started exploring. This is the growth. He started working in a coal mine. He started studying religion. He meets a guy, and a guy gives him some religious text from India. Bill Murray goes to India. He starts reading, he's reading the Upanishads. He ends up in the Himalayas. He ends up burning all his texts and transcending himself. There's a whole love story in there, too, with a lot of loss. Ends up being a cab driver in New York. I hate to ruin it for you, but that's what happens.
- 8.45** I think the line in there is something like, "I'm just going to be like a flame, and I know I'm going to attract people that need to be in my cab to talk to me." That's the story of self-actualization and self-transcendence that was set about by this early trauma. A guy that would have normally just been a rich dude in Britain or something, just an arrogant, boring guy, because of this trauma, ends up on this journey around the world and ends up being a cab driver with a very enlightened life. That's post-traumatic growth. It's a very interesting thing.
- 8.46** The other example I was going to talk about is mystical experience. I love defining mystical experience because it's so hard to define. Mystical experiences are experiences often associated with religious practice, but they can happen at other times as well. Psychedelic world, you see it a lot. William James, when he wrote the Varieties of Religious Experience, spent a lot of time trying to document and understand mystical experience. James had mystical experiences of his own. He writes about those in his book. I said before, I think he was using nitrous oxide. That was his go-to. People do what people do.
- 8.47** He wrote about mystical experiences. Like I said, James is smarter than me. Here are what he says are the big four descriptors of mystical experience, and I am going to read these to you a little bit because they're interesting. The first description or the first descriptor of a mystical experience is ineffability. What does that mean? This is James' quote. "The handiest of the marks by which I classify a state of mind as mystical is negative." What that means is, the one thing I can tell you about mystical experiences is you can't explain them to anybody.
- 8.48** The core of a mystical experience is it's something that's ineffable. It's something you can't explain to somebody else. That's a weird definition because it's what something isn't rather than what something is, which is why James is saying it's a negative. His first definition is a negative definition. Something about mystical experiences are very hard to explain. The second thing James talks about is they have a noetic quality. You hear this term a lot, noetic quality, N-O-E-T-I-C.

- 8.49** "Although so similar to states of feeling, mystical states seem to those who experience — mystical states seem to those who experience them to also be states of knowledge." A noetic quality of a mystical state is that there's a transfer of knowledge or intelligence in that experience. It feels that there is something intelligent in there, and sometimes you're getting that intelligence. When you get direct communication in a mystical experience, this is often called a revelation, like the Book of Revelation. If you read the Book of Revelation, and you probably haven't done it in a while, I did it pretty recently.
- 8.50** It's kind of, the scene is, guy eats a book, it tastes a little bitter. And then he starts having visions. Angel comes down and then he has a bunch of, and the visions are all alchemical texts, and I don't really understand them. But that's what's going on in the Book of Revelation, is a guy having a mystical experience, and that mystical experience is filled with knowledge. It's filled with revelation, noetic qualities. Basically, they're saying, is it John? I don't even remember. And they're saying, "Hey, John, here's what you're going to get." Boom. Here's your vision.
- 8.51** Then he gets this vision and he writes it down and like, "What do I do with this? I don't know. I don't know what it means." You got a vision. The noetic quality of these experiences, there's an intelligence coming to you, and sometimes it's a revelation that's very direct, like the Book of Revelation. If you read the Ganesha Upanishad, that was a revelation. A guy was worshipping. He had an image of Ganesha. They taught him a mantra, "Om Gam Ganapataye Namaha." And that was written down into the Upanishads. And then other people started trying that.
- 8.52** The sacred heart of Jesus, you see that heart, the flames. That was a vision. I'm going to say Teresa d'Ávila, and it's probably totally wrong. Sorry, guys. That was a vision someone had. That was a revelation. And then that revelation got brought into the church. Now I drive around the interstates in Florida, I'll see the flaming heart of Jesus or the sacred heart of Jesus. But again, that was a mystical revelation that someone had a long time ago. There's this noetic quality to this experience. Again, the revelations are what I think people should be studying more, and they're just not studying that much because it's not in our measure so much.
- 8.53** The third quality, and I've hinted at this a few times, is transiency, meaning these things are short-lived. "Mystical states cannot be sustained for long. Except in rare instances, half an hour, or at most an hour or two, seems to be the limit beyond which they fade into the light of common day." What James is saying is, people are having mystical experiences. Again, he gathered everyone he could find, primarily Christian. He said that these things would last a little while and then they would go away. Often, they would have no effect again. You'd have a mystical vision and that was it. You'd never have another one. It might not have any influence on your life at all.
- 8.54** Other people would have one and they'd have a revelation and it would have an influence. It would change them dramatically. But there's short-term things. People aren't typically living in a mystic state. You go to the Himalayas, you probably can find

some people living in mystic states for a longer period of time. But in our culture, typically a mystical experience is a short-term thing. There's transiency, so these things are generally short-lived.

- 8.55** Then there's passivity, meaning that, although the oncoming of mystical states may be facilitated by preliminary voluntary operations, meaning you can pray, you can prepare, you can do a dieta, you can do whatever. "Yet when the characteristic sort of consciousness once has set in, the mystic feels as if his own will were in abeyance, and indeed, sometimes as if he were grasped and held by a superior power." There's an experience. Part of mystical experience is feeling that I'm not really running this thing, something else has taken over. That's the final, that's the description.
- 8.56** A mystical experience is an experience that's very hard to describe, that has some sort of intelligence or revelation that you can see that lasts not for very long, and that seems to take me over when it happens. That's it. Very hard to make sense of that, mystical experience. People started measuring mystical experiences. I think this was the '70s when they started doing this. It came out of some of the anthropological work at Harvard, and they developed the Mystical Experiences Questionnaire or MEQ. If you ever want to measure mystical experiences, there is a questionnaire for it.
- 8.57** They just came out with a short form. I got real excited because I love the short forms of questionnaires. The short term, the short-form mystical questionnaire, mystical experience questionnaire, here are the four questions it's asking, the four topics. Did you experience a sense of oneness, insight, into ultimate reality or sacredness? Sense of oneness, sense of unity? Did you have a positive mood? So generally a positive experience. Was there a transcendence of time and space? Did you feel outside of time and space, and was it ineffable? Was it incapable of being expressed or described in words?
- 8.58** That's a short version of measuring mystical experience. It's on a continuum. So a full mystical experience would be, "Yeah, I had a sense of oneness inside into the ultimate reality. It felt good. I transcended time and space, and I really can't explain it. It was just weird." That's a mystical experience. Again, they don't measure revelations in there, and I wish people would measure revelations more. We just haven't gotten there yet because I always find that the interesting part.
- 8.59** Mystical experience as a process of self-transcendence, which it really is, it's becoming, sort of escaping yourself and connecting with something bigger or something greater in a way that's unexplainable, it was very hard to study. The way James did it was he would run around and collect stories. Maybe all this priest over in Alcot had an experience, and he wrote it in his diary, and maybe this person wrote a diary. Then there's Saint Francis and all the different classic experiences.
- 8.60** James collected those, but they're not a lot. People weren't having mystical experiences very often. It would just happen occasionally, unless you were a poet like

Walt Whitman or something, or Thoreau, you just weren't having these. What we have now are psychedelics. Psychedelic medicines or psychedelic compounds have the ability to reliably produce mystical experiences in just normal scrubs like all of us. The research that really blew my mind on this was done by Katherine MacLean and Matt Johnson and Roland Griffiths, at John Hopkins, and this was 2011, so this is probably 15 years ago when they were first doing this.

- 8.61** They were looking at the effect of synthetic psilocybin on individual's mood, personality, and religious experience. The way the paradigm works is that people will have somebody, they'll feel comfortable with a social worker, a clinician, somebody they get comfortable with ahead of time. They come into the lab, they lie down on a couch, they take a dose of, again, it's synthetic psilocybin. I don't even know what you may call it, something else. Put on headphones and eye blinds, typically, but you've got a person there just in case. There's certain music they listen to. It was classical, I think, and now they're changing. You can find these different psychedelic playlists and stuff.
- 8.62** People would just sit there for four or five hours on the couch and have an experience. It was very non-directive. It was that people were just there, and if they wanted to talk, they could talk. Then they'd measure change in personality, mystical experience, all that after. When they did this first study, they found that something like 40%, around half the people had mystical experiences. I saw that, I'm like, "Oh, my god. You took half the people in your study, you have a mystical experience, like a lifetime." They rated it as one of the most important experiences of their life.
- 8.63** I'm like, "You can bring just some knucklehead off the street, put him on a couch, and give him one of the most important experiences of your life? That's weird." Then they said, and lo and behold, you find change in personality that goes with this, particularly in openness. You find people who have mystical experiences tend to end up a little more open to experience, in terms of Big Five personality traits. Remember, we talk about trait openness. They argue that, yeah, these mystical experiences are maybe opening people up a little bit, and this is a bit of a permanent change. I saw that—hard to describe. This blew my mind back in.
- 8.64** Now, you guys all know about the psychedelic work that has been going on a long time, but I just was shocked. I was talking to Katherine MacLean. I'm like, "You got to come down and give a talk." I invited her down Georgia because I'm like, I got to hear this stuff. She did a talk and we hung out. I was absolutely fascinated with the stuff. That is what's going on now in medical, psychedelic work. I got interested in that stuff, but I'm a yogi and I just meet people and I ended up with one of my buddies. Then she's like, "Yeah, my boyfriend's in town," and I see this guy doing yoga with a beard down to here. I'm like, "He rocks, but he looks like a hobo." She's like, "It's my boyfriend."
- 8.65** So I go talk to him and he's like, he's a shaman. That's interesting. What do you do? He was like, "I'm an ayahuasquero, curandero." And I go, "Well, that sounds like nonsense, but let's hang out." I'm a dick. I'm sorry. So I said, "Let's go have some tea, and I'd just

love to hear what you have to say." So I chatted with this guy, and he's like, "Yeah, this is what we do." And he's like, "You want to try something?" I'm like, "Yeah, I don't really want to try ayahuasca. No." He goes, "Well, how about some kambo?" I'm like, "Oh, that sounds easy. What's that?" "Well, we just burn you and just rub some frog venom on you and it's good to go." I'm like, well, that sounds easy enough.

- 8.66** I'm hanging out and we do a kambo ceremony. I don't know if you guys know what kambo—anyway, I should explain it. Yeah, it's like you, I don't know why I'm talking about this on set. I'm glad this isn't being filmed. Oh, God. OK. So what they do is they will burn you, and then they scrape the wound open, put in some venom, and then it's like, I don't know exactly what it is. It feels like a neurotoxin. When I've looked at the research, there's some opioids in it. I just felt like I was being strangled and I was about to die and I couldn't breathe. Then I'm puking in a bucket.
- 8.67** Then I had a vision. It was like I had a vision of this kambo from, what the fuck? I'm cracking up and puking and thinking I'm going to die. I go to my buddy afterwards. I'm like, "What the hell did I just see? I don't understand this." He goes, "Just think of it as a Jungian archetype." I go, "OK, I'm comfortable with that." I don't know what that was, but it was weird, but it made me feel really good. I started getting interested in what we call plant medicine, this Amazonian plant medicine.
- 8.68** And what you'll notice when you start working with the Amazonian plants is they're using natural things like kambo, which isn't really a psychedelic, but it's visionary. Or they're using things like huachuma or San Pedro cactus, which is like mescaline base, which is more classic psychedelic. Or they're using ayahuasca, which is DMT that you can drink, which is a very powerful psychedelic. But all these things make you sick. When you go do the Western version of this, you're in a nice room, it's all chill, it's clean, it's antiseptic. You got headphones on.
- 8.69** You do the more traditional version of this. You take a psychedelic, you take a frog, and you end up purging. You end up throwing up, you end up sweating, you end up having diarrhea. It's never fun. I got interested in this because I thought, well, this is pretty cool. There's got to be something with this. I had a grad student do it. It was so bad. My grad student is like, "Yeah, I'll go figure this stuff out." He heads down to Peru to go hang out with some shaman and drink ayahuasca, figure this stuff out. I should feel guilty about that.
- 8.70** Anyway, long story short, we start studying the effects of ayahuasca on personality change and mystical experience. Lo and behold, what you find is people that go through ayahuasca ceremonies, and these are done—I'll, in a second, I'll explain how this works. What you find is people pretty reliably have mystical experiences. Not all the time, often it has no effect, but pretty reliably have mystical experiences, and you get pretty substantial personality change.

- 8.71** We did not find people becoming more open after drinking ayahuasca. Turns out that people that are traveling to Peru to drink ayahuasca were pretty open to start with. We couldn't do a random assignment. You can't just like, "Hey, you seem like a boring person. I got a little adventure for you." We found a big drop in neuroticism. We found an increase in psychological flexibility and a drop in neuroticism. People just get more calm. This is why it seems helpful for PTSD, post-traumatic stress disorder. We've done a little work with PTSD, but not big enough samples. It's just hard to find that many special operations people that are down, and it's happening now.
- 8.72** What do I want to say about psychedelic mystical experience? Well, I'll tell you how, I'll just give you an example. What the heck? The way that, there's different versions of ayahuasca. The most commonly used approach is a modified approach from the Shipibo tradition. There are lots of people studying Colombia now. The Colombian traditions are a little different. They just use the medicine a little differently. There are other traditions that people aren't—well, there's some in Brazil that are more religious, like San Daime, that are different. People use it in different ways. But when you're talking to a bunch of gringos, usually they're doing more of a Shipibo version.
- 8.73** The way the ceremonies work is, there's usually a preparation ahead of time, like a dieta, diet for a couple of weeks. So you eliminate pork and sex and drugs, and you clean yourself up. Remember purification? So there's spiritual purification ahead of time. And then the ceremony's, it's typically about four, five, six hours, somewhere along that. It starts around, a shaman sits there, you purify everything, a bunch of tobacco. Then everyone drinks a shot of espresso, which isn't really espresso. It's just nasty ayahuasca, but it tastes like gnarly espresso.
- 8.74** Then everyone sits in the dark for like 45 minutes because it takes about 45 minutes to kick in. Then the shaman will go. It would be like, and you're like, "Uh-oh." Then they start singing. The way the shaman change you in an ayahuasca ceremony is they use songs that they were taught by the plants, which are called icaros. They sing their songs that they learn from the plants, and then the songs and the plants start doing the stuff. They start doing the healing stuff. That can take all sorts of forms.
- 8.75** There's a great book called *Antipodes of the Mind*, if you're really into this and want to see all the different experiences people have. People have very similar visions. Then there's usually, people start to purge after about another 45 minutes. After it starts, about an hour in, people start throwing up and it's gross, but you're like, the weird thing is, when you're throwing up, that's the good part because you don't feel like you're dying. Then after about four hours, it goes away, and there's a little bit of a close. That's how an ayahuasca ceremony works.
- 8.76** They're very challenging, or they can be very challenging. I never recommend it to people. I was trying to think of a mystical experience to share because I'm like, I got to talk about one. I got to think of one. The last mystical experience I had was, after two days of ceremony, so I was just dead. I wasn't paying any attention. And the next thing

you know, these are just visions. You just get visions. I'm rolling around the Earth looking down and everything makes sense. And I'm like, everything coheres, everything makes sense. I feel total peace. I was like, wait a second, I'm getting a mystical vision. This is really awesome. Thanks. I was too beat up to even appreciate it, but I'm like, thank you. Then it went away.

- 8.77** That's a mystical experience. You get lots of crazy experiences with the medicines. You get entities, you get angels, you get demons, you get all sorts of crazy stuff. But the mystical vision happens occasionally. It's often an experience of wholeness. But again, it just goes away. You can't really hold it. You can't keep it all the time. You just roll through it and roll out. But what I find crazy about the world now is every normal person can just go get on an airplane and go have whatever crazy visionary experience they want. Again, I don't ever recommend it to people because these things can be really destabilizing.
- 8.78** What happens is people go, "Oh, I saw God. Oh, God's real." Then they go, "I need to change my life. I'm going to quit my job, leave my family, and become a flame dancer or whatever. I'm going to become a juggler and join." That's what mama ayahuasca wants me to do. I'm like, maybe not. Just take care of your kids. Not a recommendation. But these are really powerful ways of inducing mystical experience and transcendent experiences that are very easy to access, and maybe too easy to access.
- 8.79** There's a place around, probably four hours from here, around Universal Studios or something, where they have a whole ayahuasca church that apparently there's not even a shaman. They just have music playing. I don't know if that's true. I've just heard stories, just heard stories. Yeah, I would not do this, but not do this without somebody you trust, by the way. Big smiles. OK. So that's it.
- 8.80** So mystical experience is a bit of a medium-term thing. It happens, you think about it, but people don't just live in that mystical state, except for every once in a while, you read about somebody somewhere doing it. Longer term, we talk about it as self-actualization and transcendence. When Rogers and Maslow wrote about self-actualization, this was the 1950s and '60s human potential movement. There was this massive interest in bringing out the most possible potential out of people.
- 8.81** If you hear terms like Esalen Institute in northern California, up by Carmel, that was where people would hang out. That was one of the places. You hear about T-groups, or if you hear about encounter sessions or encounter groups where people would sit there and tell the truth to each other and be real honest. That's part of the human potential movement. All these ideas that we hear now with optimization were big in the '50s and '60s with human potential. We got all the '70s stuff, like S-data out of this. This is all before your time. Anyway, all the culty things.

- 8.82** Rogers and Maslow were really focused on self-actualization. What happened is that, as Maslow got older, he had a heart attack. He started going, "Yeah, there's more to life than just being a really good psychologist." Like, hey, I'm the best as I can be. They also started studying self-actualization. There's this great chapter Maslow wrote where he sits together with a group of people and they're like, "Let's identify all the self-actualized people." They get Eleanor Roosevelt and Gandhi and Abe Lincoln and Martin Luther King. It's like six people that are self-actualized. They're like, "Well, maybe Thomas Jefferson," 50-50.
- 8.83** Basically, what they're saying is, none of us ever get there because six people actually actualized. That's a sad model of self-actualization. But Maslow, after his heart attack, started noticing things that were self-transcendent. The people that were focused on actualizing would occasionally have, like what I said before, these mystical experiences, these connections to the divine, "momentary experiences of transcendence, awe, beauty, wholeness, and connection." It's a quote. Those are peak experiences. What Maslow and Rogers were talking about were things like peak experiences that people would have in the short term.
- 8.84** The optimal life in the humanistic psychology world is to focus on being the best version of yourself you can be, but be open to transcending yourself into something greater than yourself, even though that will only be for a short period of time. That's the American self-actualization, self-improvement model. Be really good, occasionally mystical experiences, but don't get too weird. Come back. I love that model.
- 8.85** The other really big model of self-transcendence is the Jungian, Carl Jung's model of individuation. When Jung was talking about individuation, he was talking about taking the self as something that's primarily unconscious and make it something that's primarily conscious, and making it something that's unaligned to making it something aligned with the divine. So, how does Jungian individuation work? In four and a half minutes or maybe three minutes, instead of reading 25 books. Here's how it works.
- 8.86** In the Jungian system, you're divided into a series of opposites. Remember, I talked about the shadow, and I talked about the anima as the soul. Those are opposites. I've got my ego and I've got my shadow. That's an opposite. I've got my self and I've got my soul. Self is male, soul is female. That's the opposite. You have these series of opposites, these pairs of oppositions. You also have them in your personality.
- 8.87** I didn't talk about Jung's model of personality because that's more for a personality class, but you've heard it because you've heard of the Myers-Briggs scale. You've heard about introversion and extroversion. You've heard about sensing, thinking, feeling, and intuition. Have you heard those? Those are the classic. Those are Myers-Briggs. When Jung was talking about personality, he wasn't talking about those things like traits, even though we talk, yeah, I'm a sensing person, that we talk about as a trait.

- 8.88** What Jung was saying is, that's your way of relating to the world. A sensing person deals with the world as it is. You're dealing with the material world. A sensing, a feeling person is dealing with the world through emotions. They're dealing with the emotional material of the world, the feelings of the world. An intellect is dealing with thoughts. They're dealing with the thinking of the world. And an intuitive is dealing with patterns or resonance or vibrations of the world. So they're dealing, that's just how they deal with the world. It's not a personality trait in Jung's model. It's more how you deal with the world.
- 8.89** It's Earth, air, fire, and water. Sensing is Earth, feeling is water, thinking is fire, and intuition is air or ether, which we got rid of ether, but I still like to think it exists. Somebody like me, I'm very intuitive. I like to do things with vibe. People, they go, they don't believe me. I'm like, no, no, no. This is how I run my life. I just do vibes. I'm here because I have vibes. I like the people that work these cameras. I like them, vibes. That's intuition. What do I need to grow? What's the opposite? Well, I need sensation. I need to work. I need physical. I need to ground myself. I need physical.
- 8.90** In the first part of the Jungian system, it's balancing that part of yourself out. If you're too intuitive, add some Earth to it. Like Nietzsche said, the best thing for people that were thinkers is like chopping wood. There's that old Buddhist thing, "Before enlightenment, chop wood, carry water. After enlightenment, chop wood, carry water." It's grounding yourself. If somebody is too emotional, work on thinking. If you're a thinker, I think a lot, too. I got over a lot of that because it stopped working. But if I think too much, you go to feelings. Because when you think your way through a relationship, you're guaranteed to screw it up.
- 8.91** I do it all the time. "Well, actually, honey, this is what's really going on." I'm like, no, that's not going to work. I got to feel my way through a relationship. I should go back. In the first, the basic part is moving your personality into wholeness by finding these opposite parts of yourself. You're always moving to wholeness. The shadow, my shadow, is going to be something that's more sensing, maybe something more feeling. That's doing that shadow work; it's going to integrate. I'm going to have a whole personality. I'm using all the elements of my personality.
- 8.92** Then once I've got my shadow work done, I've figured out the wholeness of my personality, I'm going to meet my soul. My soul is going to come as a woman. If you're a woman, it's going to come as a man, in Jungian theory. Who knows, maybe it comes as a giant bird. But I'm going to be introduced by my soul. My soul is going to come to me because I'm worthy of a soul. So your soul appears when you're worthy. You've done the work. And then the soul says, "Hey, let me show you some stuff. I'm going to bring you deeper into the world," your unconscious world.
- 8.93** And then you start dealing with the unconscious world, and the goal of that is reaching the center of the collective unconscious, which is the godhead or the Self, with a capital S, often represented as a wise old man like Yoda, as a labyrinth, like a maze, like

Chartres. I don't know if it's there. One of those cathedrals has a classic maze. A labyrinth, like where the Minotaur is. That path to the self can be thought of as a labyrinth or a maze going inward. What you're doing then is the process of development is changing your life. It's like, my center is my ego—I'm an ego-driven little thing— to my center is up here and I'm aligned with that center.

8.94 My center is God. My ego is a satellite of that, a microcosm of that macrocosm, and I'm connected with all these things. I've become a connected, balanced person. That's individuated. That means I'm fully an individual. I'm not living an unconscious life. I'm not just being pushed around by the currents of life. I've gone deep, I've worked through this stuff, and now I'm alive and agentic. So, the Jungian process of individuation is not a straight line. It's not a process of optimization. It's a process of discovery. If you I wanted to read about Jung's journey, basically, he sat in his house in Switzerland, had massive—what the heck? Go Jungian here.

8.95 He'd do what's called active imagination. This is a Jungian practice for sort of letting yourself just think and your unconscious come up, and you just play with your unconscious. Then he'd have visions, and he wrote these visions in this giant book called *The Red Book*, which is really big and filled with art and everything. It's amazing. He didn't publish it until after he died. I didn't read it when I was a kid because it wasn't available. The Jungians had it in secret, and now you can buy it. So Jung's journey is not a straight line. It's much more of a labyrinth. It's much more complex. It's much more like a hero's journey.

8.96 So we've talked a lot in this class about the self, and I thought, you start with the self, and then you focus on making it the best self you can. In the process of becoming the best self you can, you lose who you are and connect with something greater than yourself, and that's as good as it gets. I thought, well, how do I end this course? I thought of about 45 ways to end it, and none of them made any sense. But what kept coming back to me is this line from the Japanese Zen monk, Eihei Dogen. He is the person who brought Zen from China, where it was called Chan, into Japan, where we call it Zen.

8.97 One of his more well-known sayings is to study the dharma, to study the law, is to study the self. "To study the self is to lose the self, and to lose the self is to be one with the 10,000 things." I love that line. Essentially, the whole act of trying to understand our self is really a process of overcoming ourselves. We understand ourselves so we can lose ourselves. When we lose ourselves, we can connect with the world. When we're stuck living in our little ego, defending ourselves, trying to be a big deal, doing selfies, that's not self-transcendence, that's a little ego. But when we can grow beyond that, we can connect with something greater, and it's pretty awesome. I'm going to leave it there. Thank you.

8.98 Do you think in some particular cases, dreams or nightmares could be categorized as a mystical experience?

- 8.99** That's a question I've never had before. I'm going to answer yes, and now I'm going to think about that answer. I know in certain traditions, people work in what they call as dream time, or they do dream work. They will enter a dream state and have experiences. Now, we might call this lucid dreaming in the West, but I know, I have a Lakota friend who does this and enters dream time, and that can be like a mystical space where things can happen. I think there's something possible in there.
- 8.100** But I don't know if there's a difference between something like dream time, which they talk about, like I said, in the Native American traditions, you hear a lot of that in the aboriginal traditions in Australia and other places, versus a full dream. Now, my guess is there's dream yoga where people are doing this work in dreams, but they're not talking to me. So I imagine it can happen. I do think that dream world is a place to access ideas that can be powerful. Actually, Freud wrote *The Interpretation of Dreams* and said that was his greatest work in 1899. I think there's a history of that in psychology as well.
- 8.101** I apologize in advance for the heaviness of this question. What do you think the relationship between one's narrative self and hero journey and the culture that is either more communal or individualistic? Because my hypothesis is that a hero's journey, it thrives more in a more communal environment because a hero serves others. In a society that is more individualistic, while it's also losing its purpose to technology, another question from yesterday, it seems a little like doomed. Do you think there is a remedy that we as individuals could take on or take responsibility for in our society?
- 8.102** It's a great question. The question about the hero's journey being culturally bound, and I think what you're arguing is that, in a more collectivistic culture, so the story of the Buddha who's in, I don't know, it was in Nepal at the time or northern India, he goes through this experience. He is enlightened. He comes back with a message and he brings it to everybody, and he starts a tradition. When—I'm trying to think of the Western model of that. Well, Jesus went through a pretty heavy thing, and he brought back a tradition, too, and gave it to Mary and a couple of other people after his return. It is a similar story there, but then Christianity is very collectivistic as a Western organization and different than the Romans.
- 8.103** Then you get the story of Hercules, and he just kicks butt and comes back, and he's a legend. That's more individual like Harry Potter. He won the war, but he's just cool. I think that the hero's journey works, obviously in the West, because we talk about it all the time. But I think your point you're making about bringing a reward back to culture is going to be maybe harder in a more individualistic culture. What we're going to see is somebody that we admire more, like the hero is somebody we look up to.
- 8.104** Maybe we want to, have them be a role model or a vision for us as individuals, but not necessarily the bringing back care. I don't have an answer for you, other than I think that's a pretty interesting question, and I'd love to see someone look at that because I think you could look at it.

